The Negotiation of Significance: An Instrumental Case Study of Students' Struggle for Significance within an Alternative High School

by

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Curriculum Vitae

John Sheehan was born in Rockville Center, New York, on the 22nd of November in 1972. He attended Nassau Community College from 1990 to 1992, and graduated with an Associate of Arts degree in 1992. He attended SUNY Geneseo from 1992 to 1995 and graduated with a Bachelors of Science degree in Education in 1995. He attended Radford University from 1996 to 1999 and graduated with both a Master of Science degree in Psychology and an Educational Specialist degree in School Psychology in 1999. He was employed and received tenure as a school psychologist within a small city district for three years. During this time, he developed an alternative middle school, and attended SUNY Brockport. He graduated from SUNY Brockport in 2002 with a Certificate of Advanced Study in Educational Administration. He was appointed as the principal to the alternative programs in 2002; he has maintained this employment to date. He came to the University of Rochester in the Fall of 2005 and began his graduate studies at the Margaret Warner School of Education in Teaching and Curriculum. He received the University of Rochester/SUNY Brockport award. Throughout his career, he has continued to work toward closing the divide between the theoretical and the practical application of educational theory; in particular, his research interest within discourse analysis examines the lived experiences of students within schools under the direction of Professor Joanne Larson.

Abstract

This dissertation is built upon a robust theoretical framework based on critical thirdspace which was developed through an analysis of critical theory, postmodernism, post-structuralism, and phenomenological theory. The dissertation establishes a “hole” in the educational research pertaining to students who do not complete high school. Research has focused almost exclusively on the establishment of predictive factors that indicate which students are most likely to leave school without graduating. This research has led to an understanding of who is likely to leave school prior to graduating, but does not address how students negotiate the meaning of their lived experience within and outside of school, and the implications that these constructed/negotiated meanings have for one’s understanding of self, the world, and others. This study addresses this particular gap within research through a multifarious analysis (critical discourse analysis, narrative analysis, and grounded theory) of autobiographical narratives. This analysis provides an understanding of how seventeen participants, who were deemed “not likely” to graduate, via their placement within an alternative high school negotiated, assigned and constructed meaning of their lived experiences within both a traditional high school and an alternative high school and the implication these meanings had for their understanding of self, the world and others.

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I would like to first and foremost thank my mother, whose love, support, and gentle guidance throughout my life has taught me how to be gentle and thoughtful. She has been my greatest teacher. It is through her teaching that I have developed a love of learning, and she has taught me what it means to be critical through her actions. I would also thank my wife, who has been a tremendous support, coach, and friend throughout this process. Without her gentle guidance, love, and support, this work would not be possible. I also owe my two children Sophia and Phoebe a great gratitude for their understanding and patience that Daddy was not always able to be a part of their daily lives due to my work, as well as for their encouragement: "to finish."

In addition, I would extend a thank you to each student with whom I have worked within the context of this study, as well as within each of my professional roles. Within this study, the participants' openness pertaining to their lives and lived experiences has taught me much, and touched my heart. I am deeply appreciative of all that they have taught me. In conclusion, I thank anyone who reads this document: my hope is that by understanding a new perspective to an old problem, that your perceptions, thoughts, and ideas are altered, and in the process, that you are disoriented. Thank you for being open to disorientation.

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Preface

Have you ever had the experience of placing your socks in the dryer, and after the dry cycle is completed, there is this one stray sock that is sitting in the dryer to which you never find the mate? This everyday common phenomenon is a cultural norm that seems to live beyond rational explanation and is just expected. This lonely sock that sits at the bottom of the dryer or laundry basket and which never finds a mate is usually discarded at some point, or turned into a rag which prolongs its utility for awhile, until it is finally discarded. This "missing sock" phenomenon is analogous to students who do not complete high school within the United States of America: it is almost expected that there will always be those students who do not graduate, and this cultural norm is deeply embedded within the grammar of school (Tyack & Cuban, 2000). During the previous 50 years or so, within the field of educational research, there has been a focus on developing an understanding of the predictive factors that indicate which students are more or less likely to graduate from high school. This research has done little to ameliorate the situation. Year after year, and decade after decade, the operation of and practice of schools continues to turn over and over, much as the dryer drum, and year after year, after each cycle, the students, much as socks, are found to be mismatched to school, and they are discarded and/or leave school without graduating.

To arrive at different conclusions, one must ask different questions. This dissertation raises new question(s), with the intention of altering both the foregrounds and the horizons. It is in the changing of the foregrounds and the horizons that one's perception of what is seen and understood is changed (Merleau-Ponty, 2007). The foregrounds and horizons within the social sciences are the unstated, implicit, and

expected norms which frame what a culture perceives as reality and understands. The exploration of and examination of cultural assumptions and norms as well as their consequences grounds this study within a critical perspective. This dissertation transforms the foregrounds and horizons by changing the lens of analysis from identifying stable and predictive factors to developing an understanding of how students' negotiated meaning of self, the world, and others within an alternative high school in Western New York and how these negotiations led students to transform themselves from being unlikely to graduate to graduating from high school. The focus on the student negotiated meanings moves the analysis beyond a critical analysis of the lifeless and static categories of race, class, and gender, to an understanding of how youth construct and ascribe meaning to their experiences. As Merleau-Ponty noted: "I understand the world, because for me there are things near and far, foregrounds, and horizons, and because of this, it forms a picture and acquires significance before me, and this finally is because I am situated in it, and it understands me (2007, p. 474). This study provides an understanding of how students situate themselves within the world, and how this placement of self in relationship to others allows for how others understand the participants.

To change the perception of research, I will use the following three questions to frame this dissertation: a) How and in what ways did participants negotiate and construct meaning about self, others, and the world? b) How did these constructions and the meaning- making process situate the participants within and outside of school, and what implications does the students' negotiation process have for school? c) What in the

context of an alternative high school provided the context for students to renegotiate their understanding of self, others, and the world?

These questions move the focus of this study from a deficit model of thinking: identifying factors that inform us of which youth are most likely to drop out, to the development of a rich and deep understanding of how students make meaning of their experiences within and outside of school, and how youth mitigate, negotiate and construct meanings which led to their transcendence of failure. I will answer these questions through the use of a multifarious analytical framework that will answer the questions from different perspectives. This framework is grounded within what I refer to as a critical thirdspace framework.

This study is presented and organized in the following manner: Chapter 1 provides the ontological and epistemological beliefs that frame the study. This chapter is presented first so that a reader has the larger view of how the study is grounded. Chapter 2 provides a clear articulation of the problem, reviews the literature within this area of research and provides the reader with the answer to the "So what?" question of research. Chapter 3 builds on chapter 2 and answers the "so what?" question, focusing on the methodological approach that will be used within this study, as well providing the context of the study. Chapters 1, 2, and 3 comprise Part One of this dissertation, and provide a macro framework which is integral to the understanding of and the analysis in Chapters 4, 5, and 6.

Chapter 4 uses a grounded theory analysis to argue that multiple rejections from parents, teachers, and peers, situate participants within a struggle for social significance. The negotiation of significance theory provides a new understanding to how students

negotiated an understanding of self, the world, and others, and how a change in the metric of negotiation provides the context to change the horizons and foregrounds of the self. In Chapter 5, the analysis is focused on the development of the self. The analysis leads to the understanding of the development of self for three participants, as well as provides additional warrant for the findings within chapter 5. Chapter 6 provides a summary of the major findings of this dissertation, practical implications, and discusses how the participant's negotiation for significance parallels that of the formation of this dissertation.

On a personal note, I would like to extend a thank you to anyone who reads this dissertation. Thank you for allowing me to share with you what I have learned.

Chapter 1

Critical Thirdspace

Overview

As we experience the world around us, we are bound to this world, and in being bound, we construct, construe and extract meaning from the world, so our experiences not only frame the world but are framed by the perceived world, which leads us to ascribe meaning to our experiences. It is through our experiences that we are capable of developing both a shrinking and expanding world. The constructed world is real to each individual; thus it forms one's sense of reality. Subsequently, the constructed world becomes one's reference point to evaluate truth and knowledge, as well as to evaluate experiences and assess the outcomes of actions taken or not taken. It is in the formation of our reference points that one's sense of morality is rooted, and as such, judgments are grounded within one's conceptions of the world, and conceptions of the world are grounded within one's morality and judgment. Thus, when casting a judgment: in particular, a moral judgment, it is always against a foreground of a constructed norm; thus one's conception of the world, in the moment of judgment, is both foregrounded and present. This is akin to a shadow being cast from a tree. What remains unseen in the shadow is the object which is illuminated, thus the norms that form the basis of judgment stay hidden in describing one's shadows. In describing one's shadow, the shadow is assumed to be the North of a compass, but this North only makes sense in relationship to a South, East and West, which are left unstated. Our construction of reality is limited by these two factors. We speak of shadows as objects, and we are limited to speaking of concepts in relation to other concepts.

The construction of a world begins at the age when a child understands that she is separate from the objects in the world and that she does and can affect change on objects, which includes people. As we progress within life, we continue to develop and refine our ontological and epistemological truths. In many ways, this chapter is a symbol of my own ontological and epistemological truths. As these truths are constructed by me and through my interaction with the world, they reflect how the world has shaped me in its image, and how I have shaped the world within mine. As one begins to describe one's ontological and epistemological claims, one comes to realize that human concepts and constructs rely on and refer to other concepts and constructs for their meaning and significance; thus one's description is always incomplete and partial, as what is signified is done so in relation to something else, which is signified by something else, therefore meaning and knowledge are intertwined. As Nietzsche (1882/2008) noted: "We operate only with things which do not exist, with lines, surfaces, bodies, atoms, divisible times, divisible spaces- how can explanation ever be possible when we first make everything a conception, our conception?" (p. 97). Explanations are only possible when one holds that explanations are impartial and incomplete, as what we explain may not exist except within the space of mind, and the space of social expression. In bounding these experiences with words, we form a description and create a construct, but in doing so, we lose the aesthetic experience- the lived experience. "Any attempt to put such sensations into words would run the risk of destroying the response. This sentiment, however, is also commonly accompanied by a need or desire to communicate that feeling, to share it with others." (de bolla, 2003, p. 60). Soja viewed the need to share our experience as essential: "To be human is not only to create distances, but to attempt to cross them, to

transform primal distance through intentionality, emotion, involvement, attachment. . . the distance is meaningless without its negation: the creation of meaning through relations with the world (1989, p. 133). In sharing our experiences and concepts, we mitigate the primacy of experiences with words and with others, so as to share ourselves and meaning. “Meaning is truthful;” and inversely, “Truthfulness is nothing more than meaning;” and finally, “Truthfulness has but one constant characteristic: it means, it has the sense of a meaning” (Kristeva, as cited in de Certeau, 1988, p. 236). Our shadows and conceptions are as true as they are meaningful to us.

One of the issues bound to this dialectic relationship between “experiencing” and sharing one’s experience is, as Nietzsche (2003) noted, that language cannot get over its awkwardness. This leads to the conclusion that

> Even in the midst of the most remarkable experiences we still do the same; we fabricate the greater part of the experience and can hardly be made to contemplate any event, except as ‘inventors’ thereof. All this goes to prove that from our fundamental nature and from remote ages we have been- accustomed to lying. Or, to express it more politely and hypocritically, in short more pleasantly-one is more of an artist than one is aware of. (Nietzsche, 2003, p. 48)

The question that seems to arise is with what material and in what medium do we create our world? In reworking Marx’s famous dictum, Soja (1989) noted that: “We make our own history and geography, but not just as we please; we do not make them under circumstances chosen by ourselves, but under circumstances directly encountered, given, and transmitted from the historical geographies produced in the past” (p.129). As such, we are not “free” artists, or social actors, such as was conceptualized by Giddens: “We

are, not what we are, but what we make of ourselves" (1991, p. 75). We are more so, as Rousseau (2005) conceptualized when describing the human condition: "man is born free; and everywhere he is in chains" (p. 5). It is in the construction of meaning that one feels and struggles with the dynamic tension between the need to justify one's chains and within the same explanation, shed these very same chains. The struggle is not a matter of opposing forces competing; it is more a matter of fine lines of gradation between trading one's individual freedom for the freedoms offered as part of membership within a community. As noted by Soja (1989) & Rousseau (2005), this choice of membership is often made for an individual within a historical and political realm, without ever actually gaining one's consent. It is assumed.

With the introduction to this chapter, I have established two of my ontological positions: first, that as humans, we experience the world, and in experiencing the world, we are compelled by the experience to share this experience, and in sharing the experience, we share both the experience and ourselves with others. As Mauss (1990) noted, "to accept something from somebody is to accept some part of his spiritual essence, of his soul" (p. 12). In sharing experiences and accepting one's essence, we are able to arrive at a new understanding that was in neither of us from the outset of the conversation. As Merleau-Ponty noted:

> In the experience of dialogue, there is constituted between the other person and myself a common ground; my thought and his are inter-woven into a single fabric, my words and those of my interlocutor are called forth by the state of the discussion, and they are inserted into a shared operation of which neither of us is the creator. We have here a dual being, where the other is for me no longer a mere

> bit of behavior in my transcendental field, nor I in his; we are collaborators for each other in consummate reciprocity Our perspectives merge into each other, and we co-exist through a common world. (2002, p. 413)

The discourse we use relies primarily on relational concepts in which one concept is referred to and understood partially through another concept, but neither concept is fully understood onto itself (Lakoff & Johnson, 2003). The "truths" and "meanings" we create are done so within a world that has been historically created and formed; thus one's conceptions are bounded not only by his/her experiences, but also within a particular historical, social, cultural, and political context. As Nietzsche (2005) demonstrated, our values and morality are also dialectical as opposed to being derived within the object: "It might even be possible that what constitutes the value of those good and respected things, consists precisely in their being insidiously related, knotted, and crocheted to these evil and apparently opposed things- perhaps even in being essentially identical with them" (p. 7).

It is an a priori position that I hold that truths and meaning are bounded both by history and the social structures one lives within. As such, I initially grounded my framework within a critical tradition, and will use the critical lens to explore the macro-structuring of society. In doing so, I will explore the concepts of class power, hegemony power, and praxis. The concepts of praxis and power will move my lens from the macro to micro level of individuals. The micro-level of my theoretical framework is influenced by postmodern, poststructural, and phenomenological paradigms. In the final section, I will bend both the macro and micro together by drawing from the work of Soja (1989 and 1996) and Lefebvre (1991) and their conceptualizations of a thirdspace, and that within

such space, binary oppositions of "either/or" thinking can be conceptualized as "and/both" and a new radical openness can be created. This radical open space is embedded within both philosophical thought (Arendt, 2006; de Certeau, 1998; Nietzsche 1969 & 2005) as well as within educational philosophy and theory (Dewey, 1954; Freire 2005). This space is the space of possibilities, hope, and conjoint experiences. I argue that the creation of a thirdspace is a radical form of praxis. Praxis, which is the belief that the world can be changed by human action, "has always been the centerpiece of critical social theory whatever way its particularized source and emphasis" (Soja, 1989, p. 14). In the next section, I will elucidate the foundational basis of my critical perspective. Within the study, I will use this framework to understand the multiple perceptions of students, and the multiple means that students use to construct and make meaning of their experiences within both a traditional and alternative high school, as well as of their lives outside of school. I will also argue that leaving school without graduating for participants within this dissertation is constructed and understood to be a death and the final social rejection in a series of multiple rejections, and that the alternative high school provided a critical thirdspace of hope which provided the participants within this study with the ability to renegotiate failure and insignificance in their relationship to self, others, and the world. This renegotiation creates both a space of hope in which the students' relationship to self, others, and the world are renegotiated, and the formation of a new metric of significance.

Critical Perspective

As Carspecken (1996) noted, critical researchers are concerned with social inequalities, social change, social structures, power, culture, human agency, and how

these concepts interact to structure and define a world that can be beyond reproach. As a critical researcher, one of the basic ideas is not only to approach this world, but to approach it in a way that challenges, fights and struggles against the hegemony of the ruling and predominant class within a society. There exist several key concepts within a critical framework that influence schools, more precisely the operation and function of public education within the United States, which in turn, shape the experiences and educational opportunities provided to and for school-aged children. They are social class, power, the distribution of wealth, hegemony, and human agency. As Marx noted in *Capital*:

> As capital accumulates, the lot of the labourer, be his payment high or low, must grow worse. . . It makes an accumulation of misery a necessary condition, corresponding with the accumulation of capital. Accumulation of wealth at one pole is, therefore, at the same time accumulation of misery, agony of toil, slavery, ignorance, brutality, and mental degradation at the opposite pole, i.e., on the side of the class that produces its own product in the form of capital. (1906, p. 799)

The accumulation of wealth is based on the internal logic of capitalism. The outcomes of the capitalist are to accumulate and amass wealth. As such, the capitalist takes over the labor process via organization, and by owning and operating the means of production. In organizing the labor process, at least two things happen: the laborer is separated from her labor, and in selling her labor, she also sells her labor potential, which the capitalist uses to generate a profit. Profit is nothing more than surplus labor, which is sold. The selling of surplus labor is impossible without a metric to measure and assess an exchange value; thus money is established both as the metric, and as a form of capital.

Money as a means of capital has the ability to generate profits from its circulation. In the capitalistic system, a laborer has an inverse relationship to her labor: as she becomes more proficient in the production of her labor, the product of her labor decreases, while the profits for the capitalist increase. This of course does not speak to the moral degradation that is created when one is separated from her labor. This system of economic exchange begins to and eventually establishes a social class structure within society.

As McLaren and Farahmandpur (2005) noted, we are currently living in a historical period of Neoliberalism/global capitalism. These terms refer to the structuring of the social world through an ideology which supports unregulated, unfettered corporate domination of society, the suppression of anti-market forces, the elimination of all social services and limitless concessions to transnational corporations, with the terminal goal of comodifying all public space, so as to be governed by the private interests of the wealthiest class (McLaren & Farahmandpur, 2005, p. 5). The effects of these policies are shocking and disturbing. As Harvey (2006) indicated:

> the net worth of the 358 richest people in the world was then found to be ‘equal to the combined income of the poorest 45 percent of the world’s population- 2.3 billion people.’ The world’s 200 richest people ‘more than doubled their net worth in the four years to 1998, to more than $1 trillion,’ so that ‘the assets of the world’s top three billionaires were more than the combined GNP of all least developed countries and their 600 million people. (p. xi)

McLaren (2006) also noted that “the combined assets of the three richest people in the world exceed the combined GDP of the 48 poorest nations’ and the combined assets of

the 225 richest people are roughly equal to the annual incomes of the poorest 47 percent of the world's population" (p. 52). Harvey (2005) noted that: "the net worth of Bill Gates in 1995 was greater than the net worth of the poorest 40 percent of Americans (106 million people) (p. 43). McLaren and Farahmandpur (2005) indicated that "the cost of providing basic education and health care, as well as adequate food, and safe water for the entire population of the earth is estimated to be $40 million dollars, (less than the net worth of Bill Gates)" (p. 27). All the while, "a billion or so people are struggling to survive on less than a dollar a day, and 2 billion on two dollars a day, while the rich are piling up fortunes across the globe at an astonishing rate" (Harvey, 2006, p. xii). In the United States, "the richest tenth of households in the United States own 83% of the country's financial assets, whereas the poorest four fifth owns only 8% (McLaren & Farahmandpur, 2005, p. 27). It is evident from the above data that Marx's understanding of the overall effects of capitalism was not an abstract theoretical understanding of some distant possible future state, but is instead a reality that has been lived and enacted within the current context of the world. The question which arises is what, if anything, should be done about this social structure, and these outcomes?

The spreading of wealth to the extremes of the poles impacts public education, as schools are embedded within the networks of their communities and are connected to the world at large. For example, within New York State, the funding of schools is primarily based on a levy which school districts collect based upon property values within the given community; thus school districts that have the highest property value are able to have both lower tax rates, and increased capital to spend within their district. The question arises: what effect does the level of funding for schools have on graduation

rates, and how does a district's wealth impact the experiences of students within the school? This former question will be addressed within Chapter 2, while the latter question is a macro-level question which is embedded within the questions that frame this study.

A second way that education is impacted by the logic of capitalism is that an axiom of capitalism is that "all the best is always scant and rare for mass in anything cheapens it" (Gracian, 1647/2008, p. 9). For education to have value, it would need to be scant. Within the United States, attendance is compulsory; thus there are two ways to raise the value of education: a) develop a system of education that produces systematically different outcomes for different groups of people, and/or b) develop a system which ensures that all do not graduate. This leads to the question: are there systematically different outcomes for different groups of individuals within the United States, and within this study in New York State? This question will be addressed in Chapter 2.

An argument framed to address the sheer magnitude of these outcomes fails to address the underlying degradation of humans who are forced to live in this manner. As Habermas (1998) noted, "no one is free as long as the freedom of one person must be purchased with another's oppression" (p. 418). And while contemplating freedom is akin to contemplating a "squared circle" (Arendt, 2006, p. 142; De Spinoza, 2008, p. 19), and can be a hopeless enterprise, one element that is embedded within the concept of freedom is implied within McLaren and Farahmandpur's concept of socialist dreaming:

> [it] is not about the liberation of the individual from the social but is about a collective dreaming through the social in the service of ensuring that workers are

> able to create a new world on their own terms, and in their own voice without seeking permission to narrate their own future. (2005, p. 45)

Thus a critical perspective needs its critique not only to focus on the consequences and outcomes, but also on the structures: social and political ideologies that not only maintain these outcomes, but actively resist transformation in favor of the status quo (Darder, 2002). We need more than reflection; we need "reflection with action or praxis" (Freire, 2005, p. 125). Praxis is an idea that has been embedded in philosophical thought for centuries. As Aristotle noted: "it is not enough to know of virtue then, but we must endeavor to possess it and to use it, or to take any steps that make us good" (1893/2004, p. 222). In critical reflection, there is a necessity to reflect on and engage with predominant ideologies of the ruling class, so as to take action at the root cause of the structures and ideological practices which maintain and reinforce hegemonic practices. Ideologies are hegemonic when they establish practices that are intended to maintain a social order that inflicts untold violence within a society, as a means to maintain the ruling class' power (Gramsci, 1971). As Lefebvre (1991) indicated,

> Hegemony is exercised over a society as a whole, culture and knowledge included, and generally via human mediation: policies, political leaders, parties, and also a good many intellectuals and experts. The ruling class seeks to maintain its hegemony by all available means, and knowledge is one such means. (p. 10)

In the next section, I will explore three hegemonic concepts: objective and rational thinking as the single means to understand truths, White-heterosexual maleness as the norm, and individualism. The exploration of each of these hegemonic concepts allows for the development of an understanding of how individuals either by choice, or by

circumstance, who do not accept or cannot abide by the cultural norms, are established by these truths and are positioned as a deviance from the perspective of those who stand inside these truths. The act of standing outside these truths provides the ability for those within the truths to mark those outside of these truths as deviant, and in doing so, confirm themselves as normal. This marking allows for the objectification of the person outside of these truths, and also reconfirms those who engage in the marking, as being situated inside these truths.

The marking of others as "others" within this dissertation is constructed by each of the participants as a "rejection," typically one in a series of ongoing rejections through her lifespan; this may lead to the construction of the self as a failure, and as a consequence, to losing the ability to construct the world for herself. Instead these individuals are situated as "the others" and their "otherness" increases the likelihood of increased rejection, which leads to increased isolation. Thus, participants within this dissertation are left situated within a world of rejection and failure which work together to reinforce each other, and which increases their understanding of themselves as isolated and alone, and of the world as hostile and punishing. This dissertation also provides insight into the impact of a father's acceptance or rejection of his child's being, the impact that the father and child's negotiation has, and how this relationship affects the child's negotiation of self, others and the world. Research has paid scant attention to this relationship, and instead focuses attachment theory research on the relationship between the mother and child. The dissertation in questioning of the knowledge of attachment theory, struggles against the hegemony of "knowledge" that a child's mother is the single

significant figure of attachment, and provides insight into the significant effect of a father's rejection and abandonment.

Hegemony

Plato concluded that within the living world, our senses could be easily fooled and thus the world could be misrepresented. He held that true and certain knowledge could only come from the world of abstraction (Eisner, 1985). Knowledge was conceived as being outside of our lived experience, and one needs to discover knowledge: one does not make knowledge (Eisner, 1985). This conceptualization of the world has led to a false dichotomy between lived knowledge and institutionalized knowledge. This partitioning of knowledge provided the context for knowledge to be assessed different values and thus knowledge was converted into capital- "cultural capital" (Bourdieu, 2005). Cultural capital, similar to other forms of capital, can be bought, stored, and traded for a variety of services. This dichotomy has provided the context for the separation of mental work from physical work, and for differentiated values (prices) to be ascribed to one's labor. As Gramsci (1971) noted, "The intellectual's error consists in believing that one can know without understanding and even more without feeling and being impassioned, (not only for knowledge in itself but also for the object of knowledge" (p. 418). A world of scientific reasoning is oppressive in two ways. First it invalidates the majority of people's experiences, and their knowledge is cast as folk knowledge, and secondly it limits and sets a market price on certain "ways of knowing." As knowledge plays a critical role in how an individual can conceptualize, construct and interpret the world (Harvey, 2000), limiting and restricting knowledge allows for a limited conceptualization and interpretation of the world.

The second example of hegemony is the establishment of White, middle class, heterosexual males as the norm to be measured against; thus all who are not White, heterosexual, male, and middle class are othered. “Where Whiteness operates, the White bourgeois appropriates the right to speak on behalf of everyone who is nonwhite, while denying voice to these others in the name of civilized” (McLaren & Munoz, 2005, p. 196). Whiteness also positioned the other as highly visible, as she or he is not White, so the others stand in direct contrast to that of Whiteness (McLaren, Leonardo, & Allen, 2005). Another effect of centering-Whiteness is that, as Bell (2004) indicated, “The interest of Blacks in achieving racial equality will be accommodated only when that interest converges with the interests of Whites in policy-making decisions. This convergence is far more important for gaining relief than the degree of harm suffered by blacks or the character of proof offered to prove that harm. . . [and only so far so as not to be disturbed, or to disrupt] the superior societal status of Whites” (p. 69). In being othered, one is moved away from the center, and in a Foucauldian (1977) sense, being non-White and male subjects one’s physical body to the endless exam, which continues to mark the non-White as the “other.”

The final example of hegemony is a return to individualism, and away from a collective responsibility, which has been a fundamental achievement of sociological thought (Bourdieu, 1989 & 1998). This return to individualism makes it “possible to ‘blame the victim’, who is entirely responsible for his or her own misfortune, and to preach the gospel of self-help, all of this being justified by the endlessly repeated need to reduce costs for companies” (Bourdieu, 1998, p. 7).

This position of individualism is evident in the work of Giddens (1991) who indicated that:

> taking charge of one's life involves risk, because it means confronting a diversity of open possibilities. The individual must be prepared to make a more or less complete break with the past, if necessary, and to contemplate novel courses of action. (p. 73)

The plurality of choices is in direct contrast to the juggernaut of free-markets with its deregulation, privatization, downsizing of government, social welfare, and the endless outsourcing and dismantling of organized labor (Harvey, 2000). Within this context, the social world is ideologically framed as a shopping mall with an endless selection of choices to fit all preferences, while ignoring the fact that most of the world's population cannot get to the mall, and even those who do lack the capital to purchase the most basic of services - clean water, food, and shelter. As schools are situated and interwoven within the community in which they are located, just as in society, in the community there is great disparity with regard to the services provided to and for students: the same situation is duplicated within schools (Kozol, 1991). To this end, attendance is compulsory, but education is not.

There is a plethora of examples of hegemony. I have chosen to highlight the above for two primary reasons: first, to move the concept of hegemony from an abstraction to a concrete example; and second, to highlight the following: a) to elucidate how knowledge and power are related; b) to demonstrate how, within the analysis of class power, that a part of the analysis must include an analysis of the interrelationship

between class, gender, and race with a particular sensitivity to not privileging class over race, or gender; and c) to refute the myth of individuality, which justifies laying the blame of social failure and inequality on the victim of these injustices. It is important to remind oneself that an additional form of hegemony is the ability of the ruling class to divide the subordinate groups along lines of those groups' particular interests. An essential part of my critical lens is not only to be cognizant of this strategy but to actively engage this ideology and deconstruct it by working toward a more unified political left. One example of this struggle against the myth of individuality is the shift of focus from individual predictive stable factors, which are often "located" within the child, to a focus on the interactive negotiation between the participants, others, and the world.

Power

The final element of my critical approach is to explore the concept of power, and in particular, what is power, and how does it work and/or circulate within the society? Power has been conceptualized along a continuum: at one end, individuals are considered to be rational decision makers who use their power to either get what they want, avoid what they do not want, and/or convince and compel others to engage in or not to engage in a set of behaviors for certain outcomes which are beneficial to those who compel or convince. The other side of this continuum views power as an outcome of social forces which marks, creates and shapes individuals to a certain end, which is not theorized to be in any one person's particular interest but the interest of society as a whole. I will first outline the concept of power that Dowding (1996) suggested, and as Barry (2002) extended Dowding's concept of power, I will draw from Barry to extend this conceptualization of power. After this discussion, I will then draw on the work of

Foucault (1977), de Certeau (1988) and Lefebvre (1991) to outline the other end of the continuum. In exploring the continuum of power, two questions will arise: what is the nature of the relationship between power and knowledge, and what is the relationship between human agency and power?

Dowding (1996) defined power as: a) power to, and b) power over. Power to is defined as the power for a person to do something, and power over is defined as the power to influence another individual or group to do something that she or they would not otherwise do (Dowding, 1996, p. 4). Dowding, 1996, then defined two types of power: outcome power and social power. Outcome power is "the ability of an actor to bring about or to help bring about outcomes, [and social power is] the ability of an actor to deliberately change the incentive structure of another actor or actors to bring about or help bring about outcomes." (Dowding, 1996, p. 5) Dowding's concept of power is centered around the notion that individual actors have power and that they are able to get what they want, either by acting themselves to obtain the outcome, or by being able to structure the context and/or environment, so as to provide the appearance to others that it is within their best interest to act, or engage in a set of behaviors. Dowding (1996) noted, just getting what you want is not an indication of power: sometimes you get what you want, even when you do not try. Dowding defined this as "systematic luck" (1996, p. 52). Dowding's notion of systematic luck appears to be related to his concept of the "blame fallacy" (1996, p. 16). The blame fallacy is the notion that just because you did not get what you want does not mean that there is someone to blame. It appears that actors can get what they want by not trying, and can also get what they do not want by trying. These two concepts of systematic luck and the blame fallacy appear to be theoretical moves to

account for a theory which cannot wholly explain why certain outcomes occur or do not occur regardless of the relationship between power and outcomes. It seems that Dowding's concept that "every powerful actor is powerful because of the resources they bring to a bargain with other actors" (1996, p. 53), cannot or does not account for some sets of outcomes that are not affected by their personal power. The resources of power are: knowledge, "legitimate authority, unconditional incentives to affect the interests of others, and conditional incentives to affect the interests of others" (Dowding, 1996, p. 54).

Barry (2002) extended Dowding's concept of power by defining power as the "ability to bring about desired states of the world by actively overcoming resistance" (p. 161). Barry (2002) stated that Dowding's concept of power is just one type of power: "influence." Influence is the ability to influence others' outcomes, because they hold that an actor can, or will make them worse off if they were not able to make a certain choice. Barry (2002) attempted to broaden the concept of power, and to move the concept of power beyond the confines of either getting what you want or not getting what you want.

Thus far, I have highlighted one end of the continuum: that which covers Dowding's (1996) and Barry's (2002) concepts of power. I will now explore the other end of the power continuum, by drawing on the work of Lefebvre (1991), Foucault (1977) and de Certeau (1988). In particular, I will focus on three aspects: a) human agency, b) the concept that people "know" what they want, and c) the relationship between power and knowledge.

Both Dowding (1996) and Barry (2002) placed the focus of their analysis of power onto individual actors. This could be considered a micro-analysis of power. Their

analysis of power appears to rest on the epistemological foundations of enlightenment thinking: particularly the notion that as humans, we are rational beings that make use of or implore rational thought and reason to understand the world around us. As Foucault (1977) noted:

> We are much less Greeks than we believe. We are neither in the amphitheatre, nor on the stage, but in the panoptic machine, invested by its effects of power, which we bring to ourselves since we are part of its mechanism. (p. 217)

As opposed to both Dowding's (1996) and Barry's (2002) notion: that we are actors on a stage attempting to get what we want, Foucault (1977) suggested that we are in essence, part of the stage itself (panoptic machine), and in being part of the machine, we give up our sense of liberty and freedom, and are interested in maintaining a system that is intended to prescribe to us what it is we want, and/or need. This is a sharp contrast in human nature, as opposed to Dowding (1996) and Barry (2002), who assumed that we are free to make choices about what we desire and what we do not desire, and we are in a society or a marketplace of exchanges to get what we desire, Foucault (1977) held that we are not free, and in fact we are most interested in recreating the machine that binds us. Through the disciplining of the body, we recreate the machine that binds us.

Foucault's (1977) notion was that the act of discipline has become "less immediately a physical kind, a certain discretion in the art of inflicting pain, a combination of more subtle, more subdued suffering, deprived of visual display" (p. 8). The two aims of discipline are a) to act in depth on the heart, the thoughts, the will, the inclinations (Foucault, 1977, p. 16), and b) it provides the means to bend individuals' behavior to a terminal state. de Certeau (1998) extended the art of discipline to our

bodies: “every power including the power of law is written first of all on the backs of its subjects. . . to tattoo him in order to make him demonstrate the rule, to produce a ‘copy’ that makes the norm legible (pp. 140-141). For de Certeau (1998), our bodies are the pallet on which society inscribes its norms. This is in contrast to Dowding (1996) and Barry (2002) who held that humans are independent actors, which implicitly suggests that they are active in shaping and creating their world, whereas Foucault (1977) and de Certeau (1998) held that the function of power is to discipline bodies and souls into becoming docile. As we are part of the panoptic machine, our souls, wills, and inclinations become docile, and in doing so, they reinforce the machine. Within the context of public education, the outcomes of schools shift ever so slightly away from the stated outcomes: such as the cultivation of reflective thinking, and the development of an understanding of the relationship between oneself and the world; to a curriculum whose outcomes are a slow dulling of the mind to become unreflective, and to be a mere container of facts and bits of unrelated truths as opposed to cultivating the ability to pose questions and seek the answers to those questions (Dewey, 1910/2005; Freire, 2005). Dullness of the mind leads to the unquestioning acceptance of the machine, and the apparatus which reinforces it.

The third and final difference of power revolves around that of the relationship between knowledge and power. Dowding (1996) held that knowledge is a resource which actors bring to the bargain. For Dowding, there existed a clear separation between knowledge and power, whereas for Foucault (1977), there was no separation between power and knowledge.

> We should admit rather that power produces knowledge (and not simply by encouraging it because it serves power or by applying it because it is useful); that power and knowledge directly imply one another; that there is no power relation without the correlative constitution of a field of knowledge, nor any knowledge that does not presuppose and constitute at the same time power relations. (p. 27)

One manner in which power produces is as Lefebvre (1991) noted:

> between the signified, and the sign there is a mesmerizing difference, a deceptive gap: the shift from one to the other seems simple enough, and it is easy for someone who has the words to feel that they possess the things those words refer to. And indeed, they do possess them up to a certain point-a terrible point. As a vain yet also effective trace, the sign has a power of destruction because it has the power of abstraction-and thus also the power to construct a new world different from nature's initial one. Herein lies the secret of Logos as foundation of all power and all authority. (p. 135)

Language is knowledge and knowledge is language.

As opposed to Dowding (1996), who held that power is used to get things, Foucault (1995) held that power produces: "In fact, power produces, it produces reality; it produces domains of objects, and rituals of truth." (p. 194). The concept of power for Foucault is that it is everywhere and nowhere, whereas in Dowding's (1996) and Barry's (2002) concept of power, it would be very logical to speak of empowering individuals, and to explore the notion of actors with more or less power. Foucault held that power creates knowledge and reality, whereas Dowding (1996) and Barry (2002) held that power is the ability to serve one's own individual will.

As Nietzsche (1882/2008) noted, “Man has been reared by his errors” (p. 98). In conceptualizing power along a continuum: from free actors to actors that are determined and branded by society, the paradox of power comes to light. We can’t account for all outcomes by power, nor can we account for all outcomes by conceptualizing a completely socially determined world, since in doing so, the notion of praxis would be nonsensical. The root of the paradox lies in the very manner in which power operates, “power never allows itself to be confined within a single logic. Power has only strategies- and their complexity is in proportion to power’s resources (Lefebvre, 1991, p.162). Power is thus not an entity that is signified within a word, or bounded and held within a unitary code; it is, in effect, a concept that lives well outside the signified and signifier relationship. We can bear witness to its effects, and struggle to define its strategies, and as we struggle to find the strategies, we often mistake strategies for power. Thus the paradox of power assists power to be elusive and the paradox serves to be yet another strategy of power. Power (within the dissertation) is conceptualized as residing within three areas: within the individual, within the space between individuals and the world, and within the world itself. Participants initially negotiated relationships using their power to reconfirm their own rejection by rejecting those whom had rejected them. Within the alternative high school, they began to use their power to influence the space between themselves, others, and the world. As will be argued in Chapters 5 and 6, the ongoing rejection of the self situates these students as “dead” to others and it is through their renegotiation of themselves, others and the world that they come to negotiate acceptance and in the process, they renegotiate or situate themselves from “dead” (insignificant) to alive (significant).

Thirdspace

In this chapter, I will expand my critical lens to include the concept of thirdspace, as developed by Soja (1996) and Lefebvre (1991). I will first draw on Lefebvre's work, and then draw upon Soja's work, as he built his conceptualization of thirdspace from that of Lefebvre. I will then demonstrate how the conceptualization of thirdspace is prevalent in both philosophical thought, and within educational philosophy.

Lefebvre (1991) conceptualized space in three ways: the physical space of nature, the mental space of the representation of space- that of formal abstraction, and the social space- it is a place of both social action, thought, control, domination, but it also eludes each of these as it is a space of production (Lefebvre, 1991). The social space is the space of the lived: from this lived space the conceived is derived, and thus the representation of space. The representation of space is a mixture of understanding and knowledge, whereas the representational space is the space that is directly lived. Lefebvre (1991) seemed to be most concerned with the relationship between representational space and the representation of space. Within this relationship, he appeared to be concerned with knowledge claims about space: "Knowledge falls into a trap when it makes representations of space the basis for the study of 'life,' for in doing so, it reduces lived experience. The object of knowledge is, precisely the fragmented, and uncertain connection between elaborated representations of space on the one hand and representational spaces (along with their underpinnings) on the other; and this object implies and (explains) a subject- that subject in whom lived, perceived and conceived (known) come together within a spatial practice," (Lefebvre, 1991, p. 230). Lefebvre breaks the dichotomy between sensory experience and abstract thought, as both are one

and the same ways of knowing, and both are irreducible within an individual: thus privileging of the abstract over the lived is debunked.

Drawing from the work Lefebvre, Soja (1996) expanded the concept of 'other-than space' (critical thirding) in his development of a thirdspace (p. 61). The first space is the relative locations of things, activities, and evolving processes between humans, their constructions and nature (Soja, 1996, p. 77). The second space is the space of the symbolic, and of the interpretation of space and geography (Soja, 1996, p. 77). Thirdspace is not a critique of first and second space, but a space of possibilities. This thirding introduces a critical "other-than" choice that speaks and critiques through its otherness. It is critical for two reasons: a) it transforms either/or thinking to both/and thinking, and b) creates a radical openness by deconstructing and disorienting the logic of either/or thinking (Soja, 1996, p. 61). This other space outside of traditional thought opens a new world of possibilities: no longer is one confined to choosing from a false dichotomy, but one is also able to think in new ways-"thirding." This concept is evident in both Arendt's (2006), and Dewey's (1954) concept of democracy. Arendt conceived of democracy as lived between individuals, much the same as Dewey viewed it as a "conjoint experience" (1954, p. 87). This thirdspace is also evident in Nietzsche's account of a free spirit ". . . a spirit could bid farewell to every belief, to every wish for certainty, accustomed as it would be to support itself on slender cords and possibilities, and to dance even on the verge of abysses. Such a spirit would be the free spirit par excellence" (1882/2008, p. 182). It is my assertion that hope is a thirdspace phenomenon as it lies in between reflection and action, and praxis is the enactment of the thirdspace conception of hope. The aim of this study is not only to reflect, but to take action in the

form of providing a space for the voices of both students and their families so that their voices will inform and shape the future direction, policies, and practices of the alternative high school and school leaders and policy makers can have no choice but to listen to the effects of their decisions, and in listening, this will at least momentarily disrupt the machine.

Either/or thinking frequently is represented as a continuum- spatially as a line with two ends. Lines transverse space, and in doing so cut and divide space. Once established, a line becomes the metric with which one can be measured at, above, or below. At each end of the continuum stand opposing concepts, which establish a dynamic tension which pits one concept against another: thus one can either be for or against this or that concept. Moving along the continuum requires in a spatial sense, one to move closer and at the same time, further away from a concept. Concepts are established as competing entities, in which the good of each concept is established by the bad of the other. Thirdspace thinking allows for the continuum of either/or thinking to be bent until both ends meet and dissolve into each other, and a space of new possibilities is created. Linguistically, irony is a thirdspace phenomena as its meaning lies between what is said and what remains unsaid. It is this connection between the unsaid and said that provides irony in its meaning (Fiumara, 2001). When the continuum connects, ideas no longer compete against each other, nor rely on each other for meaning but instead are independent, and yet in their independence, they are connected in the sense that they are equally distant in relation to each other. The space created by bending the continuum is a space that mystics, philosophers, artists, and athletes experience and it extends beyond and lives outside the bounds of the structure of language; thus escaping human

expression. All that exists is the experience, and the meanings we come to ascribe to these experiences. Within the dissertation, I will establish a struggle for significance theory in which participants have experienced repeated rejections of the self, and through these experiences, they establish a metric of social negotiation of life (significance) and death (insignificance). The participants struggle against insignificance, which is represented in the act of leaving school without graduating, and within their experience of being rejected by others. They construct significance for themselves within an alternative high school by bending their metric of life and death together to experience a space of hope, where they are significant to self and others, and can begin to renegotiate self, others, and the world.

Connecting Critical Thirdspace to Public Education

In this chapter I have argued for the consideration of a radical openness, which is grounded in the concept of a thirdspace. Thirdspace is a space which is created when the constraints of binary thinking are broken by bending the ends of dichotomous thinking together. By bending the ends of the continuum together, each end loses its ability to locate its meaning within its opposing end. As concepts cease to be opposing forces, they create a new space: a space of experience, and hope. For participants, the opposing forces of success and failure within school were bent together within an alternative high school, which provided the students with the ability to renegotiate failure, rejection and death. This dissertation develops an understanding of the how these seventeen participants renegotiated themselves, others, and the world.

Chapter 2

Old School, New School: Same Old Problem

Introduction

This chapter is a review of the extensive literature that has been collected during the previous 50 years on students who have not completed high school. The chapter is framed by, interwoven and intrinsically connected to, both my theoretical lens and methodological approach, and as such, it is situated within this dissertation between the theoretical framework and methodological approach. Charmaz (2006) noted that the purpose of a literature review is to substantially engage with the body of literature, so as to demonstrate a significant grasp of the relevant work and, in doing so, not become so engrossed within the collective works of others that one's own work becomes constrained and constricted by the literature. This could result in the loss of one's creativity and limit one's ability to develop new insights, construct rich and robust theory, as well as, offer significant contributions to the field. New insights are of particular importance when one raises the notion of exploring old problems, and such is the case in the area of students who do not graduate from high school. The first questions that arise are: why study an old problem, and more importantly, what new insights can one's work bring to an old problem? These types of questions are frequently framed as the "So what?" questions of research. In a manner that is consistent with my critical thirdspace framework and methodical approach, I will argue that there exist numerous unexplored questions, such as: How do students negotiate their experience of failure and rejection within and outside of school?; and How is their negotiation of rejection and failure within school interwoven within systemic issues that are deeply embedded within the grammar of public education?

To establish both warrant for my claim that my questions are indeed new questions for an old problem, and to establish that this old problem is salient today, I will review the literature on students who do not graduate from high school. I will further argue that little or no research has been focused on students who are in the transitional space between: being not likely to graduate to being likely to graduate from high school with a traditional diploma. In the context of my study, this would result in a student earning a Regents diploma[1]. To this end, the proposed study is grounded within a particular "alternative high school" within the western region of the State of New York. I will begin by stating the nature of the problem, and then move to the rest of my argument.

Statement of Problem

On February 13, 2006, the Office of Communication for the New York state education department released a field memo in which it stated that "64% of students who started 9th grade in 2000 have graduated after four years, and 71% of students who started 9th grade in 2000 have graduated in five years" (University of the State of New York, 2006). Within the same field memo, State Commissioner Richard Mills stated, "This is a disturbing number" (University of the State of New York, 2006). Mills' response is quite revealing of the ideological practices of the State and of the Board of Regents. While I might agree with the Commissioner that the number is disturbing, I would strongly disagree with indexing students as numbers. What appears to elude the commissioner in his statement and throughout his written response is that the numbers of which he speaks

[1] A regents diploma is awarded to students within New York State that earn 22 credits (4 credits of English, 4 credit of Social Studies, 3 credits of Mathematics, 3 credits of Science, 2 credits of Physical Education, 1 credit of Art, 1 credit of Language other than English, .5 Health, and 3.5 elective credits, and earn a score 65 or higher of each of 5 Regents Exam (English, Algebra, Earth or Living Environment, US History and Global).

are living, breathing students who are not currently meeting the expectations for graduation. The memo calls for "higher achievement in high school in the future" (University of the State of New York, 2006). The commissioner's use of the phrase: "higher achievement in high school in the future" omits students; thus suggesting that higher achievement is through the organizational structures of school, as opposed to a focus on students and their learning. This focus on the structures, order, and operation of school leads to changes within the organizational structures of school, but may not affect students' learning. This study is grounded as a critical study as it includes the voices of the students that the commissioner excludes, and in doing so, includes the voices of those spoken about, but not heard, and it shifts the focus from the operational functions of school to a focus on students, their learning and their negotiation of self, others, and the world.

In a 2007 news release pertaining to high school graduation, Chancellor Robert Bennett (New York State Board of Regents) indicated that students who do not graduate will not be able to support a family or themselves, and as a state, we will be less competitive (University of the State of New York, 2007). Mills stated that the rate of graduation is unacceptably low, and that "we need to act urgently now" (University of the State of New York, 2007).

In reporting the data for the 2003 cohort class, Bennett indicated that "graduation rates have improved slightly overall, but they need to improve much faster" (University of the State of New York, 2008). Mills appeared to back away from his proclamation that he had made a year earlier to "act urgently now" by stating that "Blacks and Hispanic students showed a 5.5% point gain in the 2003 cohort when compared to those who

started in 2001." He further noted that "White students are improving, but not as fast-another indicator of a narrowing achievement gap" (University of the State of New York, 2008). He concluded that these results were indicators that persistence counts (University of the State of New York, 2008). In the span of one year, Mills went from a call for urgent action to a course of persistence: linguistically he dramatically transformed his message from one of reform and action to one of maintaining the status quo. This change is based on an overall graduation rate change of 5% from a rate of 64% to 69%. There is no evidence to suggest that within the span of a year there were any changes made by the state or local school districts that would impact the graduation rate.

The message from the New York State government is not consistent. On October 10, 2008, at Nazareth College, Governor David Paterson held a state summit on student engagement and dropping out. Paterson noted that "as dropout rates increase in more school districts throughout New York State, it is imperative that we make a significant and sustained effort to promote school completion and readiness among our State's greatest assets-its youth" (personal communication, 2008). He stated that this summit was a call to action. This study is a response to the call to action by Governor Paterson.

At the time of the completion of this study, there Mills has resigned his position, and a new Commissioner of Education has been appointed: Dr. Steiner. In a field memo released March 9, 2010 pertaining to high school graduation rates for students who began 9th grade in 2005, it was indicated that there was a modest improvement in graduation rates (University of the State of New York, 2010). The graduation rate was 72%. Regents Chancellor Merryl Tisch stated: "it is clear to me and to the Regents that the margin between what we are achieving and what can be achieved is far too great - and that we

cannot accept business as usual" (University of the State of New York, 2010). The field memo further indicated the need for "critical education reform" (University of the State of New York, 2007). It remains clear that high school graduation is a relevant and significant issue.

I will now move the analysis from the overall graduation rate for the different populations of youth within the state to graduation by ethnicity. In this analysis, I have utilized the 2003 cohort data by New York State (University of the State of New York, 2008).

Table 1.

Percentage of New York State Students Graduating High School by Race and Gender (2003 Cohort).

Race	Overall	Females	Males
White	73%	76%	63%
Black	33%	38%	28%
Hispanic	32%	36%	27%
Alaska Native/American Indian	42%	50%	35%
Asian Students	69%	75%	63%

In reviewing the chart, it is important to note that this is the data to which Mills (2007) referred in suggesting that persistence is making a difference. This chart provides evidence within public schools in New York State that there exists systematic and institutional racism, as a student's ethnicity is a significant factor in his or her likelihood to graduate or not to graduate from high school. Within this dissertation, of the 17 participants, 16 would be considered White, and one participant would be considered

Black. This raises the issue of whether a student's Whiteness is a factor in her/his ability to negotiate herself, the world, and others. Beyond ethnic status, another significant factor that influences graduation is the wealth of the district in which the student resides. To explore this aspect, I will report the graduation data from across districts based on the Need/Resource (N/RC) code.

The N/RC code is:

> a code indicating to which of the six Need/Resource categories a district belongs. Each district within New York State is placed in an N/CR based on their N/CR Index. The N/CR index is a measure of a district's ability to meet the needs of its students with local resources. The measure is calculated by dividing a district's estimated poverty percentage by the district's combined wealth. The NR/C six categories are: New York City, large cities, hi-need urban, average need, and low need. (University of the State of New York, 2000)

Table 2 compares the graduation data across NR/C codes from the 2003 cohort class.

Table 2

*Percentage of New York State students graduating according to need and resource category (2003 Cohort)***.**

Need/Resource Categories (NR/C)	Graduation Rate
New York City	52.2%
Large Cities	47.3%
High-Need Urban-Suburban	60.9%%
High Need Rural	72.4%
Average Need	79.9%
Low Need	91.2%
Total Graduation rate 2003 Cohort in June 2007	68.6

The category names conceal as much as they elucidate. The particular category to which I draw attention is that of the low need category. It is quite uncommon to refer to a person or entity that has a high degree of capital in terms of low: the term low often refers to a classification that signifies lack of, or below some standard. It would be similar to referring to a student in an honor program as having low needs. It would seem to be linguistically appropriate and grammatically correct to indicate low need districts as high capital districts. It appears the category name was assigned to conceal at least in part some of that which is being signified. It also allows blame to be placed on districts, as in, that district has high needs, and this one has low needs, and when exploring the graduation rates under the category of low needs districts, we find that most students are White and middle to upper class, and that higher need districts have a higher concentration of poverty and non-White students. In this manner, need is a marker of both class and race. This classification of low and high need districts supports the logical focus on the organizational structures of schools, as opposed to student learning. The focus on schools' organizational structures provides a context for teachers to be the focus of the blame for the failure of schools as well as provides additional warrant for the argument that what needs to change in public education is a shift from education being a publicly owned and operated service to the private operation of schools.

It is clear from this data that as a district's wealth increases, so does its overall graduation rate. The school that is the focus of this study is within a geographical region that would be considered rural. The graduation rate within this area for the 2003 cohort was 80%. The cohort consisted of 3,492 students, of which 716 students did not graduate.

The school of focus within my study had 22 students graduate in June of 2008, with a total population of 71 students.

It is clear from the 2003 cohort data that racism and classism are systematically supported by public schools within New York State, and that at the current time, we need urgent action as opposed to persistence. Persistence within the educational system will only result in the continued support of institutional classism and racism. The action within this dissertation is to understand how students negotiate self, world, and others, with a particular emphasis on this negotiation within school, and how these systematic factors influence students' negotiation. The participants within this study are not limited to the negotiation of self solely within school, but also within the context of the communities in which they reside, which are situated within a particular historical context, and as such, I will focus on the broader of impacts of neoliberalism.

Neoliberalism and Historical Context

Neoliberalism is "a set of policies that promote the primacy of the market, the fluidity of capital and labor, and individual self-interest in all spheres of economic and social life (Lipman & Haines, 2007, p. 476), or as McLaren dubbed neoliberalism, it is "capitalism with the gloves off" which guts public services, and provides unlimited concessions to transnational corporations (2005, p. 5). Bourdieu (1998), in exploring the effects of neoliberal policy stated that this ideology provides for the restructuring of relationships which is evident within the withdrawal of government from the social realm where it had previously taken responsibility under the welfare state policies to provide for the well-being of those it governed to a policy of privatization of public works, and to the individualization of responsibility. Bourdieu (1998) claimed that this has led to an

increased level of misery and despair for the vast majority of citizens. Governments within Europe and the United States have and continue to promote a new kind of conservatism "that appeals to progress, reason, science (economics) to justify the restoration and so tries to write off progressive thoughts and actions as archaic" (Bourdieu, 1998, p. 35). The effects of these ideological practices on educational policy and decisions are no more apparent than within the Chicago City Schools and the Renaissance 2010 project.

Lipman (2002) explored what educational opportunities were made available to students in Chicago City Schools, as the school system had redesigned the landscape of city schools through the development and building of new schools within the city to meet the demands of becoming a global city. In her geographical analysis of newly constructed schools within Chicago, Lipman found that:

> although high profile programs and schools alleged to be academically challenging are scattered throughout the city, almost all whole-school college-preparatory programs initiated in the last four years are clustered in middle-class, White or gentrifying areas. Most academically challenging programs in low-income communities involve only a portion of students. Vocational, military, and Direct Instruction (teachers use and read fixed scripts as instructions) schools-most involving all students in a school are clustered in low-income African American or Latino areas. (2002, p. 401)

As part of Renaissance 2010, the city is planning to close 60 to 70 public schools and open 100 new schools, with two-thirds of the schools being operated by private

industry, and staffed by teachers and school employees that will not be members of the CPS unions (Lipman & Haines, 2007, p. 471). Renaissance 2010 holds the same promise: as working class neighborhoods are torn down, they are replaced with high-priced condominiums and townhouses, wiping clean any account of the former communities (Lipman & Haines, 2007). The middle and upper classes are poised to move back to Chicago and lay claim to the renaissance of the city, claiming both its profits, and establishing white middle class values as the norm. The process is frightening not only because it is racist and oppressive, but in that it establishes a class system in which one class is provided with an educational focus on the development of skills for high paying jobs of the future, while other sections of the population are being educated to fulfill unskilled, low paying jobs, with few or no benefits (Lipman, 2002). The enactment of these policies underscore how the ideology of neoliberalism supports a world of social injustice where policies and procedures perpetuate social injustice, and inequality by differentiating life choices across the lines of race and class.

The issue of unequal educational opportunities for African-American students has a long history within our country and as Bell (2004) noted, Brown v. Board of Education has done little to change the historical under-funding of schools that enroll a predominantly nonwhite student population. Bell (2004) concluded that when whites were forced to desegregate schools, they responded by closing schools and then when they were forced to open integrated schools, whites left the city and fled to the suburbs where they could reestablish prominently segregated schools.

Evidence of such “White flight” can be noted by “the strongly pro-integration Harvard Civil Rights project, which reported that as of 2000-2001, White students

> on an average were attending schools where 80 percent of the student population was white, and that non-white students were increasingly attending schools in which virtually all students were non-white. (Bell, 2004, p. 127)

Bell concluded that he would favor a new version of the Supreme Court's ruling: one which would uphold the separate and equal school system, under such conditions that the equality was enforced across all schools. Bell called for the following: a) funding to be equalized across all schools; b) all facilities within a district are equalized; c) teacher pay is equal across all teachers within a district; d) that all schools would be required to meet a national norm for expenditures per pupil; and e) that school boards and decision making bodies would need to consist of members that accurately reflect the population of the school district (2004, p. 22-28).

In the discussion of students who do not complete high school, there needs to be a clear focus on how the context of current policies are shaping schools, how this affects the opportunities that students are provided so as to negotiate self, others, and the world . While the left has been criticized both for writing its politics onto, and reading its politics into their academic work, the right continues to hide and obfuscate its politics in individual responsibility, and the myth of pulling oneself up by one's bootstraps. What they neglect to mention is that the lengths of one's bootstraps is determined by social class and race. Within the context of public school, as the above data clearly demonstrates, if you are White, and upper to middle class, your bootstraps are longer and stronger, and thus you have more negotiating power to construct yourself as successful. This is not a case of reading into the data; it is a matter of allowing the data to be clearly presented. There can be no other explanation for these unequal outcomes, except that

public schools as institutions systematically privilege Whites, and in particular Whites from affluent communities, and as such, part of the grammar of school is that the negotiation of self, the world, and others is systematically favored for affluent Whites to continue to define themselves as the winner of the negotiation and thus justify their position as the center against which others are defined, and it provides logical justification of the rewards they reap from a system that is systemically designed to favor this group.

Review of the Major Themes of Literature

The vast amount of literature about students who do not complete high school has been conducted within the quantitative paradigm, which has been interested in the identification of predictive factors which are most salient when predicting which students will leave school prior to completing all of the requirements for graduation. Research has identified the following factors as the most robust predictors of non-completion of high school: social class, grade retention, race and employment opportunities (Jimerson, 2001; McNeal, 1997; & Rumberger, 1995). These factors tend to place the issue of non-completion onto students themselves, and as such, the student him/herself becomes the locus of the problem. As the locus of the problem, the origin and solution to the problem is placed onto and inside of youth: as we look inside youth, we are unable to question the practices and policies of schools in the larger context of society. This ideological practice of locating problems within the students, irrespective of what adults both say and do within their daily practice of “teaching” within school, is part of the grammar of school, and allows schools in a general sense to require students to bend their will and inclinations to that of the school. In many school environments, this leads to the teaching

of unreflective thought, and toward a teaching practice that fills students' minds with facts, as opposed to teaching students to pose problems and seek solutions. There are a few qualitative studies that focus on the process of disengagement, and how the gap between students' lived experiences within schools and students' lived experiences outside of school influences students to leave school prior to graduation (Fine, 1991; McLaren, 1999; Rymes, 2001). In the next section, I will review this body of knowledge. As the majority of the literature is within a quantitative paradigm, I will review this literature first, and then I will focus on qualitative studies, and where it is appropriate, I will demonstrates links between these two different paradigms. I will begin this review by first exploring the term within the literature for students who do not complete high school - drop-outs.

The term "drop-out" began to appear around the 1950's as it became the expected norm that youth graduate from high school. This was due in large part to long-term economic trends, as well as shifting demographic patterns within the United States (Dorn, 1993). As the norm within the United States became graduating from high school, what separated drop-outs from graduates were character flaws, which led them to be ignorant of the consequences of the choice to leave school (Dorn, 1993). As Dorn stated, "the label stigmatizes those without diplomas and its opposite (high school graduation) conveys social inclusion and good citizenship" (1993, p. 373). As with other terms, the term drop-out signifies two things at the same moment: first: the norm or social expectations (high school graduation) and at the same time, the deviation from the norm (not graduating from high school). The term also lessens the humanity of a person; when he is referred to as a drop-out, he is no longer a person, or a student, but he is a fixed

entity- a dropout. As drop-out stigmatizes and dehumanizes students, I have actively refused to use this term within my writing.

The diploma as a terminal degree stands as a mark of successfully completing school, or a long series of continuous examinations. The completion or non-completion marks the individual, as Foucault (1977) noted:

> Thanks to the whole apparatus of writing that accompanied it, the examination opened up two correlative possibilities: firstly the constitution of the individual as a describable object, not in order to reduce him to 'specific' features, as did the naturalists in relation to living beings, but in order to maintain him in his individual features, in his particular evolution, in his own aptitudes or abilities, under the gaze of a permanent corpus of knowledge; and, secondly, the constitution of a comparative system that made possible the measurement of overall phenomena, the description of groups, the characterization of collective facts, the calculation of the gaps between individuals, their distribution in a given population. (p. 190)

As affluent White students are statistically more likely to graduate from high school than Black or Hispanic students, the continuous examination continues to center affluent Whiteness as success, and students who are affluent and White have an increased power to negotiate self, world, and others, as their power is visible. This visible power is converted into a written power through the practice of the continuous exam, which provides the space for language to be used (written texts and spoken words) as a tool that is established to further legitimize an illegitimate power through the establishment of a binary system of classification. As Foucault stated:

> Generally speaking, all the authorities exercising individual control function according to a double mode; that of binary division and branding (mad/sane: dangerous/harmless; normal/abnormal): and that of the coercive assignment, of differential distribution (who he is; where he must be; how he is to be characterized; how he is to be recognized. (Foucault, 1977, p. 199)

It is clear that drop-outs are perceived as abnormal/deviant. de Certeau (1998) noted that "every power, including the power of law is written first of all on the backs of its subjects. Knowledge does the same" (p. 140). Conceptualizing power and knowledge as having the ability to write on the backs of its subjects clearly extends Foucault's concept of the exam resulting in labeling, to that of the exam having the ability to physically inscribe its mark onto individuals. Therefore, the institution of school marks all of its subjects (students), and ensures that being white and affluent is the mark of success and acceptance. Quantitative researchers will deny their inscription in the name of objective science, but these inscriptions, which have been ascribed in the name of science, must in fact become the focus of sciences. The institution of schooling and science needs to cease its pursuit of discovering an endless array of child pathologies, new labels, and new remediation strategies, as each of the pursuits serves the function of ensuring that each student who leaves school without graduating is marked as deviant in multiple ways, and the labeling process inscribes students as deviant not only within their school files and at the pharmacy counter but onto each child's soul. The permanent inscription of deviance onto the student's soul ensures that the youth's deviance is transferred outside of the school house doors, and into his/her community. The gaze of schools needs to turn inward to explore their practices, policies, and beliefs, and their effects on students. This

change in focus will change the question from: “What is wrong with children and right with schools?” to “What is right with children and wrong with schools?” The changing of this question will provide the context to explore how the institution of school, for too long and without question has, if not supported classism, racism, and sexism, has surely done little to ameliorate classism, racism, and sexism. With this in mind, I will now turn toward the literature.

Jimerson (2001) conducted a meta-analysis of twenty studies pertaining to dropping out and grade retention from 1990-1999, and concluded that grade retention is a significant factor that is likely to increase the probability of students dropping out of school. Rumberger (1995) indicated that students who are retained are eleven times more likely to drop out of school than students who are not held back (p. 604). Jimerson (2001) also concluded that retaining students, or pushing them forward to the next grade would not improve students’ educational achievement, and implored those who work with children and youth to explore and develop new alternatives for students. In 2002, Jimerson, Anderson, and Whipple (2002) noted their concern that with the increasing focus on accountability and standards, schools have responded by increasing the number of students that are retained in school as there are sometimes short-term gains in student achievement, but that the long-term consequences of retention are that the gains are quickly lost, and retention leads to a significant increase in the likelihood of not completing high school.

Absenteeism, truancy and disciplinary issues all have been identified as factors that increase the probability of a student not completing high school. These three factors are considered together as they all result in the same effect: a student who is not present

in school. Bowditch (1993) concluded that school disciplinary school procedures are designed to have students who are over-aged (above age 17), and not on track to graduate to be removed from the class rolls as an outcome of disciplinary procedure. These students are frequently perceived as “troublemakers,” and thus the outcome seems justified. This theme of forcing out the troublemakers to save the “good ones” is consistent with Fine’s (1991) findings. Stearns and Glennie (2006) concluded that frequent disciplinary action leads to students dropping out. While Stearns and Glennie (2006) suggested that the institution of school may evaluate White and African American student behavior differently, they quickly moved away from this controversy by stating that more research needs to be done within this area (p. 54). It is by moving away from this and claiming that more research needs to be done that we come up with petty excuses that only condone and allow for this violence to continue to be perpetrated on youth.

A related factor to absenteeism is the employment of students that are of school age within the workforce. It appears that both the type of employment and the hours worked by students have a statistically significant effect on students dropping out. McNeal (1997) suggested that, as opposed to the assumption that the number of hours worked leads to dropping out, the type of employment and hours worked have an interactive effect that needs to be considered when drawing conclusions about the effect of working on dropping out. While acknowledging that an interaction exists between type of employment and hours, Lee and Staff (2007) concluded that working less than 20 hours a week increased the probability that a student would drop out of school, while working less than 20 hours in a particular type of employment may lower the risk of a student dropping out.

The final factor that I will review is that of socioeconomic status. Rumberger (1995) indicated that "Black, Hispanic, and Native American eighth grade students had significantly higher odds of dropping out than other students, and Asian students had significantly lower odds" (p. 603), but that "even controlling for a host of other factors, students from low social class families were twice as likely to drop out as students from average class families" (p. 616). Rumberger also concluded that:

> eighth grade students one standard deviation above the mean in socioeconomic status (which was normalized to a mean of zero and standard deviation of one) were almost one third as likely to drop-out as students with mean values of socioeconomic status. Conversely, eighth grade students one standard deviation below the mean in socioeconomic status were 3 times as likely to drop out of school as students with mean values of socioeconomic status. (1995, p. 603)

It is clear that on a national and local level that class is a determining factor which predicts high school graduation. As graduation is set as the norm, and not graduating as a deviation, then not graduating from high school transcends the label of a person as student, but also their lived experience, and culture outside of school. The non-graduation from high school becomes the condemnation of the whole person, and is not isolated to being a school issue. This is perhaps why "dropouts are costly. Dropouts experience higher levels of unemployment, and receive lower pay, and are more likely to have health problems, engage in criminal activities, and depend on more social services" (Rumberger, 1995, p. 584). The marking and then writing on the backs of students who do not graduate has devastating effects at the individual level, which translates into larger societal issues. Despite this, the system of school and the ideology behind it continues to

reproduce at an alarming rate students who do not graduate from high school. I will now turn to explore this problem from the lens of a qualitative research paradigm.

The most notable qualitative study of dropping out is Fine's (1991) ethnography of the practices and policies of a New York City School, and how these policies worked to support students being pushed out of the schools through bureaucracy, rules and regulations. Fine (1991) concluded that the policies of schools are designed to structure a process so that students become disengaged, and through their disengagement, which was structurally supported, they are pushed-out.

This process is parallel to Foucault's concept of how discipline is exercised:

> Exercise is that technique by which one imposes on the body tasks that are both repetitive and different, but always graduated. By bending behavior towards a terminal state, exercise makes possible a perpetual characterization of the individual either in relation to this term, in relation to other individuals, or in relation to a type of itinerary. (1977, p. 161)

This process of bending to a terminal state, and creating relationships is also noted by Fine (1991) in her critique of how low income schools "contain rather than explore social, and economic contradictions, and condone rather than critique prevailing social inequalities, and usher children and adolescents into ideologies and ways of interpreting social evidence that legitimate rather than challenge social inequity" (p. 61). These educational and institutional practices silence students, and may result in students disengaging from school as they are witness to the hypocrisy of their education, and thus reject the hegemonic force by resisting inculcation through disengagement.

Disengagement may be a “safer” form of resistance since, as Fine noted, “some students that actively resist are frequently banished from school via the mechanism of school discipline which classifies the student as insubordinate, or oppositional” (1991, p. 61). Perhaps their resistance should be recast as a negotiation for their own humanity.

McLaren (1999) held a similar position of curriculum as a hegemonic force that not only reproduces the politics and economic dominance of one social class over another, but also considers how the curriculum is able to project its interpretation of the world by establishing certain ideologies to become and be considered common sense (p. 84). A major theme that McLaren raised was the different ways of acting and being that constitute being a student, and being a person outside out of school (street corner).

> Ritual knowledge in the student state was often sullied by an inflated rationalism, whereas in the street corner state, the students made use of more bodily exploration and organic symbols. Ritual knowledge in the student state was more symbolically sophisticated; but because such was discarnate and not a lived ‘engagement,’ it remained distant, isolated and abstract. (1999, p. 206)

This separating, and privileging the abstract and rational over the immediate, lived experience and the body further separates and disconnects students from school and learning. McLaren noted that teachers tend to blame the failure on the students themselves, and on internal traits of the students. McLaren and Fine were both deeply troubled by the common practice of locating failure inside children.

Rymes (2001) explored the narrative identities of students who have chosen to drop-back in to an alternative high school. The student narratives highlight both the process of disengagement as a long running process and the need for research to focus on

the many events in students' lives over time which impact and affect students' choices within schools. Rymes concluded that

> dropping out is usually the result of a long series of encounters and experiences and the building up of attitudes, views- an identity- that is compatible with leaving school. The narrative creation of such an identity is coauthored by other students, by an institution, and, even in this case by me. (2001, p. 174)

Rymes further stated "that disengagement is a potentially reversible process. But it cannot be accomplished without attention to the particularity of individual lives, the ways those lives are narrated" (2001, p. 174). Rymes' work is clearly both important and significant, as it fundamentally shifts the focus of inquiry from that at the macro level to that at the micro level, as well as shifts the focus of changing schools to the interactional space between schools and students, as opposed to focusing on either schools or students.

My own study extends Rymes' work by exploring the transitional period within an alternative high school. My study also built onto the area of research, as in my research, I could not locate other similar studies. As Knesting and Waldron (2006) noted, there is little known to help students stay in school. Knesting and Waldron (2006) used a case study to better understand how support services at one school enhanced the students' motivation to graduate. Using a grounded theory approach, Knesting and Waldron (2006) concluded that students persisted when they: a) were goal-oriented (believed in the benefit of a high school diploma, b) had a willingness to play the game of school (abide by the rules of the school) and c) had connected with staff members that they perceived cared about their success in school, and that they perceived cared about each student as a

person. Caring and connecting to adults is a prevalent theme within educational leadership publications as a means to improve the graduation rate.

Conclusion

In the conclusion, I had three aims: a) to provide a summary of the literature review, b) to articulate the problem that emerges from the literature, and c) to provide a rationale for a new approach to an old problem.

It is clear from the review of the data that being White, from upper-to-middle class significantly increases a student's likelihood of graduating from high school. Within the State of New York, within each of the race categories, female students have a higher percentage of graduation than males within the same race category. At a national and state level, the most salient predictor of graduating from high school is that of class. While this is the case, it was also demonstrated that Blacks have historically either been denied education altogether, or when education has been provided, it has been provided with fewer resources than white schools have. The issues of systematic and institutional racism and classism are key macro level issues that frame the experiences of students within public schools. A majority of the literature that pertains to students who do not complete school is quantitative in nature and does not focus on issues of race and class; instead it is focused on predictive factors, which result in locating the problem within youth and children themselves. This has led to little change with regard to the problem of students leaving school without graduating, as there is little one can do to change the internal problems. The factors that are most salient are: a) grade retention, b) disciplinary reasons, and low attendance, and c) employment during the high school years.

Within qualitative research, this issue or problem has primarily been explored as one situated within the operation of schools. Salient themes that are noted within this corpus of inquiry are that working class youth and non-white youth experience a curriculum within school that silences their experiences of injustice within both school and society, and alienates students by actively disconnecting the official school curriculum from that of the lived experience and knowledge of students outside of the school. Both within qualitative and quantitative studies, there has been a consensus that leaving school without graduating is a process, as opposed to an event.

Rymes' (2001) study broke the dynamic tension between being pushed-out, or pulled-out of school: she explored the issue as an interactional issue between schools and students, and how these interactions shape and construct certain identities within school. Rymes' study is the only study that I found that states that the process of non-graduating is interactional.

The review of literature leads me to conclude that the practice and ideologies of schools foster and create environments in which students who are non-White and who are not of middle or high class status have and continually have been situated within school as failures, and that the marking of youth as failures is not only an act of violence onto the students themselves, but also transcends the school house door and becomes a condemnation of the students' culture, families, and social position outside of school. The condemnation not only leads to the solidification of a rigid class system, but when coupled with the ideological work of the right, it is made to seem natural and right that the individuals are solely held responsible for their failure, as opposed to the system that produces the failure. There have been too many youth and families on which this

violence has been perpetrated: we must fight against a system which continually brands so many non-White, lower class students as failures and in the ultimate irony, holds the individual accountable for his/her failure as opposed to the system that continually reproduces this failure. It is my strong contention that this fight not only needs new analytical tools, but also an unwavering commitment to slowly and methodically bend the system back against itself, so as to expose it for what it has done and continues to do. Critical discourse analysis appears to be one such tool of promise. In the next chapter, I will outline a methodological approach that was used within this study to understand how seventeen students within an alternative high school renegotiated themselves, the world, and others.

Chapter 3

The Space In-Between: A Critical Approach to Discourse and Identity

Introduction

The structure of my dissertation is an instrumental collective case study design. Stake (1995) defined an instrumental collective case study as a study in which the object is to understand something else other than this particular case (p. 3). Within the framework of an instrumental case study design, an interpretative methodological approach was used to answer the following questions: a) How and in what ways did participants negotiate and construct meaning about self, others, and the world? b) How did these constructions and the meaning-making process situate the participants within and outside of school and what implication does this negotiation process have for the educators who work with students? c) What in the context of an alternative high school provided the conditions for participants to renegotiate their understanding of self, others, and the world? The unit of analysis for this study was the participants' narratives. In a manner consistent within the critical thirdspace framework, the analysis of narratives was done both at the level of meaning above the sentence (macro) and well as at the level of utterance (micro). Having both a macro and micro level of analysis provides for the development of a robust theory of how participants negotiated and constructed meaning within and outside of school. To ensure that each of the participants' voices was heard, each participant's voice was included within the text of this study, via direct quotes and analysis. As each study is bound within a particular time and space, I will provide the context for this study.

Context

The context of the study is an alternative school in Western New York, whose mission it is to work with students who are currently not earning sufficient credits to meet the graduation requirements of the New York State Board of Regents (22 credits within particular sets of classes, and the completion of five Regents Exams with a score of 65 or higher). The students are referred to the alternative high school via the superintendent of Schools of the school district in which they are a legal resident. The expectation of the Superintendent is that each student within the program graduate from high school with a Regents Diploma. In many ways, this school is similar to other alternative education programs, as such programs are the outposts of an educational system, where students who have not met the established markers of success are sent. It is here, in the margins where the study originates, but much as the epicenter of an earthquake sends many ripples, so do the narratives of the participants, and as such, the narratives focus well beyond school and much focus is on the negotiation of self, others, and the world. As the participants' narratives send many different ripples in many different directions, the methodological thinking and techniques need to be robust enough to honor the richness and depth of the participants' lived experiences. I will first elucidate a theory of language which provides both warrants for the techniques used, as well as a broader perspective about how I conceptualized language in use. This will provide warrant for the use of an iterative methodology in which the methodological process is both structured and is structured by the inquiry itself, and the methodology transcends procedures applied to become a way of thinking about phenomenon (Charmaz, 2006; Denzin & Lincoln, 2005; Gee 2006; Marshall & Rossman, 2006; Strauss & Corbin, 1998).

Meaning above the Sentence

In this section, I will develop a warrant for methodology as a form of thinking. My methodological thinking pertaining to language in use is grounded within the work of Freud (1993), Vygotsky (1987), Bourdieu (2005, 2003, & 2009), and Bakhtin (2006 & 2001). The methodological thinking used within this dissertation to develop an understanding of the meaning that exists above the sentence is grounded within the methodological techniques described in this chapter.

Freud (1993), within his theoretical framework of human personality, introduced the ideology of the unconscious into the field of psychology, which is represented by the Id. The Id, Ego, and Superego formulate the structure of one's personality. The Superego seeks to satisfy the Id's impulses and desires through finding socially appropriate means and behaviors to meet the Id's desires. The Ego is the portion of the personality of which the individual is consciously aware. Within the current context of American society, the acceptance of the unconscious is widely held as an established truth. Other theorists such as Carl Jung and Eric Fromm continued to build on Freud's work, and the field of psychoanalytical theory grew to include concepts such as the collective conscience and the inferiority complex. What is of particular interest within the context of this thesis are not the particulars of each of these theories, but instead the consequence that this family of theories had in expanding the concept of the human mind as being both the place of the known/aware and of the unknown/unaware. This opening of the mind provides a space for language to become a tool that humans can use to express both conscious and unconscious thoughts, ideas, feelings, desires, wants and needs. Since, at the current time, there exists no means to look into the mind directly, one can only draw inferences and

subjective hypotheses about how the mind organizes and makes sense of stimuli within the environment, and how it develops, constructs and construes meaning and significance.

Beyond the psychoanalytical tradition, other branches of psychology developed ideologies of the mind. Developmental psychologists such as Piaget developed theories, including one that states that language was used to express one's thoughts and ideas in terms of hypotheses testing, which provided a context for a person to develop an understanding of the relationship between oneself and others, and the world. Cognitive Psychology built on Piaget's idea, and developed an ideology that people develop schemas to understand, interpret, and organize the world and their place within the world. Despite the major differences between each branch of psychology, one similarity that linked each of the above theories was that language was considered to be a by-product of either/or both the conscience and unconscious mind. The study of the human mind is expansive and it branches into numerous fields. The one by-product of the mind's activity that provides a glimpse into the working of the mind is language (spoken, written, and non-verbal). Language refracts human intellectual activity into a myriad of directions. Prior to exploring how meaning is constructed within and between individuals and groups, it is important to understand that meaning is not constructed exclusively internally or externally, but also within a third area: that of experience. As Winnicott stated (2006):

> We experience life in the area of transitional phenomena, in the exciting interweave of subjectivity and objective observation, and in an area that is

> intermediate between the inner reality of the individual and the shared reality of the world that is external to individuals. (p. 86)

I will explore each of the three areas of language and meaning construction, and in doing so, I will draw on the work of Vygotsky (1987), Bourdieu (2003), and Bakhtin (2006) to develop a framework for how meaning is developed within the interplay between internal thought, external expression of thoughts and human experience. Within this dissertation, the struggle for significance theory is built on the premises that language expresses both unconscious and conscious desires, thoughts, and feelings, and that we live life within a transitional space, in which we ascribe meaning, construct understandings, and develop ways of knowing and being based on experience. As Fiumara (1995) noted: "we perceive the world as we do, we easily overlook that we behave in a way to perceive as such, and that the world is part of the loop created by our language, beliefs, and desires" (p. 91). The thirdspace framework analysis bends the continuum of objective knowledge and subjective knowing together to create a space where the participants' lived experiences and perceptions of the world they create are analyzed to develop a theory "in the Greek sense of the word: 'to see'" (Fiumara, 1995, p. 31). The findings of the dissertation provide the ability to see the world of schooling from a marginal perspective, and to capture the disquieting narratives of the participants, which expands the thirdspace framework to be a critical framework: the critical thirdspace framework.

Vygotsky (1987) theorized two key distinctions: one between inner and external speech, and the second: the relationship between thought and word. Vygotsky (1987) defined inner speech as speech for oneself, and external speech as being for others. He claimed that "inner speech expresses all thoughts and sensations, even whole chains of

reasoning through a single word" (1987, p. 276). He further stated that the meaning of internal speech cannot be translated into the language of external speech. "External speech involves the embodiment of thought in the word, whereas in inner speech, the word dies away and gives birth to thought" (p. 276). Vygotsky claimed a dynamic relationship between thought and word: "the relationship of thought to word is not a thing, but a process, a movement from thought to word and word to thought" (1987, p. 250). Vygotsky problemitized the meaning of words:

> We never know the complete sense of anything, including a word. The word is an inexhaustible source of new problems. It is, in a sense, never complete. Ultimately, the sense of a word depends on one's understanding of the world and, as a whole, on the internal structures of personality. (1987, p. 276)

Vygotsky further claimed that: "the word absorbs intellectual and affective content from the context in which it is intertwined. It begins to mean both more and less than when it is viewed in isolation" (1987, p. 276). While Vygotsky's theories are usually more aligned with social-cultural learning theories, his theory of language divides language into two different planes: establishing a relationship between word and thought and words develop meaning through their context. Each of these claims provides a theoretical base on which to develop how meaning is constructed. Freire and Macedo's concept of literacy: ". . . literacy is best understood as a myriad of discursive forms and cultural competencies that construct and make available the various relationships and experiences that exist between the learner and the world (1987, p. 20), extends that of Vygotsky's to a broader and more political realm in which the meanings between and

amongst different individuals and groups are contested over, and the ability to establish what counts as knowledge is a strategy of cultural domination.

Bakhtin (2006) moved the analysis of language beyond the level of words to the level of utterance, and he claimed that meaning is communicated at the level of utterance. I will now draw upon Bakhtin's work to continue the development of the methodological thinking pertaining to language as a field of study.

A concept which is central to Bakhtin's theory is the delineation of time into past, present, and future. Bakhtin (2006) stated: "everything- from an abstract idea to a piece of rock on the bank of a stream- bears the stamp of time, is saturated with time, and assumes its form and meaning in time" (p. 42). Time is a human construct, a concept that leads one in the hermeneutic circle- "which implies that the meaning of one part can only be understood in the context of the whole, but that this in turn is only accessible from its component parts- indicates the problem of intelligibility of hermeneutic interpretation" (Myer, 2001, p. 16). To avoid the hermeneutic circle, I will claim as Merleau-Ponty indicated, "time is not a line, but a network of intentionality" (p. 484), and that past and future only exist because I am present.

Bakhtin (2006) claimed that language is the refraction of human thoughts, and that it provides a medium in which people can express themselves, make themselves understood, and in the process, objectify themselves. Bakhtin held that language usage is rooted in a basic human need to be understood. Bakhtin (2006) moved the analysis of language away from both the word and the sentence.

> The sentence as a unit of language, like the word, has no author. Like the word, it belongs to *nobody*, and only by functioning as a whole utterance does it become

> an expression of the position of someone speaking individually in a concrete situation of speech communication. (Bakhtin, 2006, p. 83-84)

For Bakhtin (2006), language is:

> realized in the form of individual concrete utterances (oral and written) by participants in the various areas of human activity. These utterances reflect the specific conditions and goals of each such area not only through their content (thematic) and linguistic style, that is, the selection of the lexical, phraseologial, and grammatical resources of the language, but above all through their compositional structure. All three of these aspects- thematic content, style, and compositional structure- are inseparably linked to the whole of the utterance and are equally determined by the specific nature of the particular sphere of communication. Each separate utterance is individual, of course, but each sphere in which language is used develops its own relatively stable types of these utterances. These we may call speech genres. (p. 60)

The boundaries between utterances are determined by the change in speaker. While Bakhtin (2006) moved the level of meaning to that of utterances, he also established the notion that language systems are developed within specific fields and spheres. He held that words have three levels of meanings for the speaker: a neutral meaning belonging to nobody, others' words which are filled with echoes of other utterances and his/her own words for dealing with a particular situation (p. 88).

> Our speech, that is, all our utterances (including creative works) is filled with others' words, varying degrees of otherness or varying degrees of "our-own-ness," varying degrees of awareness and detachment. These words of others carry

> with them carry with them their own expression, their own evaluative tone, which we assimilate, rework, and re-accentuate. (Bakhtin, 2006, p. 89)

Bakhtin, similar to Vygotsky, situated the meaning of words within a given context. Bakhtin (2006) placed a significant emphasis on an individual's historical experiences with the words and utterances. Bakhtin also held that meaning is derived at the level of the utterance, and not at the level of words.

Bakhtin's (2006) theory of speech genres provides a context in which to expand the theoretical field of language: first that language serves a basic human desire to distinguish oneself against the backdrop of other people, and to be understood. Second, language is historically rooted, and all expressions and utterances are filled with others' voices and ideologies. Third, meaning is constructed not at the micro-level of the word, but at the macro-level of an utterance.

Another key component of Bakhtin's theory is that he moved the analysis beyond just spoken language to include written text. "Behind the text stands a language system. Everything in the text repeats and reproduces" (Bakhtin, 2006, p. 105). This link to written text provides the bridge between the analysis of spoken language and written language.

Within today's digital world, words are being transformed into images that, with the assistance of technology, can be shared internationally in seconds. de Certeau (1998) provided an important link between words and images within the modern society, and in doing so, he was able to draw Bakhtin's ideas and concepts into the "modern world. . . From TV to newspapers, from advertising to all sorts of mercantile epiphanies, our society is characterized by a cancerous growth of vision, measuring everything by its

ability to show or be shown and transmuting communication into a visual journey" (de Certeau, 1988, p. xxi). de Certeau's concept of the cancerous growth of vision not only connects Bakhtin to the modern world, but also broadens the base of the analysis of language to include visual imagery, which is currently transforming words and ideologies into visual imagery.

Bakhtin (1981) theorized a tension within language between two forces, one of unifying meaning, and the coloring of meaning by its situatedness within the context of the language use:

> Every concrete utterance of a speaking subject serves as a point where centrifugal as well as centripetal forces are brought to bear. The processes of centralization and decentralization, of unification and disunification, intersect in the utterance; the utterance not only answers the requirements of its own language as an individualized embodiment of a speech act, but it answers the requirements of heteroglossia as well; it is in fact an active participant in such speech diversity. And this active participation of every utterance in living heteroglossia determines the linguistic profile and style to no less a degree than its inclusion in any normative-centralizing system of a unitary language. (p. 272)

The tension in language is constant, and in resisting the unification of language by embracing the heteroglossia of language, which privileges context over text for meaning, one can resist the ideological domination of the dominant class.

The final concept of Bakhtin's (2006) work upon which I will draw is to focus on the space between words and the speaking subject. "No living word relates to its object in a singular way: between the word and its object, between the word and the speaking

subject, there exists an elastic environment of other, alien words about the same object" (Bakhtin, 1981, p. 276). As Lefebvre (1991) noted, within this space between words lies the power to signify meaning through abstraction; thus a world is created through the process of signifying meaning within words. Language is not a neutral/objective means of signifying objects in the world, but all language is subjective: it creates and constructs a world. Within the control of what language and discourse signify, and in the privileging of one discourse over another lies a strategy of power that the dominant/ruling class uses to universalize meanings and create knowledge (common sense) which signifies one meaning that is uncontested and is accepted without thought or consideration. A study of language in use must be not only sensitive to this logic, but also must extend beyond common sense to explore the multiple-layered meanings of the word and the space between the signifier and signified.

A particular challenge within this dissertation is that a relationship between myself and each student and parent was established when I was perceived as having power over each person due to my professional responsibility as the principal of the program. The power over relationship was established within my role as principal: I could accept or deny enrollment of students into the program, and I also had the ability to remove a student from the program. In addition, I established all students' schedules, and approved all course credits. After a student enrolled in the program, they also had a power influence on the daily operation of the school. A strong indication of the power relationship was that in each of the first interviews (auto-biographical narrative), I was omitted from the narrative, although other teachers were discussed. During the second interview, I asked each participant the following question: "If this school needed a new

principal, and you were responsible for hiring a new principal, what qualities should the new principal have?"

The participants' answers were often very vague: "like you, you know," "nice," "hard working," or "understanding." Answers to this question were given with an uncomfortable laugh, or with eyes shifting toward the ground. In the participants' narratives, my role within their lives was not a subject that appeared to be a topic that was to be shared. I attribute this in part to the power over relationship, and in part to the trust that was established during the participants' enrollment at the alternative high school. It may additionally reflect that the participants may have been unwilling to engage in the social negotiation of our relationship due to the perceived notion that negative comments about "me" or the program might result in a rejection from me.

I addressed this challenge by creating a new context in two ways. First, my position as principal provided the context to establish a trusting relationship. Building from this trust, I explained to each participant that my role within the interview was not that of a principal, but that of a novice researcher who was learning his craft and that their lived experiences would assist me in shaping the future of the program. This linguistic positioning of myself outside of my official role provided a space for me to embody a different aspect of myself: as novice, and in doing so, it moved me from expert to novice. As the aim was to assist the program, the aim had a relevant meaning to the participants. As will be discussed in Chapters 5 and 6, this linguistic positioning allowed for the trust previously established to be transferred to the interviews with each participant.

The final theoretical consideration within the development of a theoretical base of language is the work of Bourdieu. Bourdieu's (2003) major contribution within the

development of my theoretical base was his idea of politicizing language usage by framing it as an economic exchange (p. 5), and situating the struggle over meaning as part of an ideological battle over symbolic power.

Bourdieu (2003) stated:

> that the social sciences must take as their object of study the social operations of naming and the rites of institution through which they are accomplished. But on a deeper level, they must examine the part played by words in the construction of the social reality and the contribution which the struggle over classifications, a dimension of all class struggles, makes to the constitution of classes. (2003, p. 105)

Within his call, Bourdieu (2003) expanded the analysis of language from one of understanding the relationship between thoughts, speech, and the inner and external words, to the effect that words and language have in creating, establishing and maintaining social order. Bourdieu (2003) also established that different language systems hold different amounts of social power and subsequently different people have different abilities to shape the reality of the social world.

> The recognition of the legitimacy of the official language has nothing in common with an explicitly professed, deliberate, and revocable belief, or with an intentional act of accepting a 'norm.' It is inscribed in a practical state, in dispositions which are impalpably inculcated, through a long and slow process of acquisition, by the sanctions of the linguistic market, and which are therefore adjusted without any cynical calculation or consciously experienced constraint, to the chances of material and symbolic profit which the laws of price formation

> characteristic of a given market objectively offer to the holders of a given linguistic capital. (Bourdieu, 2003, p. 51)

The official language of the state or ruling class establishes the market for linguistic exchange which moves the market of meaning from enciphering and deciphering to an economic exchange in which symbolic relationships of power are enacted and profits are gained through the discourse (Bourdieu, 2003, p. 51). The establishment of an official language provides the context for symbolic power to be enacted and it provides legitimacy to those in power.

The establishment of an official language also allows for the measurement of one's use of language against that of the official language, thus establishing different "styles" which are more, less, or equal in value to each other, and all are of less value than that of the official language as each deviates from the official language. The more "deviant" the language, the less worth and less symbolic power it has. The second element of the establishment of an official language is that it provides the context for the dominant ideology to be reproduced without question. Therefore, it assumes the position of being 'natural' and beyond question, and no other language can challenge the dominant culture, as it does not have the symbolic power to do so. As Bourdieu (2003) stated,

> the dominant culture produces this ideological effect by concealing the function of the division beneath the function of communication: the culture which unifies is also the culture which separates and which legitimizes distinctions by forcing other cultures to deviate from the dominant culture. (p. 167)

The work of Bakhtin (1981, & 2006) and Vygotsky (1987) established that the field of language is provided warrant to theorize language in the following manner: that the meaning of words is embedded within a historical context, and that there is meaning both within the word uses, as well as at a level above the sentence. Bourdieu (2003, & 2005) and Lefbreve (1991) established that the context within and between those whom are using language can be a context in which power and hegemony can influence the meaning ascribed to language in use. This section established how I used methodological thinking to analyze the data. In the next sections, I provide warrant for the use of different methodological techniques that are used to develop answers to the following three questions: a) How and in what ways did participants negotiate and construct meaning about self, others, and the world?; b) How did these constructions and meaning-making processes situate the participants within and outside of school, and what implication does this negotiation process have for school?; and c) What, in the context of an alternative high school, changed and provided the context for students to renegotiate their understanding of self, the world, and others?

Lines of Inquiry

In this section, I expand my methodological approach from thinking about phenomena to the use of techniques that provide the ability to analyze language in a manner that is consistent with the methodological thinking that was established in the previous section that: a) language in use refracts the speaker's/writer's conscience and unconscious ontological and epistemological beliefs, which colors the meaning she ascribes to signs and symbols within the world, b) the dominant/ruling class attempts to universalize meanings and thus limits people's ability and inclination to negotiate

meaning c) that embedded within language are multiple voices, which index certain meanings, and d) language is a form of capital that people exchange and use. Within my study, I developed an understanding of the formation of self, as well as how power influences students' construction of both identity and their relationship to the world, and what resources are available to youths to construct the self within and outside of school; thus I used the following lines of inquiry: critical discourse analysis, autobiographical narratives/identity construction, metaphor analysis, and grounded theory. Each of the lines of inquiry are analogous to the angle of the stars used by the sea captain to estimate location: as with the stars, these lines of inquiry will cross and it is within their intersection that I will be able to develop an account of their lived experience, and provide a triangulation of data, which will provide validity for my findings.

Critical Discourse Analysis

"Critical Discourse Analysis is an attempt to bring social theory and discourse analysis together to describe, interpret, and explain the ways in which the discourse constructs, becomes constructed by, represents, and becomes represented by the social word" (Rogers, Malancharuvil-Berkes, Mosley, Hui, Joseph, 2005, p. 366). As Luke (2002), and Vadeboncoeur and Luke (2004) noted, critical discourse analysis can be an analytical tool to both engage the ideological and political functions of discourse, but also can be used to speak to what is possible. Luke (2002) noted that one way to access what is possible is to use critical discourse analysis to include the "minority discourses, disaporic voices, texts, and statements that are 'written out' and over by dominant institutions" (p. 106). Luke (2001), and Vadeboncoeur and Luke (2004) held that discourse can be as emancipatory as it can be oppressive: in this manner, discourse can be

bent back to a thirdspace of radical openness. A critical discourse analysis framework focuses this study on inclusion of disaporic voice, and provides a new insight into an old problem, by understanding change and a transformation of space within the context of a youth's life span. Using critical discourse analysis to think new about an old problem contributes to the formation and development of an empirical base of critical discourse analysis studies, which as Rogers (2004) noted, is needed first and foremost in the establishment of critical discourse analysis as a legitimate field of scholarly research.

While Rogers noted that the establishment of critical discourse analysis is a legitimate field of study, there remains substantial conversation regarding what constitutes critical discourse analysis. Rogers (2004) noted:

> there is no formula for conducting Critical Discourse Analysis. The researchers who use CDA are concerned with Critical Theory of the social world, the relationship of language and discourse in the construction and representation of this social world, and a methodology that allows them to describe, interpret, and explain such relationships. (p. 3)

Wodak and Myer (2001) viewed critical discourse analysis as the creative act of exposing the production of meanings that have been established as stable and natural, and in essence, unquestionable. Myer (2001, p. 30) stated that there is no accepted cannon for critical discourse analysis and van Dijk (2001, p. 96) stated that critical discourse analysis is a "critical perspective on doing scholarship: it is, so to speak, discourse analysis 'with an attitude'" (p. 96). Critical discourse analysis focuses primarily on social problems and especially on the role of discourse in the production and reproduction of power and dominance.

The current state of critical discourse analysis as a methodology is closer to methodological thinking whereas the work of Gee (2005) and Fairclough (2003) provide the tools of inquiry that move critical discourse analysis from methodological thinking to a methodological approach which is grounded within particular techniques. I will draw on the work of Gee (2005) and Fairclough (2006) to ground my analysis of both spoken and written language within specific research techniques.

Gee (2005) theorized that language has two closely related functions: "to support the performance of social activities and social identities, and to support human affiliation within cultures, social groups and institutions" (p. 1). Gee claimed that language is political in the sense that language is the means by which social goods are thought about, argued over, and distributed in a society (2005, p. 2). The key thinking tools that Gee (2005) added to the analysis of spoken language are: a) the difference between big "D" and little "d" discourse, b) socially situated identities and meanings, c) what language makes significant, d) reflexivity, and e) grammar.

Gee (2005) differentiated between big "D" and little "d" discourse. Big "D" Discourse is used "as a way of combining and integrating language, actions, interactions, ways of thinking, believing, valuing, and using various symbols, tools, and objects to enact a socially recognizable identity" (p. 21). Little "d" discourse is the speech in the moment, what is being said. Socially situated identities are defined by Gee as "different ways of participating in different sorts of social groups, cultures, and institutions, for example a 'good student'" (2005, p. 22). This leads to the first three questions: a) What discourses are being enacted, and for what end or purpose?; b) What is being made

significant and insignificant through the use of the discourse?; c) Who and what are being created, described, and explained, and to what end?

Gee (2005) claimed that words gain their meaning from the context in which they are used (p. 22). Gee's socially situated meaning is clearly linked to Vygotsky's concept of the inexhaustible problems with words. An example of situated meaning can be exemplified with the word "apple." Apple can refer to a computer, a fruit, a child's name, and/or temptation/and sin. Words needs context to gain significance and meaning. The thinking questions which guide the analysis are: a) what and how are words being enacted, and for what and whose purpose? and b) From what contexts do words draw their meaning?

Reflexivity refers to the idea that "language simultaneously reflects reality, and constructs it to be a certain way" (Gee, 2005, p. 97). The guiding question that is raised by reflexivity is: How does a person construct reality, and through one's construction, what is made possible and impossible? A closely related question is: What are the consequences of a person's socially constructed world, both for herself and others?

"Grammatical resources are used by speakers and writers to design their sentences and texts in ways that communicate their perspectives on reality, and carry out various social activities, and allow them to enact different social identities" (Gee, 2005, p. 5). For example, the convention within the English language is to put the subject first, so when a teacher constructs a sentence in which we place something in front of the sentence such as, "In my classroom, I never allow students to use foul language," the phrase "in my classroom," functions as a background context which modifies the teacher's sentence. In

this case, it would lead one to assume that other teachers in the building allow students to use foul language in their rooms (Gee, 2005).

Gee's (2005) discourse analysis approach expands my methodological approach by providing key guiding questions which will provide insight into what is made significant and insignificant through discourse, and how this affects meaning-making, the distribution of social goods, and the creation of socially situated identities. I will draw on the work of Fairclough (2003) to expand the analysis to include written text and the reproduction of the ideology of globalization.

Fairclough (2003) extended past Gee's (2005) concept of political language by situating the analysis of discourse within the social-political critique of neoliberalism policies and in particular, the struggle over meaning-making, the social effects of texts, the universal status of particular discourses, and the ideologies embedded within the discourses.

Neoliberalism involves:

> the 're-structuring' of the relationship between economic, political, and social domains, (including the commodification and marketization of fields like education - it becomes subject to the economic logic of the market), and the 're-scaling' of relationships between the different levels of social life- the global, the regional (e.g. European Union), the national and the local. (Fairclough, 2006, p. 4)

The result of this process is a closing of public debate, the weakening of democracy and democratic ideals, and the commodification of all public spaces. The clear question that arises from this is: What does this struggle have to do with high school drop-outs? I

believe there is not only a clear connection to students who struggle within school, but a connection to all students within public education. First, as schools yield market forces, the curriculum shifts from supporting students in developing a critical understanding of their local and global world to one in which students are sorted by their future potential as workers. As such, the system needs drop-outs to fill the lower-wage jobs. Secondly and closely related, the teaching of civil responsibility and how to participate within a democracy is omitted, while the values of capitalism and free-trade are lauded. Democracy needs critical participation to fulfill its promise, and currently, within the structure of public education in New York State, all students, but especially those deemed at-risk are not being prepared to fully participate within a democracy. This weakens democracy. Fairclough's (2003) framework will provide the ability to widen my discourse analysis by including the concepts of: intertextuality, nominalization, the ideological work of the text, and how the grammatical relations between clauses and sentences assist in developing meaning. Similar to Gee's contributions, as opposed to detailing particular techniques and how they will be used, each of Fairclough's concepts will be explained, and I will extend the concepts to guiding questions for my analysis.

Fairclough (2003) defined intertexuality as the "use of others' texts, words, thoughts and ideas within one's own language use" (p 17). The concept of intertexuality is clearly linked to Bakhtin's (2006) claim that each utterance is filled with echoes of other utterances. The concept of intertexuality leads to the following guiding questions: What other voices are being enacted and to what end within the text, or speech? By indexing different language systems and references, how does this provide insight into

the access that one has to language systems? What ideologies and values are brought into the text and speech, and how do they provide support for claims that are made?

Nominalization is the representation of processes in the world as noun-like entities as opposed to the process (Fairclough, 2003, p. 13). Nominalization changes processes (verbs) to nouns, allowing for the agents of the process to remain hidden (Fairclough, 2003, p. 13). The classification of drop-outs does just this: it hides the educational system's practices and policies which support dropping out and shifts the entire focus onto the student, so that a student becomes a drop-out.

Fairclough (2003) argued that contemporary social sciences are heavily influenced by social constructivism- a claim that the world is socially constructed (p. 8). He argued that:

> these theories are idealistic rather than realistic, as a realist would hold that while the social world is socially constructed, once constructed, this construction both constrains and construes both the individual and the institution themselves to the confines of the certainty of the realities that have been constructed. (Fairclough, 2003, p. 8)

Fairclough claimed that written texts are representative artifacts of the socially-constructed world, and as such, they have causal effects on people's lives. They bring about changes in knowledge, beliefs, attitudes, and values. Also embedded within text is the ideological work of the text which works to universalize particular meanings in the service of achieving and maintaining certain dominance (2003, p. 58). "Ideologies are representations of the world which can be shown to contribute and to maintain social relationships of power dominance and exploitation (Fairclough, 2003, p. 9). The guiding

questions for analysis which are raised are: a) How is the person constructing and construing the world and their position within the world? and b) What ideologies do they evoke and how do these ideologies position themselves in relation to other people and groups?

Fairclough (2003) provided a detailed description of a variety of different analytical tools to explore the semantic relationship between sentences and clauses. The aim of my methodological approach is not to provide a set means of analysis, but instead to frame guiding questions that frame the analysis of written and spoken language. Fairclough (2003) suggested the following relationships exist between clauses and sentences: a) reason-because; b) consequence-so; c) purpose-in order to; d) conditional-if-then; e) temporal-time; and f) additive (p. 83). Fairclough's tools for understanding the semantic relationship between sentences and clauses, provides the tools for a micro-level analysis, which can provide evidentiary warrant for the claims made at the macro-level.

Gee (2005) and Fairclough (2003) clearly drew their ideas from a similar theoretical framework as my own: thus their work allows for a context from which to frame questions for this study, as well as provides for another line of inquiry.

Critical discourse analysis is one technique that is used within a multifaceted methodological approach within this dissertation which also implements grounded theory, metaphor analysis, and narrative analysis. These techniques and methodological approaches are used for two ends. All methods refract, as opposed to reflect a phenomenon; therefore one of the tasks of a researcher is to see the refraction of the phenomenon in as many ways that she can, within the constraints of a given inquiry; henceforth the first warrant for the use of a multifarious methodological approach is to

establish points of rejection which can be use to triangulate the data. Stake (1995) used the analogy of a sea captain, who every morning and every evening measured the angle of elevation of the different stars, and then from each of the stars' angle of elevation, he was able to determine the location of the ship as the ship sat at the intersections of the lines of elevation. In a similar manner, researchers need to ensure that their inquiry into a phenomenon is from many different points.

Secondly this dissertation will provide a new insight into an old problem, and as such, seeks to disorient the reader. This disorientation is similar to de Bolla (2003) who described individuals' uncomfortable responses to Barnett Newan's painting, *Vir Heroicus Sublimis*. This discomfort stemmed from the need of the viewer to scale him/her to the painting due to its sheer size. One of the effects of this work is that the painting views the individual looking at the painting as much as the individual views the painting. The rescaling for the reader in the case of this research is for the reader to be able to move herself from her current understanding of the predictive factors that lead to non-graduation to understanding the negotiation of participants within and outside of school and the implications of this negotiation. The rescaling and re-norming from stable predictive factors that are centered within the child to the fluid negotiation of the self, others, and the world in which the reader may see him/herself within the participants' narratives, and as analogous to *Vir Heroicus Sublimis*, the reader is seen by the dissertation as much dissertation is seen by the person as each of us negotiates for significance within our interactions.

Autobiographical Analysis/Identity

The three key areas of analytical focus that I explored were: positioning, turning points, and voicing. These a priori codes drawn were drawn from my literature review, and consistent with a constructivist grounded theory, I used these concepts as sensitizing codes. Prior to exploring these areas, I will first begin by defining the concept of identity.

> People do not possess one identity related to the social categories to which they belong, rather they present and re-present themselves, choosing within an inventory of more or less compatible identities that intersect and/or contrast with each other in different ways and in accordance with changing social circumstances and interlocutors. (de Finna, 2006, p. 353)

Choosing to define identity in this manner leads to the question of why this conceptualization of identity, and not another? This definition is most in-line with my theoretical position, which is, as de Finna suggested, that identity is both an internal and an external construction. This is indicated by the word inventory which connotes a storage facility: i.e. the mind. This construction of identity stands in contrast to that proposed by Benwell & Stokoe (2006) who stated that: “identity is a public phenomenon, a performance or construction that is interpreted by other people” (p. 4). The moving of identity solely to a public space eliminates the internal world and meaning making. The conception of identity as: internal, external, and held within the interacted space in-between individuals leads me to conclude, as Schiffrin (2006) did, that identity constructions are fragile constructions, and that throughout our lives we re-story our lives (Mishler, 2006); thus identities are not stable enduring traits, instead they are ever-

changing and shifting as we continue through life. We are much like Harold in "Harold and the Purple Crayon:" we are always drawing the next page as we approach it, and the page is drawing us at the same time. This raises the analytical questions of: a) Why is this identity being presented, and to what end?; and b) What does this identity mean for this individual?

Autobiographical narratives provide a context with which to expand these initial questions. As narrators express and manage multiple, partly contradictory selves and experiences, they do so by taking a position in relation to people, events, and objects within their narrative (Wortham, 2001). Positioning self in relation to others expands the concept of the identity which is being presented by exploring the relationships that exist or are established between oneself and the world. One manner in which this positioning is accomplished is through the use of other voices. The notion of voices is linked directly to Bakhtin (1981). Voicing can be accomplished by: a) referencing- fitting individuals within the narrative into social types; b) metapragmatic descriptors- providing voice through the use of verbs to describe the speech act- "John lied,"; c) quotation- directly quoting others- "John said,"; d) evaluative indexicals- ways of speaking for a particular group- "Hey Dude,"; and e) epistemic modalization-the viewpoint of the storyteller (Wortham, 2001, p. 73). An element of identity construction is to explain the relationship between oneself and the world; this is done by the narrator in how she positions herself within the story and describes the relationship between herself and the world.

The last analytical tool is the exploration of turning points within narratives. A turning point is a sudden event(s) that results in shifting one's conception of self (Mishler, 2006). These shifts are of particular interest as within my study I intended to

explore the transitional space between being an unsuccessful student to that of a successful student as well as to explore students' concepts of themselves as students.

Another concept that was developed within the theorization of language was the notion that language and discourse are a strategy of power. In the next section, I will explore a second line of inquiry, that of critical discourse analysis.

Metaphors

The final aspect of language-in-use that I will explore is that of metaphors. "The essence of a metaphor is understanding and experiencing one kind of thing in terms of another" (Lakoff & Johnson, 2003, p. 5). The intention of including an analysis of metaphors was two-fold. First and foremost, it provided a point of triangulation, and secondly it provided the ability to understand the subjective knowing of participants. As Lakoff and Johnson (2003) noted:

> metaphor is one of the most important tools for trying to comprehend partially what cannot be comprehended totally: our feelings, aesthetic experiences, moral practices, and spiritual awareness. These endeavors of the imagination are not devoid of rationality; since they use metaphor, they employ an imaginative rationality. (p. 193)

The analysis of metaphors was an essential tool as the metaphors provided insight into how each student constructed his/her world within and outside of school. A powerful metaphor for students was that the alternative high school was "like a family." This metaphor provided the linguistic space for students to relate to teachers as "a second father, or like a brother," and it allowed students to explore the idea that they were "cared for." The analysis of the metaphors led me to conducting a literature review on

attachment theory, as my own understanding of the participants' use of the metaphors indicated that the element the metaphor elucidated was the need to be significant and cared for, and the element that was obfuscated by the metaphor was that the participants were expressing the feeling of being insignificant. This became increasingly clear during the analysis of a participant whom had graduated from the Alternative High School two years prior to the interview, as she recalled how important it was that we took her places (a reference to field experiences outside of the school), and that we celebrated everyone's birthday (with cake and ice cream) and that her feeling was that we "really cared." After two years of high school, some of her most salient experiences were that we celebrated not her birthday, but every person's birthday, suggesting that what was not said was that her birthday was not celebrated outside of school. The cake and ice cream are concrete representations of the feeling of being significant; thus not only did they fill one's stomach, but one's soul. The feeling of significance still reverberates within the recesses of her being.

Grounded Theory

The final line of inquiry is grounded theory. I will draw from the work of Charmaz (2006), and Strauss and Corbin (1998). Within my study, grounded theory involves the coding of transcribed interviews with the students. This inquiry provides another line with which to understand student experiences. There are four levels to coding the data. The first is coding line by line: in this coding, each line is coded. The focus of this coding will be on action words, feelings, thoughts, and the student's own words. The next level involves exploring how the codes that developed relate to each other. At this level, the aim is to develop categories. The next step is explaining the

relationship between the categories. The final level is developing a rich understanding of the phenomenon. Charmaz (2006) noted that this process involves both imagination, and a willingness to allow the codes and theory to emerge from the data. There are three criteria that need to be met to provide for the context in which theory can emerge. They are to ensure: a) theoretical sampling, b) the saturation of categories, and c) a process of continuous movement between data, analysis, and the collection of data. Theoretical sampling ensures that the categories that are developed are robust, and that they are grounded within sufficiently rich data. The saturation of a category is established when new data provides no additional insights. As Charmaz noted, "the logic of Grounded Theory entails going back to data and forward into analysis" (2006, p. 23). The grounded theory line of analysis provides for the global perspective. Within this study, grounded theory speaks to the other lines of inquiry in such a manner to make each of the lines of inquiry more robust, and rich. In the previous section, I have provided a theoretical explanation of the methodological approach. In the next section, I will ground the study within a particular time, place, and context.

Demographics

The setting of the study is within an alternative high school that is situated within a cooperative education service agency within the western region of New York State. This cooperative services agency is a cooperative of 25 local school districts that purchase educational services through the cooperative so as to meet their individual and collective educational needs as a region. The cooperative serves a four-county area that is 2,747 square miles, and it serves rural, suburban, and small city school districts. The alternative high school that is the focus of this study has two campuses and its current

enrollment is 77 students for the 2008-2009 school year. During the previous six school years, 150 students have graduated with New York State High School diplomas. The rate of graduation for this program is at 90%. The current school years' senior class consists of 25 seniors. For the 2008-2009 school year 71% percent of students enrolled within the program are eligible for free and/or reduced lunch.

The program webpage indicates that the program emphasizes caring relationships between students and staff, experiential learning, service learning, and the ethos of care. The program explicitly teaches students behaviors and values via a rubric and through having one common set of expectations, which is consistently reinforced for all students.

I am familiar with the school, as I have been the principal of this school for eight years. This factor will influence the study, and is the primary rationale for why the study focuses its attention on students who have graduated from the program, and who are current seniors. It was assumed that a power-over relationship as principal over students would not be as prevalent with students who have graduated, and for seniors, my conjecture was that the power-over relationship would be less prevalent than with non-seniors as these students would be soon transitioning to roles outside of school. After the analysis of the data, it is my conclusion that there existed a power-over relationship, which was not based on the hierarchical nature of schools, but rather on the relationship with the students that was developed while they were enrolled. This relationship, which will be explained in greater depth later, provided the basis for narratives that allowed for the sharing of deeply personal lived experiences.

Each research project and therefore each researcher must struggle between the ideal and the practical. The two factors that constrained the dissertation were

reasonability and do-ability. I was a graduate student with no external funding source to complete the project, and my own financial situation required that I remain employed full time as I completed this proposed research project: these factors constrained the scope and nature of the dissertation.

To fully answer the questions that framed this dissertation, I structured the study as an instrumental collective case study design. Stake (1995) defined an instrumental collective case study as a case study in which the object is to understand something else other than this particular case (p. 3). At the conception of the study, a complete case was considered to consist of three interviews: two with the youth and one with the caregiver of the youth, as well as a review of the participant's cumulative school record. Within the study, there were a total of 17 students, and 5 parent participants. Fifty-six percent of the participants were eligible for free or reduced lunch at the time of the study. Of the 17 students, 9 participated within both interviews. Of the 9 that participated within two interviews, 7 were students who were currently enrolled within the program. There existed only three complete case studies. Each of the student participant's voices and lived experiences were used in Chapter 4 as part of the grounded theory analysis. Within Chapter 5, the three complete case studies will be used to understand the development of self.

Participation within the study was sought through a mailing that outlined the nature of the proposed study, the expected outcomes of the proposed study, and what would be expected from each participant. The study required that the participants' high school experiences were still relevant; and as such, the focus of the proposed study was limited to the two previous senior classes and last year's senior class. The pool of

possible participants was 75 students. The response rate was 22%. There were 7 female participants and 10 male participants. There were 16 White participants and one African-American participant. The alternative high school at which the study took place is predominantly a school that enrolls students who are considered to be and/or are classified as “White.” The African-American participant was the only African-American graduate of the high school.

The reason for the three year window was that each group of seniors offered a different perspective. Last year’s seniors were in the process of graduating from school; therefore their understanding and meaning-making process of school was still ongoing. The group of seniors that graduated the previous year were one year removed from high school and had begun new endeavors and this offered a perspective of high school experiences which were still relevant, but may not be prominent; therefore the study would be able to analyze how high school experiences affected students as they entered the world of work, and/or post-secondary training. The group of students that graduated two years prior would be the most removed from high school and offered a reflective look back on what it meant to them at the time of the study. Each of these groups offered a different perspective on the questions that frame this study. As such, the structure of the study provides a richness and depth to the data as the meaning making processes of high school experiences were examined at different stages within participants’ lives. The majority of the participants 47% were current seniors; the other participants were evenly distributed over the previous two years: 23% had graduated in the school year prior, and 29% graduated two years prior to the study. The distribution of student participants

across years away from graduating from high school appears to have provided the intended outcome of providing different perspectives on graduating.

Interviews

Initial student interviews were autobiographical. Student participants were asked to provide an account of their life story beginning with their earliest memory and continuing throughout their lives. Participants were told that it is often easier to reconstruct one's experiences within and outside of school by thinking of life in chapters (early childhood, school years, middle school, and high school). As participants shared their lived experiences, I queried them on expressions and concepts that appeared particularly meaningful to students' conceptions of themselves, the world or others. After I completed five interviews, I transcribed them and analyzed them from a grounded theory perspective to sensitize myself to major themes that were presented. The initial five interviews were shocking, for each of the interviews recounted stories of violence (rape, molestation, and abandonment), some of the narratives began with the caveat that the participant "had never told anyone this." One participant, in the midst of retelling of an abusive relationship with her father, stopped to confirm that I would not share this information with her parents, because "nobody knows." I was overwhelmed both by the violence, and by the weight that these students had been carrying around. Had nobody cared enough to listen, or did the students never feel safe enough to share? If these narratives of violence, neglect and abuse came forth with such force and frequency, how many other students experienced this, and "never told anyone?" The study's thirdspace framework seemed trivial and insignificant, and it would not be until months later that I would be able to analyze the data. Probably, and retrospectively, I first needed to

experience the study and then analyze the data, which is congruent with the framework of this study. While the questions I posed were not within the scope of the study, I was and am deeply committed to sharing their narratives, so as to provide an account of the pain and violence these students experienced and to provide a space for their silent voices to be heard. Perhaps, and realistically, a very few will read this research. Despite this, I hold steadfast that one purpose for completing this dissertation is to allow these participants' voices to be heard, and hopefully to scream off the pages. I am not all that sure that scientific research, with its rules and style requirements, is particularly open to this notion, but similar to my participants I will attempt to live within the rules without forgetting the purpose.

In retrospective, this dissertation had three phases: the first phase was experiencing the interviews, being plagued by the overwhelming violence, and wondering: why so much pain? The second phase was also highlighted by a search to answer the questions around: why so much pain and violence? The answers to these questions framed the additional literature review, and my analysis. The third and final phase was conformity, which focused on meeting the standards for publication, which was a slow and painful process onto itself.

To this end, after the first interviews, I developed the second interview protocol which was a semi-structured interview format that was conducted to further explore themes brought up by participants within the first interview. After transcription of the first five interviews, I then completed the second interview with the first five participants. Over a two month period, I conducted the rest of the interviews. Throughout the study, for student participants whose caregiver volunteered to participate, I conducted the first

interview with the student, then after this, I interviewed the caregiver and then I conducted the second interview with the student (which was the third interview). I completed the analysis of the review of the school records after all interviews were completed.

After all interviews had been transcribed, I then conducted line-by-line coding of six participants which sensitized me to salient themes. I then conducted a review of the literature and completed both the line-by-line coding of the rest of the transcripts and the development of categories and themes. This analysis led to the development of Chapter 5, which focuses on the effects of social rejection within students' lives and Chapter 6, which focuses on the construction of self.

Conclusion

In this chapter, I have elucidated a methodological approach that is not only consistent with my theoretical framework, but also speaks to it. I have argued for a position in which there exist multiple truths, selves, and sciences, and that the field of language is a field that is sufficient for scientific inquiry. I have further argued that language is not only a means to understand the world and one's relationship to it, but also that language is a strategy of power, and that as much as it elucidates, it obfuscates, and that part of the strategy of power is to have language appear neutral, as opposed to a contested field.

I have outlined several different lines of inquiry that include: critical discourse analysis, autobiographical narrative, metaphors as a meaning-making tool, and grounded theory. Each of these was outlined not as a set of procedures but as tools of inquiry that can be applied to emerging topics and themes. I then grounded the study within a

particular, time, place, and context. In the next chapter, I argue for a particular theory, one which elucidates youth's struggle for significance.

Chapter Four

The Struggle for Significance

Introduction

This chapter argues for a grounded theory which provides a robust and rich explanation to the three questions which frame this dissertation: a) How and in what ways did participants negotiate and construct meaning about self, others, and the world?; b) How did these constructions and the meaning-making process situate the participants within and outside of school, and what implications does the students' negotiation process have for school?; c) What in the context of an alternative high school provided the context for students to renegotiate their understanding of self, others, and the world? The theory that was argued for was that participants within this study have experienced a series of rejections; the primary rejection being from either one or both of the parents and then they experienced rejection from peers, and educators/school. During their life span, this series of rejections positioned the participants within a struggle between significant (life) and insignificant (death). Non-completion of high school was constructed by participants as a terminal state (death). The participants initially negotiated for significance with their parents with whom they were socially positioned as having little power or influence over the rejection. As the participants entered school and experienced peer rejection within peer negotiations, either they withdrew from the negotiations or participants used power which in many cases was violence to negotiate relationships with peers and adults. Their use of violence was a rejection of others and self, and appeared to be rooted both in their early relationship to their parent(s), and a base level of negotiation (use of violence). As they failed within school, graduation from high school became less

likely, and eventually it was constructed as “death.” Participants negotiated self through a life and death framework. It was within the space of living (family) within the alternative high school that provided participants with the ability to become significant, and thus, for participants who graduated, this significance provided them with the ability to begin to shape a new understanding of self, others, and the world.

The space of negotiation between life/death is aligned with the critical thirdspace framework as living (seeking significance) was experienced at the exact same moment of experiencing death (insignificance); for to live, one must at the same moment be dying, and it is within this thirdspace of and/both that we color our experiences. In addition, it is the bending of the living and dying framework that provided the participants with the ability to renegotiate previous rejections, and to recreate a future that while was still undefined, was no longer terminal.

This theory is grounded within the language that participants used, as well as within research. The two areas of research within this chapter that grounded participants’ experiences are attachment theory, and peer rejection. The process of analysis is represented within figure 1. The theory which is argued for in this chapter is presented in a manner consistent with figure 1. I first provided a description of each of the categories. Then I provided an analysis of the three axial codes, after which, I argued for the struggle for significance theory and its implications. This analysis also included how the grammar of school (homework, grades, and discipline) was an integral element within the negotiation for significance within school. The analysis of the grammar of school (implicit norms) aligned this dissertation within a critical framework.

4.1 Struggle for significance.

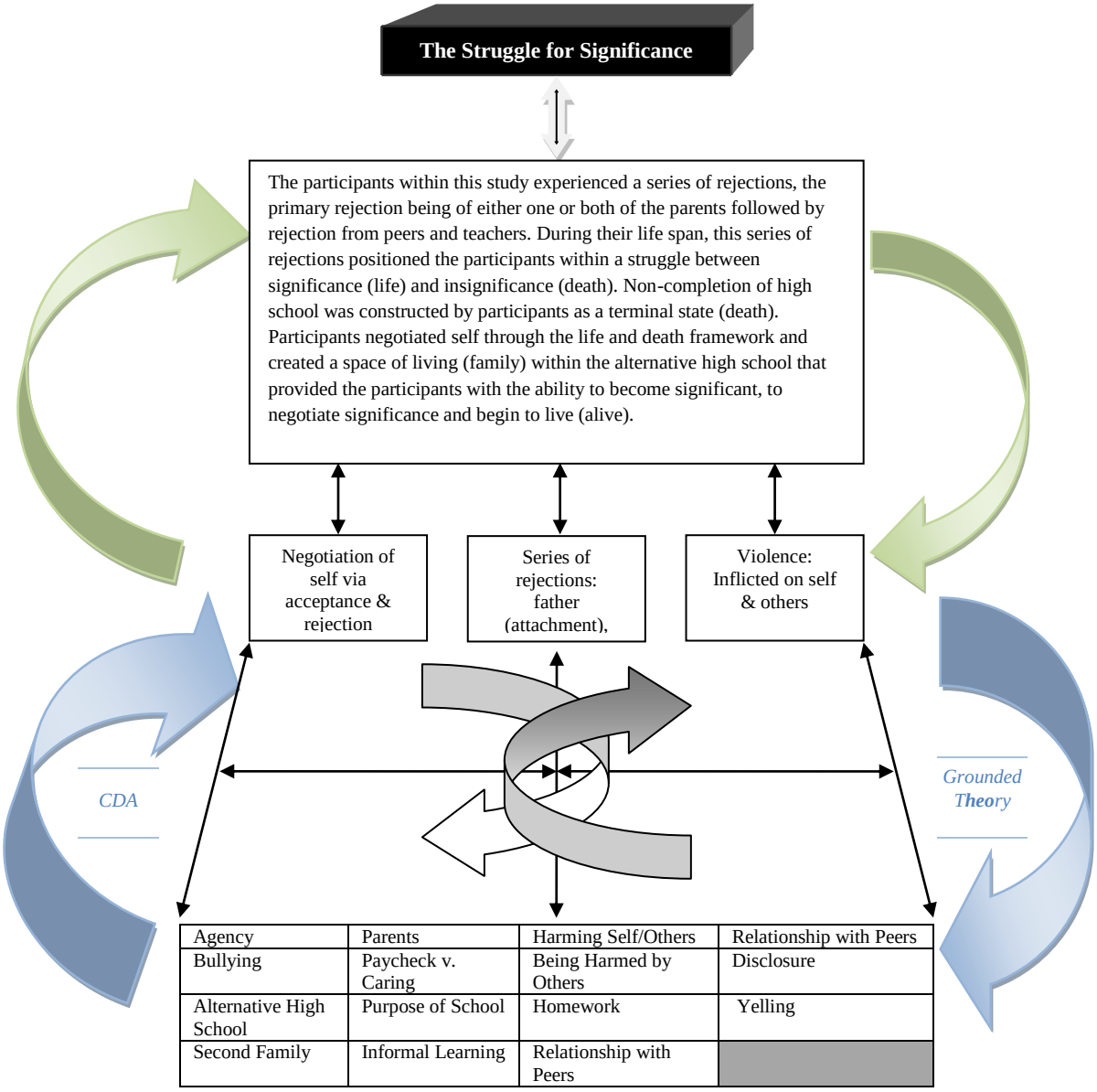

Figure 1. Struggle for Significance. Figure 1 demonstrates how the struggle for significance theory was developed.

First a definition and the description of the categories (in vivo codes) are provided. Then the axial codes that were developed are defined, and then a description of each of the three axial codes and how they were lived by students is provided. The theory

of a struggle for significance will be argued, based on the interrelationships between each of the categories, and the three theoretical codes. Critical discourse analysis was implemented as a tool to understand participants' individual negotiations, which bolstered and supported the struggle for significance theory. This argument design is consistent with the methodological approach of using macro and micro-analysis together to develop an understanding of how lived experience is constructed as meaningful narratives.

All negotiations imply power both as a means to achieve desired ends for those negotiating and as a means to reinforce the meanings and knowledge of those not present (those in power) in the negotiator's influence over the outcome. As critical discourse analysis is sensitive to the concept of power, this is used for the micro analysis. The negotiation, which is central within this study, is the negotiation of the intentional arc. Merleau-Ponty (2007) described the intentional arc as:

> the life of the consciousness-cognitive life, the life of desire, or perpetual life is subtended by an 'intentional arc' which projects round about us our past, our future, our human setting, our physical, ideological, and moral situation, or rather which results in our being situated in all these respects. It is this intentional arc which brings about the unity of the senses, of intelligence, of sensibility, and motility. And it is this which 'goes limp' in illness. (p. 157)

Students are waged in a struggle with self, others and the world against the atrophying of their intentional arc, and this struggle is the essence of this study.

Categories

The categories were developed after I had completed line-by-line coding. Then categories were developed based on grouping the line-by-line coding into broader ideas/concepts. The categories were then grounded back to the participants' language through linking the coding by category/theme to the participants' utterances. Table 3 provides each category, a definition of the category, and then an example of the category from the participants.

Table 3

Ground theory categories.

Name of Category	Definition	Example
Agency	A behavior in which participants engage in a thoughtful choice in how to respond to self, others, and the world.	"If you are going to call me a name, at least I have the ability to pick the name." -In reference to choosing to be called "lazy" over "trying and looking dumb."
Bullying	An incident in which a participant was socially embarrassed by peers or adults in which the person saying or doing something had the intent of demonstrating power over the participant for some measure of control.	"He would call me and my sisters whores when it's like we hadn't even kissed a guy before" -In reference to her father. "He was very cruel. He use to make me cry all the time. He use to cut himself in front of me."
Alternative High School	The school which is the context for the study.	"We call this place the island, because. . . it's like Rudolph and the Red-Nosed Reindeer with the Island of Misfit toys. Those were the best toys, coolest toys of all. They just like didn't fit."
Second Family	A phrase participant used to describe their position within the alternative high school.	"I think most people here, like students and teachers will joke around and like you fight with them sometimes, but we all know everyone is pretty much there for each other."

Name of Category	Definition	Example
Parents	Participant's description of a parent.	"My earliest childhood memory- probably when my dad left the house- he was always hurting my brothers."
Paycheck v. Caring	A phrase used by a participant in a describing the difference between alternative teachers and home school teachers.	"Uh, even when I was talking to people it didn't seem like they cared. They were just evaluating me. They were not understanding me." "Like the teachers actually spend time with you. You can actually have a conversation and discussion about what you are dealing with."
Purpose of School	The participant's description of the value of learning within school.	"You learn it and as soon as you take the test, that says you're done with it, it, it's gone. You don't ever use it again. It's like, 'Then what's the point of learning it?'"
Harming Self/Others	An account of either harming self or others.	"So, me and her and Jody became like best friends and we went to do coke like every day." "I just fight bigger people. It gives me an adrenalin rush. I ran up to him and I broke his nose." "I tried to electrocute myself with a blow dryer in the bathtub, and it did not work for me."
Being Harmed by Others	An account of harm that was done to the participant by others.	"It wasn't mostly wedgies. It was usually physical things like ya know push me off a bleacher or something like that. I ended up bloody and battered or bruised coming home."
Homework	School work that was assigned by school to be completed at home.	"Home is home and school is school. I go home all I wanna do is just relax and ya know? I have nothing to worry about anymore. . . I just don't wanna worry about that stuff when I'm on my break."
Disclosure	When a participant shares within the interview an episode of which few are aware or which has not been shared with others.	"I never told anyone this."

Name of Category	Definition	Example
Yelling	Participants describe conflict with teachers and the teacher yelling at them.	"Like I was in his class, and I was giving him attitude because I didn't do my homework and he's like, 'Well, you need to do your homework.' He started yelling at me and I was like: 'I don't have ta do shit for you.' And I started swearing and he was like; 'You're just another (last name)! You're going nowhere!'"
Relationship to Peers	A description of acceptance or rejection by peers.	"They didn't really acknowledge me. Just whenever I would talk they, you know they just ignored me." "But, I was really in a group. We were just like. . . bitches, but I was a bitch because I learned from my sister."
Informal Learning	An account of learning outside of the classroom, which was part of experience at the alternative high school.	"I got to go somewhere else and see what else is out there and it kinda just opened my eyes. Where like ya know, I can get out of this town and go see everything, ya know? I do not have to sit here and see the same thing every day." "Some of the field trips were really cool like when we went to the airport that was like, wow! I had never been to an airport before. Like I seen 'em in the movies and stuff like that. But I'd never actually been to one. Never really realized how huge those planes were."

The next step of the analysis was developing the connections between the categories. This led to the formation of axial codes, which are defined as "fitting the pieces of the data puzzle together" (Strauss & Corbin, 1998, p. 229). I questioned: what is the puzzle I am putting together? After analyzing the categories, it became clear that the participants' narratives were about their "intentional arc." Merleau-Ponty's concept of the intentional arc, a centralization of and unifying of the data had two effects. First, it

pushed and expanded the framework past the bounds of critical theory to a phenomenological framework, and within the analysis of language, it linked the study back to Bakhtin's concept of decentralization, of unification and disunification of language. The development of the three axial codes represents the centralizing force of language. With the development and description of the centralizing codes, there is an understanding that as much as these codes centralize the narratives of the participants, there is an equal force of decentralization. While the decentralization of language would be an interesting study, that is not the aim of this study. Instead it focuses on the development of a central theory.

The next section will focus on the three axial codes. The axial codes were developed, and then grounded within two areas of research: attachment theory and peer rejection. The three axial codes were grounded within attachment theory and peer rejection since this body of scientific knowledge provides insight into the effects of rejection and acceptance within participants' relationships to others.

Data Corpus

The data corpus for this chapter consists of 17 autobiographical student interviews, and nine semi-structured interviews that were designed as a follow-up to the first interviews, and were intended to explore themes that were presented within the first interviews. All of the interviews were transcribed, except for one, which could not be transcribed due to a recording error. At the time of transcription, each of the participants was assigned a single name. Within this thesis, participants are only referenced by this pseudonym. There were seven females and 10 males. Of the 17 participants, 16 were White and one was African-American. The participants within the study were a

representative sample of the graduates and non-graduates from the previous three years. The range of years in the program was .5 school years to five years, with students being enrolled at the alternative high school for an average of 1.8 years. No students who had attended the alternative high school and who did not complete high school responded from a letter solicitation. As a means to include the negative case, the additional step of seeking participation by these students within the study via phone calls was taken; no phone calls were returned. A potential participant who had recently (within six months of the onset of the study) left the school without graduating began the practice of picking up his girlfriend at the school. Initially, he waited in his car within the school parking lot and called her to come out to the car. Eventually he started entering the school after I went to the car and spoke with him and indicated that I would prefer that he enter the building to pick up his girlfriend. During the course of the study, we spoke about his possible participation within the study. He stated that he would participate, but on the two different established dates, he did not report. After the second missed appointment, he again began the practice of picking up his girlfriend, but from this point forward, he remained on the public road outside of the school as he waited. One of the participants did not meet the New York State requirements to graduate, but at the time of the interviews, she anticipated that she would graduate. So while she could be considered a "negative case," at the time of the interviews, the event of "not graduating" had not occurred.

Attachment

As has been argued previously, we understand ourselves in relation to others; the extension of this argument is that there is a basic human need to be in relation with

others. Within the data corpus of this dissertation's theoretical assertion that we understand ourselves in relation to others is that in each of the autobiographical narratives, the construct of the self, others, and the world is done with the participants as the foreground, and the others and the world as the background which allowed for the construct of the self in relation to others. For example: "growing up nobody wanted to help me." The foreground is the participant needing help, while the world and others are background as they are unable or unwilling to meet the needs of the participant. This relationship to others of needing help, love, and guidance and not receiving it provides a means for participants within a world, and in relationship to others in which they come to understand that their needs will not be met; thus they are insignificant.

This concept of the need for attachment and acceptance from others is argued for within the field of psychology. For example, Fromm argued that "to feel completely alone and isolated leads to mental disintegration just as physical starvation leads to death" (2009, p. 15). Baumeister and Leary (1995) argued that belonging is a fundamental motivation based on the following: a) people need frequent personal contact; b) people form social relationships easily and in the absence of any special circumstances; c) people seem not to want to risk damaging relationships; d) breaking off relationships, even abusive relationships is painful; e) people's cognitive processes are deeply affected by relationships as is evident in that people interpret situations and events with regard to their implications for relationships; f) people who lack belongingness have high levels of mental health and physical illness; and g) being accepted leads to positive emotions, whereas being rejected leads to negative emotions. There exists no line of argument for the complete isolation of the self, but philosophers such as Schopenhauer

(2009) argued that the space of social interaction is fraught with danger and that relations to others is a delicate balance between the forces of rejection and acceptance.

> A number of porcupines huddled together for warmth on a cold day in winter; but as they began to prick one another with their quills, they were obliged to disperse. However the cold drove them together again, when just the same thing happened. At last, after many turns of huddling and dispersing, they discovered that they would be best off by remaining at a little distance from one another. In the same way the need of society drives the human porcupines together, only to be mutually repelled by the many prickly and disagreeable qualities of their nature. The moderate distance which they at last discover to be the only tolerable condition of intercourse is the code of politeness and fine manners. . .

In the context of the study, the participants' descriptions of their relationships to their parent(s), and in particular of their father's rejection was often characterized as violent and placed the participants as objects to their father. This objectification as well as cases in which participants were abandoned by their father, was constructed by participants as a rejection of themselves. As this relationship is the first negotiated relationship for participants, it provided the participants with a deep insight into how power influences the negotiations of relationships. The use of power to control others is the power of colonization. As Fanon noted, the need for "change exists in a raw, repressed, and reckless state in the lives and consciousness of colonized men and women (2004, p.1). This study aims to seek change: not in a voyeuristic exploitation of the lived experiences of the participants, but instead to use the raw, repressed, and at times reckless

state of their lives in order to seek this change. I implore the reader to respect the lived experiences shared within this chapter, and throughout this dissertation.

Attachment Theory

Attachment theory is grounded within the work of Bowlby (1998 and 1984) and Ainsworth and Bowlby (1991). Bowlby (1998 and 1984) held that the child's attachment to his mother was a result of the mother's response to the infant's needs. An infant whose mother responded with consistency and warmth to her infant learned to expect that his/her needs would be met; thus when separated from his/her mother, the infant would show distress and then calm and when reunited, would seek the mother again for comfort. Bowlby referred to this type of attachment as secure. Infants whose mother's responses were inconsistent would learn that they could not be sure if the mother would provide care; thus when separated from the mother, the infants would demonstrate distress, and when reunited with the mother, they would demonstrate avoidant behaviors such as approaching the mother, and not looking at her, and not being able to calmed by the mother. Bowlby termed this attachment as anxious/resistant. Mothers who did not respond to the infant or expected the child to take the role of parent, taught the child that their needs were not going to be met, and when separated from their mother, they would show no distress. When the mother came back, they would not acknowledge the mother's presence or they would behave in an angry manner. Bowlby termed this form of attachment as "anxious/avoidant." Bowlby argued that this relationship with the mother affected the type of attachment that the child and later the adult would be able to form. For example, a child who had an anxious/avoidant attachment to his mother within childhood could lead to an adult who denied the importance of close relationships.

Bartholomew (1997) and Bartholomew and Griffen (1994) expanded Bowlby's model of attachment by adding an additional type of attachment. Bartholomew and Griffen conceptualized attachment across two dimensions: self-concept and expectations of others. This created the four-by-four matrix presented as Figure 2.

SELF

OTHERS

Secure Positive self-concept and positive expectations of others	Preoccupied Negative self-concept and positive concept of others
Dismissing Positive self-concept and negative expectations of others	Fearful Negative self -concept and negative expectations of others

Figure 2. Attachment relationships.

According to Bartholomew (1997/1990), and Bartholomew and Griffen (1994), each attachment has its own characteristics. Secure attachments are typified by both a positive self-concept, and positive expectations that others will be supportive and available. These individuals have a secure base from which to explore, and they demonstrate a high level of autonomy and intimacy. Preoccupied individuals have a negative self-concept, but a positive image of others; thus they tend to seek and need a high level of approval from others, and they frequently become over-dependent on others. Dismissing individuals have a high positive self-concept, and negative expectations of others; thus they tend to devalue the importance of relationships, and place a high value on self-reliance. Carvallo and Gabriel (2006) concluded: "dismissing avoidant individuals

(despite their claims) possess a strong desire to be accepted by others. Thus, dismissive avoidants do not represent a counterexample" (p. 706) to the need to belong hypothesis. The fearful attachment type is characterized by a self-concept that they as individuals are unlovable, and others are uncaring.

In studying the nature of to whom young adults form attachment, Trinke and Bartholomew (1997) concluded that young adults were more likely to rely on family members, as opposed to friends as secure bases in distress (p. 604). They also indicated that young adults rated romantic partners "most highly as attachment figures followed by mothers, fathers, siblings, and best friends" (p. 619). It seems clear that the relationship to one's parents or caregivers does impact the development of social relationships outside of the family. Further evidence is noted both by Dutton, Saunders, Starzomski & Bartholomew (1994) who concluded "that anxious attachment is related to a variety of measures associated with a personality constellation of abusiveness in intimate relationships" (p. 1379) and by Twenge, Baumeister, Tice and Stucke (2001) who concluded that a suggestion to people within a laboratory environment that their future based on a bogus assessment was to be one which would be devoid of close friends and intimacy produced anger. There appears to be a link between attachment which provides a sense of belonging and that thwarting or denying this need produces anger. Prior to exploring this within peer relationships, I will provide an analysis of the types of attachments that were described within the context of the study. To be consistent with the aims of the study, and to ground the analysis, I will use the participants' own descriptions of their relationship with their parents.

The four types of relationships that were present were: a) biological father present - was abusive either psychologically, physically, or sexually, b) biological father was not present, and either no or conflictual relationship with step-father, who was present, c) conflicted relationship with biological father, and/or d) the mother is absent. These categories indicate significant criticism of attachment theory in that there is an exclusive focus on the mother, and that the father and his attachment to the child is left unexplored. I will now provide a description of each type of relationship. This study's finding suggests that the attachment theory may need to be re-analyzed to determine the father's role within attachment, the types of attachment that are provided , and to provide an understanding of how the father's relationship with the child positions the child in relation to the world, self, and others (dismissive, and fearful).

Within the first category: biological father is present and abusive, there were five female participants. I will focus on the father-daughter relationships which were based on sexual, physical and psychological abuse. Theresa (who is a White female) described her relationship to her father:

> And I just got totally like, my dad was reaming me out. It was every night until like two, three, four o'clock in the morning. Every single night except for on the weekends. So this Monday, well it'd be Sunday through Thursday, I be getting reamed out. Every night for something. And I wasn't allowed to look at him. I had to have my face down at the table. . . the only time my dad ever laid his hands on me to abuse me physically is he, now I had my face down at the table. You can't see if I rolling my eyes at you.

As she was speaking, she demonstrated this practice by placing her face towards the table.

> You cannot see if I'm rolling my eyes or blinking or you know, whatever. Well he is like, "You rolled your eyes." And he took the back of my head with his hand [demonstrating by placing her hand on her head] and he slap, smashed my face into the table. Bounced my face off the table. And I went to get up cause, I was done. I was sick of getting treated the way, like that. And I went up to get up and go to my room and he was like [now she leans forwards and is making intense eye-contact] "I swear to God, if you leave this table I will kill you." (Theresa)

Later in the interview, Theresa provided an account of her father raping her.

> So it started that summer. And it was disgusting. He use to say like God awful things to me. He would be like: "So your step-mother wants me to do this. Your step mom likes this. She been asking me to." And all I can do is lay there with tears are just rolling out of my, like out of eyes.

Theresa was looking away at this point, and fidgeting with her hands.

In addition Theresa's narrative provided accounts of additional abuse: Theresa recalled her father being "mentally abusive." When queried as to the nature of the abuse, she stated: "You're a piece of shit. You'll never amount to anything. Um, you're just like your mother."

Cecilia's account detailed a physical assault by her father.

> When we were around and I went over there by myself when I was a little bit older and he got really, really, really drunk one night and drove me home in the car drunk. And he ended up getting mad at me for something and he threw a

> bottle of liquor at me and I ran into my room, and called my mom at three o'clock in the morning to come get me. And he grabbed the phone from me after I called her and smashed it against my head and then hit me. And then my mom showed up 'cause she lived an hour and a half away.

For Cecilia, her relationship with her father was also one that included psychological abuse: "I was like eleven years old or somethin', not developed at all and he told that I looked like a whore in a two-piece bathing suit. And told me I had to cover up."

Ananta, in providing a description of her worst teacher, at the end of her description she stated that, "this teacher was so much like my dad. That's why I did not like him." When queried how, she stated:

> he had the same like ta do everything perfectly. If you're not doing it my way, I'm not happy with it. Um, I really don't understand what's going on with you and I really don't care. You're gonna do the same exact thing everyone else is capable of doing, I don't care.

Within her narrative account, she recalled coming home from school and having to sit for hours at the table doing homework, while tears came down her face. During the parent interview, the same teacher came up and her father could not understand why she did not like this teacher.

There was one special case included within this group of five cases: the woman's father passed away when she was three years of age, and then, in her account, her mother became involved with a new boyfriend and her mother and the boyfriend "locked themselves in their room and did drugs with my Dad's money"(Fionnula).

Within each of these relationships, the girls are positioned by their father, through his power as a parent, to become objects. These early relationships objectified these women as "worthless pieces of shit," sexual objects to be used, and objects for male anger. The early formation of social identity for these girls in relation to their father was that they were subjects to their fathers' caprice. The fathers' use of power over their daughters to get what they wanted in these relationships became part of the girls' constructed world in which they struggled against being objects for others. Through this negotiation, the participants learned to have little trust in others with power over them, and they themselves were situated within their relationships to their fathers as possessing little value. It would appear that these participants had formed a fearful attachment.

The next category is the non-present biological father, and either no relationship or a conflictual relationship with the step-father. There were eight participants within this category: seven males, and one female. Puck's account of his relationship with his biological father was typical of the responses within this category: "he left my mom, and had a bad relationship. They divorced early. . . since I was five, I had no relationship with him."

While Dylan indicated that his father "abandoned me," he stated that he remained connected to his father through their common last name. As Dylan explained:

> he is a "jerk" and "it's like everyone has all these expectations of me that I'm gonna be a bad person and like alcoholic like and all this crazy stuff. And it's like, I'm not like that at all. And it's just hard having to deal with all these expectations that people have that I am going to grow up and be just like him.

Faunus, in answering a direct question about the nature of his relationship to his father provided a typical response for this category:

> Not much of a relationship. He was there when I needed him to ask a question or something. But most of the time he was consumed by not even working anymore but ya know chores around the house or if I asked him if he just wants to do some'in simple, it has to be always big and important for him. Like ya know, a trip to New York City. He has to be involved with that. 'Do you want to go to the movies or something?' 'No, can't do that today. Got chores.'

Faunus' relationship indicated a passive rejection of the self by the father. There was a disinterest in an ongoing relationship with the child. This disinterest was constructed as "no relationship," which was constructed as a social reality of "I am not worthy of my father's attention," because he is doing something else more important. In this case, the rejection was based on the idea that "there are more important things than me." Of particular note: this category is more of a passive rejection as opposed to rejection through physical acts of violence, which was comprised of mostly male participants, whereas the acts of violence and objectification category consisted primarily of female participants. The findings of this study indicated that a father's rejection may be qualitatively different for sons and daughters. While females within this study were often rejected in an overtly violent manner, males may have experienced a more subtle form of rejection through which they became insignificant through the lack of meaningful interaction. An additional question raised from this finding which warrants further research is: do different types of rejections affect participants differently? The

experience of rejection for these participants suggests that their attachment would be dismissive.

There was one case in which the relationship that was described was characterized by conflict with biological father, and an ongoing, though distant relationship. Ajax described his Dad as:

> having diabetes and that he didn't take care of it, so he kinda struggle with his, uh behavior and sometimes he got angry. . . but nothing bad. He yelled, um. . . I guess over time I learned to cope with it and I kinda, it wasn't as bad as time progressed. I just got used to it.

Ajax learned to "cope with it," and then indicated "it wasn't as bad." Ajax's wish was that his parents would "get back together." His description of his relationship to his father and the rejection he felt was modified by his wish for the family to be "whole" again. His coping with it seems to be a manner in which Ajax managed his feelings of rejection when his father yelled at him. This is an example of the decentralization of language: as categories unify language, there is an equal force of disunity, which is congruent to thirdspace thinking.

The final category was that of the absent mother. There were two male participants within this category. Asher, in his narrative, recalled the last time he saw his mother:

> Well my first, like, my only memory from like I was really young was uh, was at a McDonald's and I was with my little brother and I was four at the time I think and he was one. And, uh, it was like that was where we would get dropped off to get picked up by our mom 'cause she has visitation rights. And one day she

> showed up like twenty minutes late and like, my dad and her were talking about someth'in. I couldn't remember, I do not what it's about. I just remember like my Dad said somethin' and he tried to get'in into his car, And like she grabbed him by the shoulder, turned him around and slapped him in the face. The cops were called. And that's the last I seen my mom. So it been thirteen years now, that I haven't seen her.

The participants' narratives indicated the significance of the relationship between a child and his parent. Of particular note is the negotiation of the father-child relationship and the significance that this negotiated relationship had within a child's development and understanding of self, others and the world. In this study, participants experienced insignificance either through the objectification of the self or through the absence of meaningful interactions with the father or mother. This negotiated self via the parent constructed a world in which others, particularly those with social power were not to be trusted nor relied upon. Attachment theory has focused on the significance of the mother-child relationship and how this relationship orients children to the world. It appears that the father's relationship to the child is just as significant and warrants further scientific inquiry.

Early relationships provide an orientation to the world outside oneself: they do not cast or destine a person for difficult development throughout life nor predetermine negative outcomes. The participants' orientation to the world that was established was that others cannot be trusted, and that power is used by those with higher social status to control, and/or manipulate others to get what they want. In the next section, this use of power to control others also has the effect of influencing participants to either withdraw

from the social negotiation of relationships or use violence against others as a means to negotiate social relationships. For participants, both of these means of negotiation led to peer and teacher rejection. Prior to exploring the students' lived experiences of rejection, in the next section, I will review the literature on peer rejection as a means to understand the effects of how social rejection influences the negotiation of self, others and the world.

Peer Rejection and Isolation

There exists an extensive body of literature on peer rejection, predominantly based within a social-cognition theory of human behavior. Social-cognition theories hold that an individual and the environment interact with each other and through this interaction a person attributes both to himself and others stable and predictable characteristics, which are then reinforced by the person's behavior, which are now guided by both his beliefs about himself and others. As Coie, et al., (1993) noted: "human behavior unfolds in the context of multiple systems of influence (family, school, peer, work, biological) that may have varying impact at different points of development" (p. 1016). Within this body of research, the most prevalent study design is to use a sociometeric measure in which children rate their peers on likeability (the peers they like the most, and the peers they like the least). Often teachers are asked to rate children on characteristics such as aggression or other variables of interest.

Dodge, et al., (2003) argued that social rejection is a chronically stressful event that warrants scientific inquiry since rejection can lead to social isolation which would prevent a child from practicing and developing her social skills; thus leading to negative expectations for future peer interactions, which would be consistently reinforced by the belief that rejection is more likely. Thus children respond with an increased rate of

reactive and proactive aggression which then limits their opportunities to practice and develop social skills. This creates a further lag in social skill development (p. 375). As the child ages, this can lead to other difficulties as within deviant peer groups, “the rejected, aggressive children were more peripheral members of these groups, making them more susceptible to deviant peer influence than more central members” (Miller-Johnson, Coie, Maumary-Gremaud, Bierman, 2002, p. 227) of the deviant group whom are not peer rejected, as the peripheral members seek to gain acceptance by the group through engaging in deviant behaviors.

Social rejection appears to be correlated with students who behave aggressively toward peers. “Human aggression is any behavior directed toward another individual that is carried out with the proximate (immediate) intent to cause harm” (Anderson & Bushman, 2002, p. 28). Children who possess aggressive behavior orientation often alienate peers, and are exposed to other risk factors and peer rejection (Ladd, 2006). Peer rejection appears to increase the level of aggressive behavior throughout development for children who are above the median in reactive aggression (Dodge et al. 2003). Ladd and Troop-Gordon (2003) concluded that a child’s early anxious and aggressive behaviors are linked to later forms of maladjustment. Support for this is evident in both Buhs, Ladd, and Herald (2006) which indicated that peer kindergarten ratings of high aggressiveness led to chronic peer abuse (aggressive and harassing behaviors) and that social withdrawal predicated chronic exclusion by peers (ignoring and avoiding behaviors), and from Miller-Johnson et al. (2002) who indicated that peer rejection in first grade contributed to subsequent conduct problems (p. 226). Social rejection is based on student behaviors: students who demonstrated elevated levels of aggression toward peers, or withdrawal

behaviors were placed at a greater risk for social rejection. When social rejection is experienced by these children with elevated levels of either aggression or social withdrawal behaviors, these experiences appear to be correlated with a host of negative outcomes such as further maladjustment, disengagement from the classroom, and the development of a cognitive belief that rejection by others is more likely. Hence, social rejection has an additive effect in which socially-rejected children are denied the ability to continue the ongoing negotiation of relationships with peers and as such, they lack a sense of belonging (significance) and the ability to improve upon the social negotiation of relationships, thus widening the space between the rejected child and his peers. (Buhs, Ladd, & Herald (2006); Coie, Terry, Lenox, Lochman, & Hyman, 1995; Dodge et al. 2003; Kupersmidt & Coie, 1990; Ladd, 2006; Ladd & Troop-Gordon, 2003; London, Downey, Bonica, & Paltin, 2007; Miller-Johnson et al. 2002; Sandstrom & Coie, 1999)

Within the context of this study, I will again turn to the participants' accounts of peer rejection and their own accounts of withdrawal from others or acts of aggressiveness toward others. Each of the participants told stories of peer rejection: fourteen of the seventeen participants discussed social exclusion, and three discussed either being both physically violent toward others, and/or others being physically violent toward them. I considered withdrawal behaviors to include both social disengagement and the use of prescription pain medication, cocaine, and marijuana, as the use of these drugs were described by participants as a way to escape. Regular and persistent use of drugs was included in two of the narratives- a 12% prevalence rate. It is my contention that drug use is frequently associated with students who are enrolled within an alternative high school. Drug use was frequently assumed or casually stated within my interactions with other

school personnel, and in particular, the teachers and the counselors within the program would assume that all or almost all of the students used, and would state this as a fact: "Those kids use drugs- you know they all use drugs- that is why they are there" when in fact the actual prevalence of persistent drug use was a smaller percentage of the total population than perceived.

This conclusion is tentative at best, based on small sample size, but warrants further investigation as drug use may play a small role within the lived experiences of some students who enter an alternative high school.

Charon described a physical assault in third grade:

> In like third grade there's always this girl who used to pick on me. She'd always call me names and stuff and we just really didn't get along. Then she like pushed me down, held me up in a corner. She thought she was pretty funny but she wasn't. I just got like, I don't know, kinda hurt but I got over it quick.

During her eighth grade school year, Charon began to believe that physical violence was a means to get attention from her mother: "I was getting' frustrated with less attention on me. More attention on worrying about where everything is and what's gonna happen. And so in order to get attention I started hurting people." Charon used the physical violence against others to negotiate more attention from her mother. It is clear from her account that her use of physical violence was intended as a tool to negotiate significance within her family. Charon recalled "wailin' on somebody in the face for no purpose just because you thought they did something wrong, or you didn't like them."

As these participants entered school and negotiated relationships with peers, they did so in a manner that is consistent with the power-over relationship that their fathers

established within them. The reflexivity of their early relationships and construction of reality was now transferred to peer relationships. The early experience of rejection, and the framework that the world, and others are not only not helpful, but also harmful, positioned the participants within a hostile world in which "people do not care," and in particular, they do not care about them, except as objects of their anger and caprice; thus the self becomes insignificant. When a peer attempted to objectify them, by making them insignificant within their relationship to other peers, the participants fought back, not so much against the peers, but against the fear of insignificance.

Hektor's narrative consisted of a detailed account of four different physical altercations. This was Hektor's account of his first fight:

> My first fight was when I was in fifth grade. It was about a seat actually. Like I sat in the same seat like every day. Like for two years and then this kid tried sitting in it, and I just went crazy. And then. . . yeah, and then he pushed me and it was it. Yea. It was over. It was over. Like I, picked the kid up over my head like (chuckling) I was just. . . Goin' crazy.

For Hektor "goin' crazy" delineated for him typical interactions with others from the negotiation of a relationship through violence. His expression of goin' crazy also indicated that he understood that physical violence toward others is against social norms, so to use violence and break the norms, one needs a reason. In this case the reason was goin' crazy. In high school, Hektor recounted how after a physical fight, the principal turned to him and "he's like, 'Well how hard did he hit you?' I, that, I, I just started to rollin.' I'm like the kid's holding three teeth in his hand."

The research literature on social rejection and aggression focuses on aggressive behaviors during the primary grades, but not within middle school and high school. It appears that violent and aggressive behaviors seem to increase within school and that rejection at younger ages and aggressive behaviors are correlated with later and increased intensity of violence.

Social withdrawal was expressed as either a dysfunction of the self, (as Ananta stated: "I was not good at socializing, or anything like that. It was just really outcast kinda of level,") or as being socially insignificant (as Jasper indicated both with peers in kindergarten, "uh they, just avoid me," and adults, "I should've been one of the first people, on, off the bus. But instead I was, I was the last person because he forgot I was there because I was try'in to keep to myself and quiet. So I think the longest bus ride I was on was like an hour long or something.") The third way social exclusion was expressed was through a regular use of drugs. For both of the two participants who detailed their drug use, it was described as an escape from reality, and from the pain of their lives. Of particular note was that the drug of choice was either prescription medication or cocaine, both of which have a numbing effect on the body. In these narratives, social rejection was constructed as a withdrawal from others which indicated a construct of the self that was not significant enough to negotiate with others. As opposed to continuous rejection, participants accepted an outcome of rejection as the most probable outcome and then they withdrew from the negotiation, which then ensured the outcome of rejection. The choice to accept rejection was the participants' use of their power to protect themselves from the rejection of others: they chose to reject their own self's power to negotiate a relationship.

In the previous two sections, I have analyzed how participants' negotiated relationships with others. There exists significant evidentiary warrant to conclude that participants' orientation toward others was constructed as negative, and as such, one would expect that the participants within this study would not anticipate that others within their world would be able to meet their needs with consistency.

The third rejection is from school as an institution as well as from the adults within the school. The rejection was a continuous rejection similar to the experience of rejection by parent(s) and peers. As these rejections continued, the negotiation of school and of not graduating became a negotiation of life (significance) and death (insignificance). As the participants entered high school (which is generally structured within a hieratical power structure), the negotiation for significance was centered on social status (grades, athletic ability, special talents), in which the power of teachers and administrators over students was produced through the negotiation for significance. While it would be interesting to understand how this negotiation is lived and understood by all students, as well as by teachers, this dissertation has a specific focus: how students who were situated within high school as being those students most likely to leave school without graduating negotiated within high school a reality in which graduating from high school was not likely. A critical junction in this negotiation was when participants were legally able to leave school, and yet they still came to school. This choice of coming to school, even after being rejected by the institution of school was an act of living for students, and this act of living was concerning to school as the power within the negotiation had shifted. The school's power to control the negotiation via grades, and discipline: (threat of rejection) via suspension or expulsion, had shifted, as the students

were then of an age where they had a legal right to make the choice of not continuing within school, however, they continued to attend school. This shift in power within the relationship was the first time the participants perceived they had power, and that they could use their "power" to influence an outcome, in this case, school. As noted in Chapter 3, at the time of enrollment, the students within this study had the legal right to withdraw from school.

In the next section, I will provide examples of school rejection, as well as of how students came to understand the non-completion of high school as "death" (insignificance). These lived experiences by participants continue, expand upon, and provide evidentiary warrant for the struggle for significance theory. In the final section of this chapter, I will analyze how changing the life/death negotiation framework provides a context for students to change the conditions of the negotiation and enter a space of hope, which is consistent with the thirdspace critical framework.

The participants' rejection from the institution of school as well as from teachers, was based on a code that defined the social contract between the teacher and student: "If a teacher yells at me for no reason or doesn't listen to me or ignores me, then I'm gonna do the same thing," with a recognition that while they may do the same thing, "the teacher pretty much wins." This sentence provides insight into the participants' understanding of the negotiation of the relationship between student and teacher and of who in the relationship has more social power. The term power is used both as a means to influence outcomes, as well as to bend to a terminal state, as the teacher's power within the relationship results in both. The student code also indicates that the students do have a power, as they are "going to do the same thing," which means both that they will reject

the teacher as much as the teacher rejects them, and that they hold that the negotiation of significance ought to be without a power differential. This idea of equal power to negotiate significance situates the students in conflict with teachers and administrators as teachers and administrators have the legal authority to act in loco parentis, and they have the power to construct students' as significant or insignificant.

The participants described a continuum of rejection which included a lack of interest by the teacher in all students, to a lack of interest by a teacher in just the participant. They also indicated an inability for school personnel to provide safety for students, and/or directly causing harm to students. Each of these constructed meanings was another rejection from a person who had power over the participants, and had used this power to harm, or to allow harm; thus this relationship paralleled the relationship with the participants' parent(s). As such, it reconfirmed and reinforced the initial rejection. Below are provided examples of each type of rejection.

At one end of the continuum is the rejection through non-recognition of all students. As Dylan noted, it is "like with teachers at home school you can't do that (talk with them) because they are just so work, work, work, work, work. I don't know how to put it." Ananta's explanation extended Dylan's concept in her description of a good teacher, which she showed through a comparison of all of the other teachers:

> She just didn't have the same lack of compassion thing going. They all (teachers) kind of hit a point where they just don't try to even interact with the kids they're with. Or like try to inspire them to does the work or they just try to stick to the curriculum and get it over with.

Her work and learning was constructed as "something to get over with," presumably so as to be able to engage in a different activity that was more rewarding than teaching. Theresa personalized this rejection to a particular teacher:

> He was lazy. All he did was sit at his desk. He put textbooks out on the table. When you first walked in, you'd have to grab a textbook and a piece of paper, like whatever worksheet he had for us and we'd sit down and do it. He was so lazy and I complained all the time. And he was mean. He was a dick.

In each of the descriptions, the rejection was felt as a lack of concern or care for students in general, including themselves.

The next type of rejection which was felt was exclusionary but this type of rejection was constructed by the participants as targeted toward the particular participants. As Fionnula described,

> The teachers in that school play favorites, like if your last name was Jackson or if you're better than other people in sports. Like a lot of the sports coaches were like teachers. Once I stop being an athlete I, they knew I was a bad kid and they knew like what I did.

Her description of rejection was based on a line between social identities which were praised within her school (such as athlete), and so when she became a non-athlete, and she lost social recognition from the school, then she became a "bad" kid. The idea of being a "bad kid" is a representation of the internalization of the rejection from her teachers. As noted, rejection falls within a continuum. The previous examples were subtle forms of rejection. In the next section, examples will be shared in which the participants'

narratives described increasingly overt rejection, thus the rejection was more active in that it violated the students' norm that the teachers should have protected them.

Lugus described several such incidents:

> My hand was slammed into a locker, being tackled in the gym class the teacher just saying 'they're rough housing.' Getting into fights at the end of the year because I called a person a name and I tried standing up for myself. And because no one else would stand up for me I had to stand up for myself. I had to fight.

At the end of the narrative, Lugus noted that he had to stand up for himself not as an act of independence, but as an act of self-preservation, as no one in a position of power-over the students had concern, so he was left with what he perceived as his only option: "to fight." The next examples of the continuum shift from passive non recognition of a situation to teachers violently rejecting students.

As Hektor noted:

> So I suppose to be right handed and I'm actually left handed. And I can't write and she (teacher) said it was too sloppy and it doesn't count for anything. I was like, "It doesn't count for anything?" and I ripped it in half, threw it across the room and said: 'Now it does not count for anything.'

This narrative provides support for one of the basic codes for interaction with others that this participant used in choosing how to respond which is: if you treat me "x" way, then I treat you "y" way. This code establishes a conflict within school, as schools require students to act in a particular way, which they cannot require of their employees.

Bronach provided another example:

> I'd argue with teachers. I'd just um, flip out on 'em. Swear at 'em and walk outta class and stuff. . . I don't know, like a lot of times they talk to you like you were stupid. Like you had no idea what was go'in on or someth'in and like you ask them a question, like they'd explain it to you like you were stupid. Like, like talk to you like you were slow or someth'in like that. And that always pissed me off cause it's like, 'I'm not stupid. I just didn't understand that part. Ya know. . . Yea. Cause like I don't need it dumbed down. I just need, like you know, a certain part explained or someth'in like that or told to me again ya know.

Bronach's conflict was centered around the rejection of herself as being smart: she fought this by engaging in what she called "flipping out," which was yelling and cursing at her teachers.

Jasper also provided an account of being rejected through being called stupid: "He called my name and was like, 'Wow, you know everything in this class. What are you stupid?' He actually said that so I, I just left." Instead of "flipping out," he chose to handle this rejection by leaving the classroom. This suggests that these participants were responding to a threat, as they responded with either a fight or flight response to the threat of harm (rejection). The final example, and there was only one in the seventeen interviews, almost led to a physical altercation. Asher described this:

> Like, he, he, he, wanted to fight me one day like straight up. He almost hit me in the face. Well, I was sitting in class, and uh, some kid was like bit'in his finger nails and spit'in them onto the ground. And he, like, I like, Mr. Marx saw him and was like, just like 'That's what garbage bins are for.' And then he said someth'in

> underneath his breath and I, I don't remember what it was but it was harsh. And I was like 'I don't like your attitude.' He was like, 'What?' and he just gave me a dirty look and I, I stood up and I'm like, 'I don't like your attitude.' I'm like, 'You'd better calm the fuck down right now!' He's just like, 'Don't talk to me like that.' And he stood up and I'm like, 'You want to punch me in the face?' I'm like, 'Do it, Do it.' And I tried to instigate him to hit me. I'm like, 'Hell yeah.'

One of the major differences as opposed to the other types of rejections is that Asher already felt rejected, and as he constructed himself as insignificant within school, he was more willing to engage in behavior that would bring attention to him, and also at the same time, he felt that had less to lose in the negotiation as he was already rejected, and moving toward being kicked out of school; thus, he then felt less and less bound to the social norms of school, and broke these norms by directly challenging a teacher to hit him.

The other side of rejection (insignificance) is acceptance. Lugus, in recalling his best high school memory recalled one time in which he was significant to his peers.

> At the last, moment, uh, before we all left back to the bus at the end of the day. . . Uh seniors got together for a picture and I was getting a hat. I was buying a hat over inside. So several people came out there and like everyone's shouting: Lugus, Lugus what are you doing? You're going to miss the picture! I turned around see like everyone all posed. It was like you know how everyone is ready for a big picture. I am like "Oh shit, come on, come on, come on! I jump over and slide over into the picture like "naaaaah, ha, ha, And then we get a nice picture after that. But it was cool because I got to get down in front.

Lugus' best memory from high school was the one time in four years that his peers included him. This acceptance moment was initially framed by Lugus being positioned outside of the group while his peers were forming the group. While the group was forming, he was alone, shopping. The group called him into the group and then he positioned himself as almost missing the opportunity to be significant. This significance was only achieved through great effort on his part to join the group at the last possible moment. The narrative ended with a nice picture. This nice picture was a picture of significance, one which Lugus achieved through great effort and it symbolized his significance to his peers.

Pain of Insignificance

The pain of insignificance was described by Ananta: "It is just a pain. Like constantly being in pain but it's almost worse than physical pain 'cause it's deep rooted-just, I can't even describe." What was not spoken but was contrasted was that the pain that was felt was an internal feeling of pain which exceeds that of physical pain.

Of the 17 participants, nine of the participants recalled a time when they attempted suicide. Of these cases, two females spoke about instances of cutting themselves, as a means to feel "alive." Bronach described why she cut herself: "It just felt good. Like when you do it, um it just like releases endorphins and it just picks you up for a little bit. Like it made me feel better for a while." Ananta accounted for suicidal behavior as "feeling no one's gonna help you with anything. There's nothing anyone's going to do for you. If you have problems, like, there's no back door. There's no alternative option." Fionnula articulated how this pain was turned to anger, and anger she did not understand: "I was just a mean person. I have no idea why. I had a lot of hate for

everyone." For her, drug use was an escape: "oxycodone made me like mellow, like I mean is that they made me really happy." This was in contrast to cocaine: "which makes you all jittery and shaky." The pain of insignificance was written on the backs and in their souls, and this pain was a force which drove the participants to eradicate the pain, in acts which were intended to destroy the body and soul (death). The act of inflicting pain and damage to the body and soul provided the illusion of escape and power over the pain, but in fact, these acts symbolized their own rejection of self, and as Ananta recounted, that at times she could "go too far," such as the time she required stitches for a gaping self-inflicted cut on her arm, that looked like a "big smiley face."

Alternative High School

Participants identified four differences that differentiated the alternative high school from a traditional high school: a different atmosphere, the ability to receive help and to have work broken down, and family-like relationships between staff members and students. These differences were elements of the program that as principal, I worked with all staff members to include into the program. In this section, I use both student descriptions and policies of the program to provide an analysis of the differences between a traditional high school and an alternative high school, and how these differences facilitated a change in the negotiation metric that participants used in their struggle for significance. I will argue that the grades within school have less to do with a measure of knowledge acquired, and more to do with the teachers' abilities to use grading as hegemony to bend students to a terminal state, and that grades and the power of assigning grades is perceived by educators as the primary power in the negotiation, and that

changes in the policy of grading can facilitate changes in the students' negotiation for significance.

Theresa provided an example,

> I wanted to come back here because it's, it was the only place that I felt safe, comfortable and like I was actually learning and wanting to learn. Before I didn't care. I didn't care about my education or nothing. And being here, I just wanted to learn. I wanted to be here.

The school met Theresa's needs both for safety and for feeling significant about herself as was indicated when she said, " I was actually learning." The word "actually" would suggest that this was a surprise to her. She continued and included not only that she was "learning," but that she wanted to engage in further learning, as she indicated when she said, "I just want to learn." The school environment for Theresa provided her with the ability to feel as though she was learning, and that was all (just) she wanted to do.

Charon compared her home school with the alternative high school:

> because, I know that was going on in (home school) with them not caring. But in this school they're devoted to making sure you're gonna graduate. They're making sure that you're having what you need regardless if you, if it's just a couple of points extra they help you pass.

Her indication that the alternative high school was, "devoted to making sure you're going graduate" which changed the negotiation from "you are going to be insignificant" (fail) to "you are going to be successful" (graduate), and not only are you going to graduate (be significant), the school help you graduate "regardless."

Puck's response shifted the atmosphere away from the teacher-student negotiation for significance to students' negotiations with each other for significance, which hinted at a family feeling for students.

> It's completely different. It's more one-to-one with the teachers. Not them sitting, pointing at a chalk board telling us whatcha gotta do. They'll come over and talk to you personally and help you figure it out and it's great. Everyone kinda meshed and got along with each other.

This idealized family of everyone getting along is further expanded by other participants. The other feeling expressed was that the alternative high school was a "second chance." This phrase was part of the discourse of the school that both administration and teachers used to describe the program to parents and students. When the students used this phrase, it was used without much description. My analysis of this is that this was a phrase adults used around the students. In students' negotiations with teachers and myself, students used this phrase as a platitude, and the phrase itself probably had little meaning for them as students. This claim of platitude is based on the following: a) that participants used it as means to socially confirm the relationship with myself; and b) more importantly the second chance metaphor is an inadequate metaphor for the students' lived experiences shared. The social confirmation is based on the fact that each participant had heard me used the phrase numerous times: graduation, open day speeches, and other occasions, such as when discussing their behavior within the program. It was a common practice of mine to remind students that the program was a second chance, and to ask a student how they were making the most of it. It was clear to students within the program that this idea was important to me; thus in their description of the alternative high school, I as a

principal was excluded in all of the participants' accounts; this provided the participants with the ability to acknowledge me indirectly through the use of voicing, and conform that they valued what I valued too. The notion of a second chance for participants was further made absurd as outside of school, their lived experiences of rejection, insignificance, violence, and pain were outside the bounds of a second chance. For their lived experiences, there is no redo; thus I learned in this dissertation how myopic and perhaps hurtful my understanding of the students' worlds outside of school could have been. I would not use the term second chance as part of the program's vision.

The metaphor of second chance further assumed the participants were in some way culpable for failing the first chance, when in fact these participants did not have a first chance, as they are not responsible for the violence perpetrated on them. The second chance metaphor linguistically placed the failure within the students, and this was yet another small and subtle act of rejection of the participants. I was ignorant of the harm this metaphor could cause, and for this I am deeply remorseful.

Two policies which supported the feeling of a laid-back atmosphere at the alternative high school were: the homework and grading policies. In each of the interviews, participants mentioned that the no homework policy had a big impact on their success.

Bronach described her reason for not competing homework:

> pretty much like, I would take it home but when I got home there'd be like arguments or you know, stuff like that. Or I had, ta, um help my mother with dinner so I wouldn't have time ya know. And my dad would come home drunk and stuff and start yell'in and start an argument and everything. My mom would

> come home and they'd be arguing so pretty much I didn't have time to do my homework. And I couldn't concentrate on it I guess.

Ananta described a personal reason for not completing homework:

> I think it was the stress of always having those things on my mind. Like, I hate it when I get stressed to the point where I can't, at one time remember everything I have to do. . . Also I have trouble separating small things from big things or like sometimes I think small things are really big things.

Dylan explained his philosophical reason as to why homework was so difficult to complete:

> Home is home and school is school. I go home and all I wanna do is just relax you know. Ahh, I do not have to worry about anything anymore. When I am home, I wanna, like I said relax. I just don't want to worry about that stuff, when I'm on my break.

Whatever the reason given, not having homework shifted the negotiation of school and its policies and provided students with a notion that the negotiation of self as a student would be different at the alternative high school.

The second policy was around grades. There are two shifts: both of which moved grades from being terminal to negotiable. First, in a traditional high school, grades are assigned based on a mathematical average. Grades are assigned every 10 weeks (four times a year), or quarterly. As such, across four quarters, a student would need a minimum of 260 points (4 x 65) accumulated grades to pass a class. Without providing models for each case, the reader can conclude that there are multiple ways to earn the 260 grade points. It is also possible to not earn the 260 grade points, and yet still pass one or

more quarters (i.e., 70, 70, 50, 50). In this example, the student would have passed quarters one and two, and failed quarters three and four, which means that the student failed the course and yet passed some of the quarters for a given course. In a traditional setting, the student would need to take the entire course again. At the alternative high school, students were assigned quarter grades, so that each quarter was separate from the previous and following quarters (no means were used). Thus, a student could be given credit for any quarter that he/she had earned a grade of 65 or higher. This changed the terminal nature of grades from passing (significance) or failing (insignificance) to the ability to pass and fail and experience significance in a condensed time frame.

The second policy in place at the alternative high school that differed from a traditional setting was that if a student did not pass a quarter, they could be issued an "Incomplete" and be provided time to make up the work and pass the quarter. During each of the past eight years, this policy created a tension between me as principal and the teachers, and each year, we argued over the policy. It changed many times, each time with students needing to "do more" to "earn the privilege" for an Incomplete. During the last four years, the teachers wanted the policy completely eliminated. The basic argument was that students needed to be more "accountable." Accountable was a word used to express the teachers' need to control the negotiation or have power over the students as the students came to re-negotiate themselves as students. The grades provided the teachers with the power to validate the change within the students, and they wanted power to control the validation of the students' success. This is particularly interesting in that it suggests that the power of grades, even within an alternative environment where teachers promoted the second chance idea, and teaching alternatively, they still held onto

a deeply embedded and entitled sense of power over students. The power of grades for students is evident within the following account "It was kinda an upper ya know. Be able to get good grade again and stuff" and "I get good grades on my, uh, Regents and stuff like. . . just smiles on parents and just knowing that I'm mak'in them proud because I'm actually getting good grades and I'm actually do'in something." While teachers expressed a need for power over students, the students' perceptions of the teachers were that they cared about them or that they were significant.

As Bronach noted in her description of teachers at the alternative high school:

> kinda-not like teachers at school. Like they worry about your assignments and if you're doing the work, whatever. But here they, like talk to ya more. They, you know they can tell when you are having a bad day or some'in like that. They'll talk to you about it. They calm you down when you're get'in ready to freak out or someth'in like that. And you know they, they counsel you I guess. It just helps.

Hektor's explanation expanded on the notion of calming down:

> They were down to earth. They act like, they didn't. . . like going back to Mr. Rice like he, he, they acted like they were one of us. Not all the time. They definitely knew there were points ta act like a teacher. Um, but for the most part like in lunch or whatever, you could have a conversation with 'em and everyone would joke about the same thing. I mean definitely not completely inappropriate but sometimes the conversations were a little inappropriate. And like you guys, knew that it wasn't a harmful conversation. It wasn't gonna cause any harm.

Hektor's and Bronach's accounts of teachers as counselors that help calm them down, and as individuals whom are concerned about students as they both "listen and make

conversations that were not harmful. The negotiation within both Bronach's and Hektor's accounts was that they were indicating a willingness to not freak out and instead calmed down, which was a negotiation for them, and it is through their willingness to trust in other adults to help them that they were able to struggle for significance in a new manner.

These relationships were expanded beyond the bounds of the traditional teacher-student relationship, and for the students, the relationship was like a family. As Cecilia described,

> It's like a family because it's like the things you do for us. Like if, if it's your birthday, ya know, you get, you guys do ice cream and cake and everything just for a person's birthday. In my home school, they'd spend five hundred dollars for everyone's birthday, but it's just like how people do the littlest things, even it's the littlest things that you do good. They show how much they care about how good you're doing. Like people actually care.

As Dylan described, Mike (teacher) is:

> like a second Dad. He just, he's real cool. Like you can talk to' em too, just about anything, and he'll give you like an actual response. Not just like, I do not know-it's hard to explain. Like he gives you advice and just, he teaches you a lot of lessons. Like he, he always talks about like stuff that his dad taught him. And stuff like that is really cool.

The recognition of a student's birthday, providing advice, and showing that teachers cared were each indicators to students that they were accepted not only based on

social status, or skill, but as human beings, and this again changed the negotiation from one based on social status, (which as an adult I control), to a significance based on being.

The perception of care (significance) allows for the renegotiation of self within school. This significance will be symbolized by each student's graduation, which at one time seemed unlikely and was perceived as (death) as there was nothing beyond high school graduation. As Charon explained, "uh, because with a GED you can't really do too much. Even McDonald's you have to at least have a high school diploma if you're out of school now." Charon's phrase "even McDonald's" indicated that even for the lowest job, you need a high school diploma, thus non-graduation from high school was constructed as being terminal, where one would "have no options."

The negotiation of self, the world, and others for the participants within this study parallels the negotiation of students within high school whom struggled for significance. One of the primary differences of the struggle for significance for these participants was that their life experience was a continued series of rejections which positioned the participants to construct social rejection as the most likely outcome. As such, they constructed the world as hostile and either withdrew from the ongoing negotiation for significance or engaged in violent negotiation for significance. Either negotiation led to ongoing rejection which caused both physical and psychological pain. As pain and social rejection increased, so did failure within school and students began to develop a metric in which the struggle for significance was framed within a life/death framework.

This life and death struggle was played out within school, at home and in the community. The weight of this struggle and the consequences of insignificance drove these participants to accelerate death through school failure, drug use, self-harm, and

suicide attempts and ideation. As they engaged in these behaviors, adults that were in relationship to these participants rejected these participants at greater frequencies.

The rejection of students by their home school had a critical turning point which was when the students gained a perception of power as they continued to attend school although there was little chance they could graduate and they were of an age at which they could legally withdraw from school. This shift in power resulted in students' enrollment at the alternative high school. The alternative high school provided a context for the re-engagement of the negotiation of self. It was through these negotiations that the life/death framework was altered and this alteration led to the symbolic recognition of significance vis a vis high school graduation. This new method to negotiate the self for most participants was still emerging. This change in metric was very powerful and aligns with the critical thirdspace idea of hope. As previously indicated, McLaren and Farahmandpur noted: "hope is the ability to create a new world on their terms, and in their own voice without seeking permission to narrate their future" (2005, p. 45), and I would add without the omnipresence of fear, violence, and rejection that permeates their lives and saturates their beings, until there is almost no being left. I end the chapter with two narratives of hope: one from Theresa and the other from Fionnula, who demonstrated the negotiation of a new self, and whose narratives indicated that they are learning to be and live beyond and past the fear of violence. True revolutionaries!!!

Theresa as a child was raped by her father. Her narrative was about first coming to control the relationship and then terminating this relationship. The termination of this relationship began the emergence of a new self.

> It made me feel like shit. I felt disgusting. It's something I got to live with everyday. It's something that I do not know what I just. . . The fact that he was able to do this and not get any. . . That pissed me off. Like I told my Dad, I did - I started talking to my father again because I still couldn't get along with mom or step-dad. And I looked at him and I: said, 'You ever fucking touch me again, and I will kill you where you stand!' I said, 'I'm not a little girl any more, and you will die.' And he said something that I'm not going to repeat because it bothers me but. . . he agreed. I was like, 'All I want is a father/daughter relationship nothing more, nothing less. Don't ever touch me again.' And he agreed.

In this narrative Theresa was revisiting the past by negotiating a new relationship on her terms when she told her father, "I am not a 'little girl' that you abuse, in fact I am a women and I will kill you."

This narrative led to a narrative in which her father was in her home, and she was cleaning the stove. As she was cleaning the stove, as she recounted,

> He got up in my face and said 'I told you not spray that in there.' And I'm like, 'It's not going to hurt anything. This is my house.' And he took, he snatched it out of my hand and he put it up to my face and he had it pressed up against my lips and he's like, "Open your God-damned mouth.' He's like, 'Do want to taste what it tastes like?' And my boyfriend stands up, I just looked at him and I'm like, 'No.' I told him to go away. I just told him I wasn't dealing with his shit. That I don't need him. I am an adult and he needs to beat it, and he needs help.

At this point, Theresa negotiated from a point of strength from "not a little girl to I'm an adult." As an adult, she felt that her intentional arc was strong and that her father

could not and would not be allowed to make the arc go limp again. The fact that "she does not need him," indicated that he was dead (insignificant) to her.

Fionnula described high school graduation as sad.

> I don't know. I didn't want to leave high school. I didn't want to grow up. For like a half month I did drugs. And then I told my mom about it and started to go to outpatient. I have been clean since like July. I don't really talk with friends or anyone else who still does it. I keep in touch with Joe over the phone cause he like a brother.

Fionnula, who used weed, coke, alcohol, and oxycodone during high school, as graduation approached, came to realize that she needed to become an adult. The significance of graduation was the acceptance of herself as an adult, and as such, she chose to renegotiate herself from being a drug user to attending community college to becoming a waitress at a restaurant, and to do this, she needed to have old friends become insignificant. She described finding new friends and she indicated, "I met a boyfriend and I've been dating him for five months now. And he's never done any drugs. Like he hates pills. Like he hates coke." This is a significant change in her relationship to self, the world, and others. She is now clean, an adult, and so too are her new friends and boyfriend. This became possible as soon as her negotiation of herself shifted from the life/death struggle, to a struggle for significance with others: with whom she had significance.

Participants recalled from early ages that others and the world were hostile to them, and that; "people either did not care" or "nobody was going to help them," in conjunction with the experience of being rejected from parental figures: this led to a

construction of a world in which they felt insignificant. As they entered school and experienced rejection from peers and teachers, their construction of the world as a perilous and treacherous place continued to be confirmed, as well as their feelings of insignificance. The feelings of insignificance were painful as one participant indicated: "It's just a pain, like constantly being in pain but it is almost worse than physical pain 'cause it is like deep rooted- just I can't even describe it." This pain led to the description of the self as abnormal: "I am not good at socializing" or the feeling that others think of them as less than human: "I'm a scum bag." The participants had different ways of experiencing and expressing the pain though: some injured others, some harmed themselves through drug use, attempted suicides, or cutting themselves. Some chose a combination of the above. As one participant indicated, "I did it (cutting self that required stitches) to feel alive." It is my assertion that feeling alive is the result of feeling insignificant to others (dead). For participants in this alternative high school, leaving school without graduating would have resulted in them becoming insignificant; they fought against insignificance by still attending school when they could have legally left. In the space of the alternative high school, they found acceptance for their "being," and through this acceptance of peers and teachers, they felt like they were part of a family, "we are like a big family here. That helps each other out, and fights sometimes. But we still get along and care about each other so they work together, and I do not know help each other out." In this description of the school, everyone "helps each other out," (the world is responsive to my needs), and then "we still fight," but fights are not "terminal" or harmful to the extent that the conflict inflicts such a pain as to scare, but instead there is hope of repair, and reconciliation. Within the school, we are significant enough to each

other not to harm each other beyond repair, and we are responsive to each other. This experience of family provides the context to be significant to others in an emotionally powerful manner, as the metaphor of family includes the notion of an enduring bond between individuals, based on a feeling of connectedness and fidelity. These feelings bent the insignificant and significant continuum together in a place of hope, where conflict does not result in the complete rejection of the self, and where individuals can assist each other.

Chapter 5

Development of Self

Introduction

In the previous chapter, I established the struggle for significance theory by drawing on each of the participants' narratives. This chapter shifts the focus from analyzing all of the cases in the development of a theory to a focus on three particular cases, which will illuminate the three participants' development of self. As the analysis in this chapter will focus on the development of self from a different angle, it becomes a point of triangulation, which was discussed in Chapter 3. The analysis also will broaden the concept of rejection from a single event, to a continuous and ever-present ongoing element within the participants' negotiation of self, others and the world. The finding of the significant role of ongoing rejection of the self by others, especially by parents and teachers triangulates the data, and provides further evidentiary warrant for the struggle for significance theory that was presented in Chapter 5. The findings will also provide an analysis and in-depth understanding of three of the participants and provide an in-depth understanding to one of the three questions that frame this dissertation: How and in what ways did participants negotiate and construct meaning about the self?

These cases were selected because they were the only cases that were comprised of the initially conceived elements for a case study: two student interviews, a parent interview, and a review of the participants' cumulative school records. The interviews were each conducted at the end of the school year during the months of May and June. Each of the student participants understood that graduating from high school was inevitable. The inevitability of graduating from high school most likely influenced the

participants' accounts of their school experiences by highlighting both the areas of conflict within traditional schools, as well as emphasizing the positive nature of the alternative high school. The duration of the parent interviews ranged from 51 minutes to 77 minutes.

The student interviews consisted of an autobiographical interview. The question which framed the first interview was: participants were asked to tell their life story from their earliest memory to date. I queried participants during their autobiographical interview primarily when words and/or expressions were used that appeared to have particular meaning for the participant or that might have provided insight into the participants' structuring of reality. For example, if a participant referred to a person as an "asshole" within their autobiographical account, I would query, "What does it mean for a person to be an asshole?" or "How would I know that a person was being an asshole?"

The second interview was a semi-structured interviewed which was designed after I had completed five initial autobiographical interviews. The intention of the second interview was to query further about the participants' experiences within school and home that were shared during the first interview, as well as, to explore the participants' future orientation.

An unexpected finding in the initial five interviews was that, as a person/principal, I was not invoked within the participants' accounts of school. This was consistent within each of the 17 participants' interviews. This obvious omission from the participants' lived experience within the alternative high school either stemmed from a power-over relationship, or deference toward me. A third possibility is that it was a combination of both.

In an attempt to understand the participants' perception of my role as principal, within the context of the second interview, I asked students the following hypothetical question: "If this building program needed a new principal and it was left up to you to pick the principal, describe that person to me." This question was perceived by participants as uncomfortable, as initial responses were often: "I do not know" or "You do a pretty good job," and these answers were stated with non-verbal behaviors of looking away, rubbing hands together, and moving around in the chair. Both the verbal and non-verbal responses indicated a high level of discomfort or uneasiness with answering a hypothetical question. This was surprising when I considered the participants' openness to sharing other lived experiences. It is my supposition that this phenomenon occurred primarily because participants had developed a trusting relationship with me, and they most likely felt comfortable sharing their lived experiences with me, but that within the context of our ongoing relationship, it was too difficult to talk about me: our relationship was too close for the participants to discuss the relationship even within a hypothetical situation. This argument seems to be further warranted since within each of the interviews to varying degrees, participants sought my approval and understanding within their explanations with the expression "you know". . . and "you know what I mean."

A future-oriented question which was part of the second interview (the last question asked) was, "If you were granted three wishes with the condition that you could not save a wish or request additional wishes, what would you wish for?" An additional future-oriented question was: "When you think about your life five years from now, what do you hope your life will be like?"

The parent interviews consisted of a one-question interview in which I asked the parents to tell the life story of their child. One of the three parents, during the parent interview did not focus on her child, but instead focused on herself and in particular, on her relationship to her husband. Her focus on herself and her struggles as well as her subtle, negative description of her daughter, provided additional warrant for how her rejection of her daughter was both direct and indirect.

The analysis of the three cases presented within this chapter drew on both the theory and methodological approaches detailed in Chapter 3 of this dissertation. The case studies that were analyzed within this chapter emphasize the development of self, with a particular emphasis on the questions of: a) Why is this self being presented, and to what end?; b) How does this self influence one's sense of others, the world, and the self?; and c) What reality is being reflected and constructed? Each of these questions are answered within the analysis of each case study. Prior to this, it is imperative to answer the questions of: What is "self?" and Why does it warrant scientific inquiry?

The concept of the self and its relationship to others and the world are at the center of humanities. As Heidegger (2004) stated, "the essential nature of thinking is determined by what there is to be thought about: the presence of what is present, the Being of beings" (p. 244). And what do the humanities think about? The self, and its relationship to others, the world, and itself. Within this chapter, I will draw from psychological research pertaining to the self. From this tradition of thought, the self is defined and its saliency to both research and this dissertation is explained. After this, three models of the self are explored, which will be used to develop an understanding of the self and how it is presented within each of the participant's accounts, and then one

theoretical model for the destruction of self (suicide and self-mutilation) is explored. After this, each case study is presented, with an analysis of how the self was constructed through discourse.

It is important to note, as Fiumara (1990) indicated,

> Our philosophy is grounded in only half a language, in which the power of discourse is deployed while the strength of listening is ignored. We inhabit a culture that knows how to speak but not how to listen; so we mistake warring monologues for genuine dialogue. (p. 1)

Within the context of this study, I focused my attention on listening so as not to confirm a belief nor make a logical assessment of what was stated; instead I made the discourse an object of my inner world of thought, so that my thoughts would be able to recognize their own message of truth, and these truths would open parallel perspectives and reveal different worlds (Fiumara, 1990). Nietzsche (1882/2008) noted that writing allowed him to get rid of his thoughts (p.78). I am not attempting to get rid of my thoughts, for the lived experiences that were shared within this study lived within me, and have become a part of me and of my own thoughts. Instead I write to share with the direct intention of allowing students' voices to be heard, to inform theory, and to inform and direct future educational policy. As Fiumara stated, it is well past time for each of us to listen with an openness that might lead to "a state of helplessness and disorientation" (1990, p. 43).

Within a critical framework, it is my clear intention to disorient the perception of the type of person that leaves school without graduating, and why students leave school without graduating. This is done by changing the foreground and horizons of the analysis from academically, statistically significant constructed factors, to lived and personally

meaningful constructed factors. In academia, there is privileging of statistical constructs over lived factors due to the notion that statistical constructs are considered to be impartial, but as Heidegger noted, “Inquiry, as a kind of seeking, must be guided beforehand by what is sought. So the meaning of Being must already be available to us in some way,” (2008, p. 25).

Self

The concept of the self can be traced back to William James (as cited in Harter, 1999) who claimed that: a) there are two selves: the I self and the Me self, b) that a person has multiple selves, and c) that self esteem is not an “aggregate of perceived successes, but rather represented a ratio of successes to one’s pretensions” (p. 16). These three claims are relevant to contemporary psychology. Epstein (1991) stated that: “the ‘me’ self (self as object) can be defined as all of the beliefs that individuals hold about themselves” (p. 80). The I self is “hierarchically organized into a theory and it contains propositions about mean-ends relations. The organization of the self into a theory with means-end propositions identifies a system that is able to interact selectively. . . to influence the pursuit, organization, and retrieval of information” (p. 81). For Epstein, the four functions of self-theory are “to enhance the pleasure-pain ratio over the foreseeable future, to assimilate the data of reality, to maintain relatedness to others, and to enhance self-esteem” (1991, p. 82). Leary and Tangney (2003) defined the I self as the self “as-subject,” or I, is the psychological process that is responsible for self-awareness and self-knowledge. . . to distinguish it from the “self-as-known” (p. 7). Harter (2006) indicated that “the I self includes: a)self-awareness - an appreciation for one’s internal states, needs, thoughts, and emotions; b) self-agency - the sense of the authorship over one’s

thoughts, and actions; c) self-continuity - the sense that one remains the same person over time; d) self-coherence - a stable sense of the self as a single, coherent, bounded entity" (p. 508). Kihlstrom, Beer, and Klein argued that:

> the self is a mental representation of oneself, including all that one knows about oneself. The "I" who knows the "me" is the same "I" who knows everything else, and the mental representation of this knowledge is no different, except perhaps in intimacy and richness, than is the mental representation of anything else I know. (2003, p. 69)

While Kihlstrom, et al. (2003) stated that the knowledge of the self is not different from other knowledge structures, this claim appears to be modified by their assertion that, "the more that one knows about the topic, the harder it is to gain access to any particular item of topic relevant information" (p. 73) and that the self is a very large knowledge structure stored within memory. Hence, even if self knowledge is the same as other knowledge, its sheer size would differentiate it from other knowledge structures. Markus and Cross (1990) broadened the concept of self to include others: "what one 'takes oneself to be' is an interpersonal achievement deriving almost entirely from the individuals' relations with others" (p. 576). They claim that "individuals are aware of themselves as objects in the world only because other people are aware of them, or have been aware of them" (p. 576). Mischel and Morf defined the self as:

> stable and variable, consistent and inconsistent, rational and irrational, planful and automatic, agentic and routinized. Further, the self in contemporary psychology is not just a knowledge structure and thus "known", but also a 'doer' and indeed a 'feeler,' as much driven by affect as guided by cognition. (2003, p. 23)

Psychologists are concerned that the development of an "I theory would lead to a homunculus problem. The homunculus problem is that theories of the "I" lead to the conclusion that there is a self within the self that acts as the director of all action, thus the theory of self is nothing more than tautology. Within the context of this dissertation, the I or theory of the self is of importance, since the theory of the self provides the ability to understand behavior: "to understand behavior, it is important to understand an individual's frame of reference- the system used to categorize, organize, and understand data from the social world" (Markus, 1980, p. 105). The manner in which one organizes and attends to information both from within and from the outside assists one in the development of schema (Markus & Cross, 1990). This self-schemata guides the process of providing relevance to information. As Markus (1980) noted: "our social worlds are tremendously complex; the sheer variety of information available at any time is vastly greater than most people can attend to or even begin to understand" (p. 102). Thus one theory of I is an orientation to the world, and as the world is not static, neither is one's I theory: thus different contexts bring forth different interpretations of information and data and in doing so, different selves are presented and constructed. As Showers and Zeigler-Hill (2003) noted, since some organizations of the self are more salient in different contexts, individuals organize their theory of the self to fit the context. Not only do different contexts produce different I's, but as Markus and Nurius (1986) claimed, we also envision ourselves becoming someone and this leads to numerous potential selves.

> An individual is free to create any variety of possible selves, yet the pool of possible selves derives from the categories made salient by the individual's particular sociocultural and historical context, and from the models, images, and

> symbols provided by the media and by the individual's immediate social experiences. (p. 954)

Thus within one's theory of I, we not only organize our selves on past experiences and present context, we also create cognitive schema (I's) about who and what we would like or are afraid to become in the future. As Schwartz (2000) noted, within the current society, the unconstrained freedom to choose from an unlimited number of selves leads to paralysis. Perhaps the freedom to be who you want to be is society's latest reincarnation of the panopticon. As the self is permanently visible both by self and others, this opens up the endless exam which is based upon self and others' appraisal. With the cultural norm that one can choose to be anyone that he or she chooses to be, the sole responsibility of being or becoming rests on the individual. Tice and Wallace (2003) suggested an interesting claim that "people do not have accurate views of how others see them but rather think that others see them as they see themselves" (p. 95). We are a panopticon onto ourselves: thus we as people are easily manipulated. For while all the world is a stage, we cannot bear to be actors and instead we spend our lives backstage, busily fumbling with different costumes and props, trying them on and discarding them with the fear that the light of the stage might shine on us (Goffman, 1959).

In the previous section, I provided an overview of the theory of self or the I self. This theory of the self is important to this study, since the I self provides an organizing and unifying structure, in which individuals orient themselves to the world, to others and to themselves. This orientation is lived within the present but is influenced by both "what is still absent, and what is already absent" (Heidegger, 2004, p. 101). Within the context of Western culture, the belief that you can be anyone you choose to be is the new

panopticon, as we are always present to ourselves and to others: thus the endless exam is ceaseless, and we are driven not only to be one's self, but as many selves as we can, changing from one context to another. This raises the question which is central to this study and chapter: why is this self being presented? This question will be fully addressed within each case study. In the next section, the connection between theories of self and motivation is explored. The inclusion of motivation within this chapter is driven by the participants' autobiographical accounts. Motivation for school was a topic which was brought forth. For example, Ajax stated: "I just wanted to drop-out 'cause it's not-I did not feel it was worth it."

Self and Motivation

Baumeister and Vohs (2003) claimed that self-regulation and self-control are executive functions of the self. Their claim is that "self-regulation is a process that is comprised of three components: establishing a goal, or desired state, engaging in appropriate behaviors to obtain one's goals, and monitoring progress toward the goal," (2003, p. 199). The need for self-regulation is based on the theory that self-regulation provides individuals with the flexibility to meet their needs within their current environments as opposed to engaging in a futile search for the perfect environment. As Stephens, Markus, and Townsend (2007) noted: "choice, like all intentional behavior, is an act of meaning that necessarily derives its meanings from the socio-cultural context in which it is realized" (p. 814). Within the context of school, this self-regulation function and the choices pertaining to the self would appear to grapple with two questions: "What am I learning?" and "Am I welcome here?" (McCaslin, 2009, p. 143). "Students' implicit

answers to each question illustrate the press- the personal struggle and negotiation of social opportunities within a sociocultural institution" (McCaslin, 2009, p. 143).

Ryan and Deci (2003) provided a direct link between self and motivation. They differentiate between intrinsic and extrinsic motivation: intrinsic motivation involves doing an activity, because the activity itself is interesting and enjoyable, whereas extrinsic motivation involves doing a behavior because it is important for an instrumental outcome (2003). Intrinsic motivations are part of one's self, whereas extrinsic motivations are directed toward some other outcome that is not part of the self.

Eccles (2006) indicated that achievement-related behaviors are most directly related to one's expectation for success and the importance attached to the outcome. Within Eccles' model (2006; 2009), subjective task values are based on four broad categories:

> interest value (the enjoyment one gets from engaging in the task or activity), utility value (the instrumental value of the task or activity for helping fulfill another short- or long-range goal), attainment value (the link between the task, and one's sense of personal or social identity) and cost. (Eccles, 2006, p. 666)

Eccles (2009) claimed that individuals compare themselves against others, assess the amount of effort it will takes to succeed, and will conclude that some tasks are easier to master than others. Similar to Deci and Ryan (2003), Eccles also linked motivation to the self: "subjective task value is directly related to personal and collective/social identities and the identity formation processes underlying the emergence of these identities," (2009, p. 82).

If future-selves are goal states, then motivation, especially as framed by Eccles provides an interesting link to the self. As future selves are the selves we wish to be, our willingness to work toward those selves and the selves that we see as possible, can be analyzed within her model. Within the context of this study, the two questions raised by McCaslin (2009) are important questions to analyze from the participants' accounts of school: What did the participants feel they were learning?; and Did they feel welcomed in school? In the next section, three models of the self will be reviewed: a) a developmental model; b) a hot and cold system of self; and c) a terror management theory of self.

Systems of the Self

Harter (1999 & 2006) provided a developmental model of the self, which is based on her claim that the self is a cognitive and social construction. An individual's cognitive development directly influences one's ability to construct oneself. As such, in this section, I will review each of Harter's proposed stages within the development of the self. Initially the inclusion of a developmental model may appear incongruent with the framework of this dissertation: however it offers invaluable insight into how a student's understanding of the operation of the world can influence a student's understanding of him/herself as well as of others. Harter's model also offers a possible explanation as to why the participants (students) did not use metaphors in the narratives, as this would have required participants to have developed personal standards, as well as evolution of the self against these standards. The participants within this study were focused on a struggle to define the self beyond insignificance. Once a student holds that he/she herself is significant, this opens the self to be defined and understood more broadly.

As with other psychological theories presented in this dissertation, the particulars of the theories can be argued for and against and in this dissertation, more likely against, but the general idea is that the development of the self is based on the development of cognitive skills, which allows for different understandings of the self which are important to understand within an analysis of the self. Harter's (1999)model provides for how participants may recall, and reconstruct the narrative of the self within a particular understanding. Table 4 provides a summary of Harter's (1999) developmental model of the self. While a developmental framework may appear to be incongruent with the frame of the study, her framework provides insight into how people understand themselves within a lifespan. This understanding elucidates how participants within this study understand themselves within the world, and in relationship to others, which is congruent to the framework of this study.

Table 4.

Development of the self.

Stage	Characteristics
Very Early Childhood	Self representation reflects concrete description; descriptions are isolated from each other, as the child lacks the ability to integrate such characteristics.
Early to Middle Childhood	Self representations are very positive and the child overestimates his abilities. Child begins to display rudimentary ability to intercoordinate self concepts that were previously compartmentalized.
Middle Childhood to Late Childhood	The child develops the ability to form global evaluations and generalized labels to one self (ie: smart). Children can acknowledge that they can simultaneously possess positive and negative attributes.
Early Adolescence	There is a proliferation of selves that can vary as a function of self concept.
Middle Adolescence	There is a preoccupation with what one thinks of one self. This task is made more challenging given the proliferation of roles that demand the creation of multiple selves.
Late Adolescence/Early Adulthood	The development of self becomes more internalized and is based on personal beliefs, values, and standards. Self-concept and worth are based upon the meeting of these standards.

The second model presented is a hot/cold system of the self. The hot/cold model is an information processing model which is based upon the belief that the manner in which people encode information, their self-efficacy expectations, beliefs and goals determine how and why individuals both engage in the behavior that they do, and why there are differences amongst individuals' behavior within the same situation (Mischel & Shoda, 1999; Shoda & Mischel, 1998). Within the model, the self is viewed as a "dynamically interconnected system of relationships that function as an organized whole and interacts with the social-psychological situations in which the system is activated and contextualized" (Mischel & Shoda, 1999, p. 199). It is assumed within this model that "each person is characterized by a stable and distinctive network that guides and constrains the activation of the set of cognitions and affects that are potentially accessible," (Shoda & Mischel, 1998, p. 185). The system is conceptualized as system in a constant state of flux, due to continuous changing stimuli within the environment, and thus the system is never able to reach optimal solutions. (Shoda & Mischel, 1998).

Metcalfe and Mischel (1999) suggest that the ability for humans to delay immediate gratification of desires and to engage in goal-directed behaviors can be explained through a two-system model: cool and hot. "The cool system is specialized for complex, spatiotemporal and episodic representation and thought. We call it the 'know' system. The hot emotional system is specialized for quick emotional processing. We call it the 'go' system" (Metcalfe & Mischel, 1999, p. 4).

The cool system is narrative, weaving knowledge about sensations and emotions, thoughts, actions and context into an ongoing narrative that is coherent, goal

> sensitive, and strategic. Cognitive rumination is a hallmark of the system. The system is devoid of emotion and vitality. (Metcalfe & Mischel, 1999, p. 6)

The hot system is a rapid automotive response system that is based on feelings. A key difference in the systems are that hot spots within the system are not connected to each other, whereas cool nodes are connected, which accounts for the difference in the ability to ruminate, and the ability to respond quickly in a fight or flight manner. The cool nodes and hot spot systems are linked within this model, since it is theorized that they have the same external reference point, which means when a hot spot is activated, the responding cool spot is activated as well. Since cool nodes are interconnected, not each node has a hot spot match, but an activation of the hot spot can bring about a complex network of cognition which mitigates the action taken. While Metcalfe and Mischel (1999) noted that the systems are interconnected, there are times when hot nodes cannot or do not gain access to cool nodes, and these situations are of importance both theoretically and practically. If the hot/cool system is theorized as a self structure on a continuum, at one end of the continuum would be a cool and detached self that is highly reflective, and at the other end of the continuum would be a self that responds rapidly, with a high degree of emotional intensity. Mischel and Shoda (1999) noted that individuals “select, influence, and even generate their own interpersonal situations and are influenced by them in an interactive process” (p. 211).

The hot/cold model can be interpreted as incongruent within the framework of this dissertation, as it seems to give primacy to the “rational human” model that is a hallmark of enlightenment thinking. I would argue that while the model does in fact link cognition to willpower, it is also phenomenological in that, within the model it recognizes

that individuals attune to and assign salience to stimuli within a given environment, while ignoring or placing little salience on other stimuli and once assigned value, the stimuli are then interconnected with other knowledge and feeling structures. Thus the model, at its inception has a phenomenological base, and is congruent with the framework of the study. I will use this frame within two of the case studies as a means to provide an analysis of the self that was presented.

The third model presented is the terror-management system. The terror-management theory holds that humans have the "ability to conceptualize reality in terms of causality, the ability to conceive of future events, and the ability to reflect upon ourselves" (Solomon, Greenberg, & Pyszczynski, 1991, p. 95). Due to these cognitions, we are able to conceptualize both our existence and non-existence. The contemplation of one's non-existence (death) produces a high degree of anxiety within individuals. Thus, "terror management theory views the self as an essentially defensive construction that functions to protect people from a deeply rooted fear of death" (Pyszczynski, Greenberg, & Goldenberg, 2003, p. 315). Solomon, et al., (1991) claimed that "we live within a shared symbolic conception of the universe that is culturally created and maintained, and yet is believed to be an absolute representation of reality by individual members of the culture" (p. 96).

> These cultural representations of reality provide a) standards by which the individual can be judged to be of value, and b) an enduring place in the culture, and ultimately immortality to those who live up to the standards of value. (Solomon, et al., 1991, p. 97)

Thus one's self-concept is the ratio between the ability to meet cultural standards to the actual cultural standards: a ratio of one would indicate a perfect self-concept in which a person is able to meet all cultural standards. A low self-concept would be indicated by a ratio of less than one in that the individual is not able to meet some part or all of a cultural standard. For those individuals that cannot, or do not meet the cultural standard, they will either "suffer from chronically low self esteem, or will seek out an alternative worldview" (Solomon, et al., 1991, p. 115). It would appear that one makes a choice about the cost between low self concept and an alternative worldview, and this assessment of cost leads to the acceptance and/or rejection of the cultural standard. Within this model of conformity, obedience and uniformity can be explained by the need for individuals to seek validation of their worth through the measuring of themselves against a cultural standard. For Pyszczynski, et al., the basic human dilemma is: "the conflict between the immense potential for human growth and change that is often thwarted by our slavish dependence on the existing psychological structures that protect us from our fears" (2003, p. 329). As suggested by Pyszczynski, et al., (2003) the cost associated with adopting an alternative worldview is high.

I would suggest based on the findings in Chapter 4 that the cost of adopting an alternative worldview is social isolation and rejection, which in many senses is the same as death. To adopt an alternative worldview is to construct the death of self and others, as the knowing of the self, others and the world will be fundamentally altered by one's newly constructed alternative world. It would appear that people perceive that having a low self-concept and striving toward a cultural standard, has a lower cost than to

construct an alternative worldview and possess a high self-concept. This insight indicates the hegemonic power of cultural standards (the panopticon of self).

As schools are cultural institutions that not only establish standards for performance, but provide an ongoing bevy of assessments and measurement to ensure that all students understand where they are in relationship to the standard, as well as where they stand in relationship to their peers, it is clear that the model above can explain why some of the participants in this study describe school as terrorizing. This model will be used in the analysis of self, to assist in the explanation of the fear that appears to be incorporated into their lived experiences within school. I will now move from models of self to explore one theoretical explanation of the destruction of the self. This is important within the context of this study, since in each of the three case studies, students self-reported either that suicide was attempted multiple times, or they engaged in self-mutilation.

Harter's (1999) model to explain depression and suicide is comprised of two factors: peer related factors which are important to the self (which include athletic ability, appearance, and likeability), and parent-related factors (which include scholastic competence and behavioral conduct.) Youths self-assess their own ability within these two factors, as well as the support they receive from parents and peers within their respective domains. Based on her model, Harter (1999) constructed six pathways to depression, which are correlated with suicide. They are: 1) inadequacy in both clusters, and low support from peers and parents; 2) limitation in peer salient factors and parent salient factors and low parental support; 3) inadequacy in both peer salient factors, and parent salient factors, as well as low peer support; 4) inadequacy in more peer salient

factors plus low peer support; 5) inadequacy in more parent salient factors plus low parental support; and 6) inadequacy in both peer-salient factors and parent salient factors. In the context of this study, I will use this frame to develop an understanding of the why of suicide ideation and attempts. Harter (1999) noted that self-mutilation behaviors: "serve to allow the abuse victim to regulate autonomic arousal and certain internal states. Moreover, the pain functions to allow the individual to reconnect with his/her physical body. . . . Such behaviors temporarily reduce the psychic tension [but these behaviors only provide] temporary relief" (p. 280-281).

Case Study: Ajax

Ajax is a tall youth, who is about six feet and one inch tall, and he is thin and muscular, with brown hair cut short and close to the scalp, and brown eyes. He wore a tee shirt and jeans during both interviews, and generally spoke in a soft voice. Ajax's mother recalled his birth as occurring on "a rainy day, not just a rainy day but really pouring, jumbo rain drops." She continued and expressed that the day was:

> kinda sad, because he was the x child out of y children in the family, and the novelty of his, of the births in our house not for us of course. It was just not as exciting. But, ya know, the hoopla wasn't there so it was kinda of like, 'Oh great, it's raining and no one's here with flowers,' and that stuff.

Within her description of the birth, she indicated a sadness, but then grammatically corrected herself to suggest that the novelty of the birth had worn off, but then again indicated how there was no celebration of the birth, which resulted in her feeling sad, not so much about the birth, but that her needs as a mother were not met. She described him as quiet, and this led her to express a sense of guilt pertaining to breastfeeding.

> I breastfed all my children and because I had x little children at home, and Ajax was the newborn, he never, cried, he never said any. . . he never cried or said, 'Hey, I want some more food.' So like I guess I didn't feed him as often as I guess I was supposed to because all of a sudden he got skinnier and skinnier, and I felt terrible because I went to the doctor and he said; 'You need to give him some formula.

She indicated that Ajax "never complained," and "just did not say much." This construction of Ajax as quiet has important implications for his relationship within his family and with school. His mother indicated that she felt the need to become an advocate for Ajax so as to "make sure he wasn't getting looked over." The initial construction of Ajax as being quiet developed into descriptors of "really spacey" and "a loner," and later into the idea that Ajax lived within his "own world." His mother indicated that this also separated him from his family as he was "totally different" from his family, and this led to the family, but not his father, being very protective of him. Ajax's father was described as not understanding Ajax: "he did not get the spacey thing." His father not getting the spacey thing turned to anger:

> Ajax suffered the most. He suffered the most wrath from the whole thing because, um, my husband just did not get it. And he got so pissed off at him: 'Ajax what the f--- is wrong with you?' because Ajax was not paying attention.

Ajax's mother and siblings also constructed Ajax's world as a: "wonderful, wonderful world because he never knew the bad stuff that was going on around him." This construction is a very powerful construction as it becomes the central idea around how life events were explained for him. It accounts for why his father could not be his

Cub Scout leader, although he had done it with previous siblings and it was the reason he was not part of the family's plans to relocate, which was a significant turning point in Ajax's life. It also became part of the description of the alternative high school, which the family called the "island," and this island metaphor was then explained as: "it's like Rudolph and the Red Nosed Reindeer, and with the island of misfit toys. Those were the best and coolest toys of all. They just didn't fit on the Wal-Mart shelves, but they were the coolest toys." This metaphor seems suggest the relationship and construct of his mother towards Ajax: she viewed him as "intelligent, sweet-natured, strong moral convictions, and his ability to see the best in all people, and yet despite these traits, he does not seem to 'fit' in with the family, school, or with his peers." His mother was supportive of Ajax, and believed he had many good qualities, but despite these qualities, she lacked a strong sense of connection to him, and her account of her son explained this lack of connection as "not fitting in." Thus the construction of Ajax allowed for his mother to explain her perceived lack of a connection with Ajax.

Ajax described himself as "quiet, but at the same time very caring, mature for my age, and that I really appreciate the world for what it is, even if it's hard at times." Ajax indicated that his mother was "supportive and caring." He indicated that his father: "has diabetes and really did not take care of it so he kinda struggled. Sometimes he got angry, nothing bad." Ajax's placed the issues of the anger, of which his mother indicated that Ajax was the frequent target, on the disease of the diabetes as opposed to a trait within his father, or that his father's anger was directed at him. While he shifted both the purpose and direction of his father's anger, he did recognize that it was directed at him, which was evident within the following: "I learned to cope with it." He then modified the anger by

claiming, “It’s not that bad,” and he also normalized his father’s anger by claiming that his father’s anger centered around “typical like screw-ups that kids have.” The father’s anger was one of the causes of the family’s break up. This desire to place the anger and subsequent family breakup outside of the father, (which resulted in his relocation away from his father) most likely kept his wish alive, “that his parents would be happily married and um, still living together and being good models for their children.” Ajax’s wish that his parents would be “good models,” suggests that Ajax felt that his parents (one or both) had not been good role models. In describing his relationship with his parents, it was clear that as much as his mother had protected him and desired to protect the family, within this protective shield, there were some cracks and hints of conflict that were not ready to be fully explored or shared, and as such, even the wish for the family to reunite could be seen as a desire to have the issue dissolve. It is clear that Ajax was as protective of his family as his family was protective of him. This protection seemed to function as a means to keep his wish alive that his family would reunite. The breakup of the family appeared to be an unresolved conflict, and continued to cause pain and stress for Ajax.

Ajax described elementary school as “fun,” and indicated that he did not focus on school work. His teachers indicated that Ajax struggled with organization and with completing work. Ajax described middle school as a larger social environment that he was not ready to negotiate. He recalled in middle school that he “wasn’t good at making friends,” and that this was “pretty tough,” since no one acknowledged him. Although it was difficult not to be acknowledged, he indicated that not to be recognized had the benefit of not being bullied. “I got, I lucked out on that. There was kinda this negligence

ya know. That kinda, you know, not many people paid attention to me. I was just kinda of another kid."

As he entered high school, Ajax recalled that he began to make friends, and that he, "went back to my elementary school attitude, ya know. I did not concentrate too much on work. Kinda focused more on making friends and having a good time." For Ajax, the breakup of the family, and the relocation of part of his family was a turning point for him: "it just tore me apart 'cause here I am finally making friends, finally having a good time, enjoying my life and then it's all turned around." He described feeling depressed and that "he just lost everything." This sense of loss combined with the social isolation that he experienced in his new school led to depression and suicidal thoughts. As he indicated, "no one acknowledged me," and this really "hit me most when I was at lunch. I would either sit by myself at a table or I would skip lunch and go sit in the bathroom." These two events led to Ajax's initial emergency visit for suicidal ideation, and led to him feeling "scared to go back to high school," and "feeling that it wasn't worth it to go back to school to stick through it for another year and a half to two years of this." At this point, he was referred to the alternative high school, due in large part to the fact that his mother visited the high school guidance counselor, and demanded that something needed to happen. Here the cost of social rejection and isolation from peers, constructed the view that school was not worth the social pain.

Ajax reported that his first impression was that the alternative high school was a "lot smaller than my high school," and that he felt he was getting a second chance. The notion of a second chance is part of the description to both parents and students of the program during their intake meeting. An intake is required for all students prior to

attending the program. The intake is conducted by the principal, is 45 minutes in duration, and provides students with an overview of the program. Three elements of the program that Ajax indicated were important to him were: a) the teachers, b) the students, and c) the relationship between the teachers and students. He described the teachers: "They are really always there for you. If you have a question, they'll sit down and help you with it." He described how he: "fits in with the students because, they all have similar backgrounds." He described that the students and teachers also got along. The alternative high school was a place in which Ajax felt accepted by peers and adults. While this acceptance assisted him in completing high school, it did not eliminate the suicidal ideation.

During the beginning of his senior year, Ajax had been reported to me as "not acting like himself, and that his behavior was worrisome to the teachers." Teachers reported that he seemed very sad and depressed. I met with Ajax, and this led to his second visit to the emergency room for suicidal ideation. During the interview with his mother and him, I raised the topic in the context of the interview. It was clear that my role in this event, and my role as a researcher were incongruent, and neither wished to speak about it, so in respect to them, I did not query further, nor did I provide any detail of this within this chapter. I raised this at the end of the construction of self, to indicate that while Ajax and his mother provided me with a high level of access to life events that I was not a part of, life events of which I was a part of were difficult to share which indicated the difficulty of discussing my role within their lives. One possible explanation for this is that the construction of self that is presented could be incongruent to the construction of self that I hold for the participant.

Ajax's construction of himself is one of a person seeking acceptance (attachment) from his peers, teacher, and family. This need to be accepted, when it was met, allowed Ajax to feel connected to others, and when these needs were met (when he felt connected to others), he was able to meet the expectations of school and the world; but when his needs were thwarted, he became sad, depressed, and at times, suicidal. It appeared that Ajax was a youth whose self structure was predominantly based within a cold system. He focused more on internal thoughts and ideas, which could have led others, in particular, his family, to construct him as spacey, or could have led his teachers to construct him as inattentive. It appeared that he was neither spacey nor inattentive: instead his attention was focused inward, as opposed to outward. His suicidal ideation appeared to be closely related to both rejection from peers and family, as well as to the disconnect he felt between the world that he wished for and the world that was, and it appeared he cognitively ruminated about the world he wished to be, and he was reluctant to share his wished-for world. The wished-for world is clearly an alternative worldview which, if shared, could bring with it an evaluation which he feared would lead to rejection.

Case Study: Bronach

Bronach was an average size female, five feet, four inches tall. She had brown hair that was cut at shoulder length. She had a medium build and brown eyes. Bronach's relationship with her parents was one of neglect and abuse. Her mother initially described her as a good baby, but then during the telling of her daughter's life story, she described her as: "depressed," "a little trouble maker," "a little pistol," "a little stinker," "that she was always a chunky little kid who ate food for comfort," and "that she frequently had

temper-tantrums." Her mother recalled that when she was running a daycare, Bronach was always:

> jealous of the other children within the home, and would take their toys and hit them. She recalled one incident such incident: "I had this one little girl who was such a little sweetheart, and her and Bronach were good friends for years and years, til, you know like high school. And this girl never did anything wrong. And I remember she was trying to sing a song and I was trying to video tape them and Bronach was starting to cover her mouth so it was just her singing and she did stuff like that. She was like jealous of everybody.

Within her retelling, Bronach's mother positioned her twice: once against the sweet girl who did nothing wrong, and then at the end, that she was always jealous of everybody. It would seem that Bronach might have good reason to feel jealous of others if she was thought of as a little pistol, and others were thought of as sweethearts.

Her mother further described her daughter: "if she didn't want to do something, she was not going to do it." In comparing her to her grandchild, Bronach's mother indicated that:

> she was real irritable. I know that's a sign of depression. That's why I keep thinking that maybe, you know, we never, didn't know what it was, but she was irritable a lot. She wasn't like a happy-go lucky kid like my granddaughter can be real happy. Wake-up in the morning-she's all happy and like Hi-grandmother, I'm here today. And you know, an, like that. And a lot of time I do not remember Bronach when I think back being, you know, like happy-go-lucky a lot. She was like irritable and gave me a hard time.

Again, within this positioning of her granddaughter against Bronach, her description of her daughter was highly critical, and one in which others were favored to her, whether this was in comparison to her peers or to her mother's grandchildren. As she developed, her mother noted a change in Bronach:

> she seemed more compassionate back in those years. And then she got older, you know and it kind of bothered me she's gotten where she, I do not know, she's tough, she stood up for herself. She didn't let anybody give her crap like they use to, but she like kinda goes in the other way too much. She was not brought up that way.

Her mother seemed to suggest with the phrase "she was not brought up that way," that the mother had no influence over Bronach's shifted behavior of "standing up for herself," and that was the result of some outside influences.

Her mother would later identify this influence as one of her friends. What is revealing in Bronach's mother's account was that there were no positive descriptions or stories told that highlighted any positive feelings or pride. Her account of her daughter was all cast as negative. I would argue that this in itself is neglectful, but further evidence of this neglectful attitude toward her daughter was also evident in Bronach's account of how she had alcohol and drug parties in her basement throughout the summers of her ninth and tenth grade years in high school. Part of this conflict between Bronach and her mother appears based on Bronach's ability to stand up for herself positioned Bronach within a conflict with her mother, as her mother is unable to stand up or be tough in relationship to her husband.

Bronach and her mother both described her father as an alcoholic and a drug addict. His drinking and driving has resulted in four different prison sentences and to a court-mandated drug and alcohol counseling program. It has also resulted in Bronach and her mother separating from her father and living in low-income housing, which Bronach described as "we needed to live off of peanut butter sandwiches." Bronach described her father as an 'asshole,' and that when he would come home drunk, "he would start yelling and start arguments and bitching at me and then he would sleep on the couch, and the next morning everything would be fine." Bronach defined 'bitching' as:

> like he always says stuff to me about not graduating. Like I wouldn't graduate and stuff, 'I'd be working the rest of my life at McDonald's' and stuff like that, I'm not. Like he's always saying like um, that I disappointed them (she was then crying), and like I'm not worth the trouble and just stuff that makes me feel like crap. Like I'm not worth anything.

This was the second time Bronach cried during the interview. The first was when she recalled that her father took her to the animal shelter when she was young, and how "he does not do that anymore." From her accounts and from her mother's accounts, it is clear that she was not only rejected by her parents, but also subjected to the emotional abuse of feeling that she was "not worth it."

This pain Bronach expressed in tears, also found an outlet in high school in the use of drugs (marijuana, cocaine, oxycodone, and vicodin). She indicated that her drug use "helped me escape," and that: "I felt euphoria, and like nothing in this world bothers you." She also indicated that she cut herself for the same reason: "it just feels good, like when you do it, um it just releases endorphins and it just, it picks you up." She indicated

that she did it on her hip bone, and she would continue to pick at it, and make it bleed, because it made her feel better. Bronach indicated that she needed to stop using cocaine because

> I knew that I liked the way it made me, me feel. So, and I know like my personality. I do not have very much will power, will power, or like self control. So, I knew I had to stop, 'cause otherwise I'd be really bad.

While Bronach claimed that she did not have "self-control," she described an action that takes quite a bit of control, and a denial of gratification. She indicated this type of self in her description of her thoughts pertaining to suicide: "I would think about killing myself, or something but I wanted ta keep fighting. Like, I just, I wanted to see where I'd go." As Bronach aged, she developed her own alternative world through the numbing of herself. She could live within this world without a care, and she could feel good about herself.

It is clear that Bronach felt not only rejected, but worthless within her relationship to her parents. The construction of self of Bronach within her family was that she was of little value. I will focus on the construction of her self within school.

A review of her school records indicated that on her 4th Grade New York State Assessments, Bronach's academic performance within English Language Arts and Mathematics were above average. Her elementary school teachers described her as "a sweetheart, friendly, polite, and social." She was described as experiencing difficulty completing work, and her effort was inconsistent. Bronach indicated that during third or fourth grade was "when I started getting heavier," and that this was the reason behind the bullying. As she indicated:

> like they picked on me and stuff and so I always had to be the like the tough girl like, 'You're going to pick on me. I'm going beat you up' or whatever. So that's pretty much what I started doing. I'd start beating up the kids and stuff when they picked on me.

In middle school, she recalled that

> I liked to fight. I would always argue. I'd argue with teachers. I'd just flip out on 'em. Swear at em, and walk out of class and stuff. And like, I'd always flip out on kids and most of the time it would, it would not be a big deal.

She indicated the reasons for her anger toward her teachers were

> like if you had no idea what was go'in on or somethin' an like you asked for them for help with a question, like they explained it to you like you were stupid, Like, like they'd talk to you like you were slow or somethin' like that. And that always pissed me off cause, it's like I'm not stupid. I just didn't understand that part. Ya know?

As she entered high school, she recounted how she became angrier due to the drugs, and the "stuff at home," which led to more confrontations, suspensions, arrests for disorderly conduct, and eventually to being suspended for a year from school. It was this superintendent's hearing that resulted in her enrollment at the alternative high school.

When asked to describe the alternative high school, Bronach described it as a lot cooler. When asked to explain, she used the metaphor: "it's like a family that helps each other out and fights sometimes, but they still get along and care about each other so they work together, and I do not know help each other out, I guess." From her metaphor, it is

clear that the alternative high school provided her with the family that she had been missing for so long.

There appeared to be two turning points within Bronach's autobiographical account. First, in describing what she learned through service learning (volunteering at Foodlink once a month, six times a year), she indicated that,

> It made me feel good, like to help other people and like that and stuff. It just, it was fun and like I got the work done, and like I was helpin' people. It just, I never you know, like I don't usually do stuff like that at all. So it was weird and it was different, but I liked it.

This desire to help others appeared again in one of her wishes; "I would like to be able to help people. Help someone. Like help change someone's life, or something. At least have an effect on someone."

The second turning point was her performance on a state exam in which her performance was well above average. As she described, "I studied and did really well. I was so proud." What is interesting about both turning points is that they were experiences based within the context of the alternative high school, thus suggesting that the alternative high school provided her with the context to construct a more positive construction of self.

Bronach's construction of self went from one of fighting for significance which caused great pain, to a feeling of value, and extended to include a desire to help others in the future. The self which she presented throughout school was predominately a self construction based on a hot system of responses, which resulted in the destruction of relationships around her. She appeared to have limited ability or desire to assess the

interpersonal damage that her conception of the world had. This conception of the world appeared to be predominant within her father, as he would become enraged, say hurtful statements when under the influence of drugs and alcohol and then in the morning everything would be normal. Bronach did not seem to learn or have the worldview that in order to build and maintain relationships, feelings and thoughts need to be expressed in a manner that preserve relationships. When she negotiated her self within school, she did so forcefully, and with an aggressive manner, which paradoxically led her to the outcome which she feared the most: rejection. She also appeared to be vigilant for cues from others that would indicate that they were either going to insult or downgrade her, and she was ready to fight against any perceived threat.

This constant state of arousal, coupled with the continuous rejections at home, led to drug use and self-mutilation. The one protective factor within her life was that in the context of school, her measured academic ability was above average. While the endless exam is hurtful to many, she benefited because others perceived her as having the ability to complete school work. As she graduated from high school, she was still developing a sense of self. She appeared to recognize herself as a set of isolated traits, and had yet to develop a theory of self: perhaps this was due to her changing worldview.

Case Study: Jasper

Jasper is a White male, with short, straight, sandy-colored hair that was cut short on the sides and was longer and flat on the top. He has blue eyes, was of medium build and was about five feet, seven inches tall. What was remarkable within his construction of self and the construction of him by his mother and step-father was that the constructions were remarkably similar and accepting of him. The conflict that was

prevalent was that peers and schools seemed to be so unwilling to accept him, and/or provide him with the reasonable and small amount of assistance that he needed. This lack of support from school resulted in school becoming "torturous" and a place in which he "lived in fear."

Jasper's parents described him as "good baby." They indicated that he had hearing difficulties as a baby which delayed his speech. He did not start speaking until two and half or three and only after he had tubes placed within his ears. They described his transition to kindergarten as traumatic for him.

> Jasper would say that it, it was too much. Was too much going on. And at this time he had also been diagnosed with asthmatic. . . I can remember him saying that it was, there was just too much going on. It was like too much, uh buzzing noise in the kindergarten. He did not like it because of that. There was no, uh, it wasn't controlled. Everyone was running everywhere.

They indicated that he was sensitive, and that his perceptions were

> not what the average person would perceive. He sees it differently. . . He was hypersensitive to things to begin with and then his perception, he'll perceive something more negative or attacking than most would. And then react strongly to it. As an example of how he, how he saw things differently. . . he was sitting out, sitting out in the waiting room answering all these questionnaires and we're in the other room talking with the doctor. And she put her head out the window and said, 'Are you done yet?' and that was a major shutdown because he thought he was being scolded for, for taking too long or something. For taking too long, and he, that whole, I remember that whole evening he was in a horrible mood.

In elementary school, he missed school due to asthma, and this was a chronic condition for him. His parents indicated that he "did worse with teachers who had strict rigid rules and expectations, and if you did not meet them, there was no flexibility and they just hammered you and yelled at you and punished you." It is clear from the above account that school was a place or space where Jasper's parents felt that there was little positive regard for their child. As the word hammered would indicate, there was a sense of consistent and unrelenting pressure that was placed on top of their son by teachers who were in a position of power over their child in both a figurative and real sense. They described him as "shy," having "depression," "anxiety," "school phobia" and as "being disconnected." They indicated that within the middle school years, he began to be seen by a psychiatrist who diagnosed him (according to the school psychology report) as: "Social Phobia generalized (Principal), Dysthymic Disorder (Provisional), Attention Deficit Disorder (Provisional), Avoidant Personality Disorder (Provisional), and Schizoid Personality Features (Provisional)."

Outside of school, Jasper also appeared to experience difficulties with peers, as his stepfather indicated. He remembered Jasper telling him that a friend's father told him: "he thinks I am weird, and, and uh he doesn't want me around all the time." His stepfather was quick to add that this friend was also weird. What is interesting within this narrative is that his stepfather acknowledged that Jasper was weird, but he was also quick to defend his son, and indicate that the other boy was weird as well and to the same degree as his son. In this short narrative, there was the sense of acceptance of his son, and a defense against others who hurt his son. It was clear that there was a high level of parental support and caring, acceptance of their son.

Jasper began his life story recalling a birthday party at which all his family members were present (mom, dad, sister, grandparents, aunts, and uncles). When asked who was his in his immediate family, he indicated that it was his mother, his sister, and his stepfather, and that his father lived somewhere else. There was no other reference to his father, nor was a reference made by his mother and stepfather about his father. It was as if his father vanished after three years of age. He indicated a close relationship to his babysitter who watched him while his parents worked.

He described himself as "really, really, shy, and that caused a lot of trouble for me 'cause it got to the point where like some adults questioned if I was like handicapped or something." He indicated that during primary school, students secluded him by avoiding him. He, as did his parents indicated that "fourth and fifth grade were the worst grades I've ever been in." In responding to a query about why, he stated,

> just the fact that everyone had all their friends and stuff. I basically had no one. And like the only kids I could relate to were the special ed kids but that would mean other kids would seclude me more.

Within Jasper's account, he indicated a desire to be connected with and develop friendships and connections with others, but instead of finding acceptance, he was rejected, and according to his perception, he could only be friends with special education students, and this would only further his being ostracized.

Jasper perceived school as becoming more difficult in middle school, in part because he took part in a school sanctioned evaluation program involving brain waves. It was noted within a psychological report that Jasper was considered not to be a possible

candidate within the school neurofeedback program, due to his average intelligence. Jasper noted that:

> they tested me and they tested a whole bunch of other kids, and I got the highest score and they didn't understand why because I'm not doin' my work and I just. . . But I was definitely capable so that made it worse for me. Because now they, they were like. 'We don't understand what's wrong with him. He's just lazy.' And, I just don't know. I just didn't want to do it anymore. I'm just gonna stand here and say I'm lazy, I can't do it, then I'm not gonna do it.

He also indicated that the students tormented him, and that he became ill thinking about going to school, and began to have panic attacks. During middle school, he attempted suicide by "eating a bunch of pills out of the cabinet," and explained that he did this because he "had no friends, no future." Jasper articulated the feeling of insignificance (death) that each of the participants discussed, and the pain that insignificances causes, as well as the harm one is willing to do oneself it order to eradicate the pain. As he entered high school, he continued to report difficulties with establishing friendships. He recalled being kicked under the table in the knees and that it made it difficult to walk, and that his knees would bleed. In tenth grade, he reported that he stopped coming to school, and that he worked with a tutor.

Jasper seemed to construct himself through a deficit model of the self, in which he used negative particular terms to describe himself. The one negative term he rejected was lazy and he rejected this strongly, by insisting that he would not complete school work, if a teacher thought of him as lazy. His life within and outside of school appeared to be

filled with a tremendous tension: both the terror of others, and the desire to be close to others.

Beyond the construction of self, the conflict between school and family appeared as a prevalent theme within both his parent's and Jasper's interviews. I will analyze this conflict within the next section. What was interesting to note was that Jasper's cumulative school record had no written teacher comments, nor report cards for each grade, only a final high school report card and a transcript. The only other documents in his cumulative file were a high school report of attendance and a psychological report that was completed during his tenth grade year.

His parents recalled his experience at school as,

> we were always talking about current work and back work. I mean his whole life has been well, Yea, but what about the back work? What about the back work? But in his mind it's like 'I can't even think about the back work 'cause I got the current work.' And he would lose things.

This theme of lack of completion of work within school was the central conflict with teachers, which led to a turning point with the parents' relationship with the school from a passive relationship to a situation where they became advocates for their son.

In elementary school, they recalled that they stopped attending parent conferences since it was always the same. Jasper did not complete his work and owed this assignment and that assignment, that homework would take two hours, and then there was the need to complete back work. His parents' feelings were that

> we are doing everything we possibly can, and I don't know if we said it or not but in my mind it was, what are you gonna do differently to accommodate this kid who doesn't fit the mold that you're doing?

The grammatical modification of "I don't know if we said it," would indicate that this statement was most likely not said at the time, but was added after the event. What is clear were the parents' feelings of frustration that the teachers were not providing any additional assistance, and as a result, the work was piling up.

The parents also expressed frustration around whose responsibility it was to teach the content. They indicated that work was expected to be completed at home, and that neither of the parents felt qualified to teach their son. In middle school, they indicated that they were still meeting with teachers and discussing ideas on how to organize Jasper. They also indicated that during middle school, he started to have panic attacks in school, and they would need to pick him up from school. The school's advice to the parents was just to get him to school. His parents recalled one such time:

> I remember there were days and it started in middle school. Uh, literally, I, he's dragging on my ankle. And I'm saying 'You're going- you've got to go.' There was that one day we literally dragged him outta the house, put him in the car and took him to school. It was awful. Yea, it was kinda, I think like a light bulb moment for us. It was like, 'What are we doing?' We were torturing him. The thing that let us off the hook psychologically as parents was when we went to this doctor, psychiatrist and he told us, 'Stop torturing yourselves over this. . . Encourage him to go but don't get to the point where you are dragging him or screaming or yelling.'

This was the turning point as they viewed their son as having a "legitimate medical issue that affected his quality of life, rather than just school." Their acceptance of Jasper's medical issue and insight into their son resulted in their desiring the school personnel to use the psychiatrist's expertise to "help their child."

The parents referred their child to the Committee on Special Education for additional support, but the committee concluded that he did not qualify for special education services as neither having an emotional disturbance or a learning disability. At this point, his dad indicated that

> we started pounding, 'Well whatta are you gonna do for him? What more can you do for him? You won't qualify him for this. You got the 504. That's obviously not enough. If we all agree, what can we do? What can we do?' and there's really nothing in place.

His step-father also attacked the practice of punishing Jasper for not completing work.

> Look you're not keeping our kid after school unless he can do his work. I mean this is not a punishment thing and we should be trying to help him do his work. If you wanna keep him after to get him caught up, fine, keep him after. Have a teacher there to help him and we'll be glad to have him stay after.

The parents had switched their roles from being passive and supporting the school to directly challenging the school.

As this was happening, Jasper stopped attending school. Jasper learned of the alternative high school through a friend and requested to go. His home school district denied his request stating that, "it is a school for bad kids, it is a dumping ground, it costs too much money, and they have no slots to send him to the alternative high school." His

father emailed the assistant superintendent, and the concerns changed: they could not send him due to his attendance. His father argued that if he was in a better environment, that he would be happy to go, and a decision was made to send Jasper.

Jasper indicated during his second interview that “he hates violence.” When asked what violence was, he stated: “yelling and screaming.” Within his psychological report, a teacher report was included in which the credit for the work was given to the teacher, and there was figurative yelling in the written description;

> Jasper was EXTREMELY disorganized. He does adequately on tests and quizzes. He has not completed homework so far this year and his average shows that with a 64. The only reason it was even that high is that I spent a FULL period with him just sorting his backpack by subject and putting them in separate folders. For one week, I asked him to bring the ringed binder he said he had at home for Global, but he never did so I GAVE him one and MADE his notebook so the 60% on his notebook was the ONLY reason his average is what it is.

It is interesting that a district that has such a scant amount of information within a student cumulative folder permits figurative yelling in a psychological report, and if permitted on paper, it clearly raises the question of what occurred between students and teachers each day. Perhaps some part of Jasper’s anxiety within school was based on what he assessed as violent: yelling. It is also interesting to note that what Jasper did well was demonstrate that he learned the material by doing adequately on tests and quizzes. It stands to reason that despite the teacher’s need for notebooks and homework to be completed, Jasper could learn the information within his classroom without these aids. The word adequate

would indicate that he met expectations with regard to learning the material, as that would be the intent of the tests and quizzes.

Both Jasper and his parents indicated that his enrollment within the alternative high school was a turning point. As his father indicated; “it is the beginning of the good story.” His parents indicated that the flexible deadlines, the ability to leave the classroom to get air, or go outside, and the notion that Jasper felt safe, were the keys to his success. Jasper indicated that the small size of the alternative high school, and that there were only five teachers, made him feel more in control. He also noted that both peers and teachers at the alternative high school “accept you.”

What stood out about this case was clearly that his parents saw the problem:

> Yeah, if the kid fits the system, it worked out well for everyone. If the kid didn’t fit the system, it didn’t work out well for the kid and I think it sets up conflict between the teachers, parents, and school.

This case would suggest that the school will use its power to punish and coerce a student, especially a student that as Jasper stated, they believed was lazy. It was only after the parents had another expert outside of school, a child psychiatrist, that they believed they could challenge the school. Without this knowledge and sense of power to fight the school, I am left to wonder if Jasper would been “pushed out,” since he was constructed as being lazy. The school seemed to be able to do so little for a student with a diagnosed mental illness, and the question remains why?

Conclusion

In this chapter, I outlined and defined the concept of self, and from this I focused on the I self or the theory of self. After I reviewed the scientific literature pertaining to

two systems of the self, motivation, the developmental process of constructing the self, and the act of destroying the self, I grounded my critical discourse analysis within this research, and used this approach with three different case studies, which demonstrated the uniqueness of each case as well as the similarities. Within the context of school, social rejection by peers and teachers led to disengagement.

The context of the interviews and my role as principal led to presentations of the self that focused primarily on the self within school, and on how this self interacted with the self within the home, so it was difficult to analyze the multiple presentations of the self. What was a particular challenge for me was that each of the students within the case studies had been enrolled at the alternative high school for at least for two school years; thus during the analysis and writing of the chapter, I was aware of other stories and presentations of self within school. I did not include any other presentations of self, as the participants agreed to the study based on the interviews and the review of the records and they did not provide consent for me to use my observations from the previous two years.

Chapter 6

Reflections

Introduction

When I was a boy, my family traveled to New York City. As we visited the city, I was fascinated by an exhibit in which a Tibetan monk was working on a sand design. The tedious and slow tapping out of the sand which resulted in the intricacies of the design captured my imagination. As we left, my mother told me that after he completed the design, he would blow away his work, and my fascination turned to bemusement. How could a person work so arduously at a task, and then blow it away?

Since this question sprang forth, it has stayed within me seeking an answer. The answer has come to me in the most unusual manner. As I composed this last chapter of this dissertation, I understand that the mental and physical energy required to complete the task coupled with what I have learned from the completion of the task has primacy over the product. I can now understand, and say, much the same as the monk, that my work is completed and if it were to blow away, it does not matter, for the voices of the students and their truths live within me. I have finished what I had set out to do, and in the process, I have learned how to "represent, embody, and articulate a message, a view, an attitude, philosophy or opinion to, as well as for the public" (Said, 1994, p.11).

The major goals of this dissertation were to have students' lived experiences change the foreground and horizons of scientific research as it pertained to students who were considered to be likely to leave high school without graduating; and to have student voices inform and enrich theory pertaining to this discourse and the scientific body of knowledge which has historically focused on them without including their voices within

the discourse. Another goal was to mark that this particular program existed within a particular time in history. These goals have been accomplished, and within this chapter I will review the major findings of this dissertation, the weaknesses of the dissertation, and discuss the implications for schools and students. However, prior to this, I will explore the concept of nihilism, and its implication for my ontological position. My position with regard to nihilism provides me with the ability to aspire to what Said stated, which is: "the hardest aspect of being an intellectual is to represent what you profess through your work and interventions, without hardening into an institution or a kind of automaton acting at the behest of a system or method" (1994, p. 121). My work both as a doctoral student, and a practitioner provided me with a space to live within two worlds, and one of the unique aspects of my dissertation is that it spans both worlds. The findings of this dissertation are a mix of theoretical knowledge, lived experiences, and the space in between. As such, I am unable to harden into a system or method, and instead have come to live within a space of nihilism.

Nihilism

> Nihilism is the conviction that life is absurd, in the light of the highest values already discovered; it includes the view that we have not yet the smallest right to assume the existence of the transcendental objects or things in themselves, which would be either divine or morality incarnate. (Nietzsche, 1906/2006, p. 5)

Accepting that life is absurd, along with the Heidegger's insight that: "a boundary is not that at which something stops but, as the Greeks recognized, the boundary is that from which something begins its presencing" (2001, p. 152). As humans, we build buffers against this boundary. These buffers include concepts of: divinity, humans as the creators

of meaning, scientific “truths,” popular culture, drugs, alcohol, entertainment, and the list goes on. What this variety of concepts and ideas allows us to do is to avoid the boundary at which nothingness is felt: we are deeply afraid of being, and thus we focus on becoming, or distract ourselves with concepts and ideas to explain away the feeling of nothingness. We also seek others to avoid this concept of nothingness. As we are validated through our relationships with others, we can stave off the knowing that all we have, hold dear, and believe are all distractions from being, and in being, one comes to cross the boundary into nothingness. Within the undefined space of nothingness, can one understand that life is absurd, and that we fill our lives with as much noise as needed to avoid coming close to the boundary of nothingness, and the acceptance of nothing. The space of nothingness allows for one to think, as Heidegger (2004) noted: “we can learn thinking only if we radically unlearn what thinking has been traditionally. To do that, we must at the same time come to know it” (p. 8).

Within Dewey’s definition of reflective thinking, we find a radically different way of thinking.

> Reflective thinking is always more or less troublesome because it involves overcoming the inertia that inclines one to accept suggestions at their face value; it involves a willingness to endure a condition of mental unrest and disturbance. Reflective thinking in short means judgment suspended during further inquiry and suspension is likely to painful. (Dewey, 2005, p. 12)

Judgment suspended is the willingness to cross over into the space of nothing, and the pain experienced is the release of one’s noise, not just for the matter at hand, but for all judgment. The obvious weakness of this position is that if one were to suspend all beliefs,

all of the time, then why take any action at all, or think anything? Within this space, it is the acceptance that life and the beliefs we build are arbitrary, contextually-bound and absurd. Within the space of nothingness, one must be willing to recognize both the absurdity of her ideas, as well as the absurdity of others' ideas.

Questions Proposed and Answered

The questions which framed this dissertation were a) How and in what ways did participants negotiate and construct meaning about self, others, and the world?; b) How did these constructions and the meaning making process situate the participants within and outside of school, and what implications does this students' negotiation process have for school?; and c) What in the context of an alternative high school provided the context for students to renegotiate their understanding of self, others, and the world? The dissertation argued for a theory of a struggle for significance in which participants' experienced multiple rejections. These rejections were not single events, but instead were a continuous part of their life experiences throughout their negotiation of self, through the relationship to self, others, and the world. This ongoing negotiation resulted in a feeling of insignificance, which caused a great deal of pain, and led to participants' attempting to eradicate the pain through drugs, withdrawal, suicide attempts, and the rejection of others. It also facilitated the development of a life (significant) versuts death (insignificant) struggle for these participants which led to an increasingly violent response to others or to withdrawal and this led to the outcome which they feared the most: rejection. The alternative high school provided a space in which the life and death struggle could be lessened, as the significance shifted from ability and social capital (special talents, skills) to an a acceptance of being. The change in the negotiation from a

life and death struggle to a negotiation of acceptance is a critical thirdspace of hope in which participants were able to renegotiate self, the world, and others.

The study also challenged attachment theory, which focuses on the mother's relationship to the child, by indicting within a sample, that the father relationship to his child has a significant influence. The use of critical discourse analysis within the study added to the growing body of research within this area.

Limitations of the Study

As indicated within this dissertation, I had privileged access, as each participant was or had been enrolled within the school where I was principal at the time of the study. As principal, I had built and established a trusting relationship with the students and parents. This trust provided a safe context for the disclosure of lived experiences that were salient to the participants' lives.

While this privileged relationship opened and may have created a context of safety for students, it also limited the scope and nature of the dissertation, since teachers and other professionals related to the program were not included in the dissertation. The teachers were not able to participate within the study as, prior to the onset of the study, by the nature of my position as principal, I had a supervisory relationship with the teachers. This relationship might have prevented full disclosure by the teachers about themselves, the students, the program or me.

An additional area of concern was the limited participation of the school personnel from the students' home school districts. Again, this exclusion was one that was based on my prior relationship and professional role with other district personnel. School districts purchase services from a BOCES; thus it would be problematic at best to

suggest that a researcher could seek answers to meaningful questions, without the possibility of alienating or offending one's customer. Again my professional roles and responsibilities were in conflict with my role as a novice researcher.

There is a choice to be made between the study one desires and the study one could complete within real world constraints. The extension of this study would be to complete an ethnographic study for a two-year period, in which the researcher could participate within multiple schools, the alternative high school, and the outside-of-school spaces in which students live. Within such a study, a much more in-depth understanding of participants' lived experiences could have been developed.

The final weakness is also a realization that is there is a large divide between the theoretical understanding of class, race, and gender, and the lived experiences of these concepts for the participants within this study. These abstract concepts were expressed in terms of not having material items, such as popular clothing, cars, gaming systems, or broad concepts such as "we didn't have a lot of money," or "there were financial difficulties." The participants had not yet developed or expressed a global understanding of how these constructs positioned them within society. This may be due in large part to the notion that public schools within America do not focus on developing a critical consciousness.

Implications for Schools

Schools are social institutions in which attendance is compulsory for children and youth within America. Schools, and in particular public schools, are government agencies that provide a knowledge base for all students. Within the current context of schooling, our national discourse has been focused on academic rigor, and standards and assessment.

Within this study, the participants did not focus on their difficulty with learning classroom content; instead they focused on their social relationships to and with others, which suggests that what is salient to students and their success within school is not congruent with that of adults. This suggests that educators, in the operation of school and in the name of safety and best practice, tend not to recognize that students are first social beings, and that what is salient to students remains hidden from school officials by our "old-accustomed preconceptions which are so stubborn because they have their own truth" (Heidegger, 2004, p. 152). This hidden knowledge and/or ignorance on the school's part could be conceived as a form of unconsciousness, and as de Certeau noted: "between two forms of unconsciousness: one that refuses to see the damages and one that avoids the responsibility of reconstruction, one that denies the problem and one that refuses to seek any solution- we must look at the issues of lucidity and action" (de Certeau, 2001, p. 4). We continue to refuse to acknowledge the damage we inflict by the single mindedness that is pervasive within schools. As Foucault noted: "power produces, it produces a reality, it produces domains of objects, and rituals of truth" (1997, p. 194). What school produces with its rituals of truth is to continue the perpetuation of social rejection and alienation. The mark, which is written on the backs of the students, is that of social rejection. The participants within this study provided detailed accounts of their rejections, the consequences, and their longing and striving to erase these marks, by being socially accepted.

de Certeau noted that "we are spectators who refuse to be participants" (2001, p. 18). How long will you choose to be a spectator who refuses to participate?

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